

THE LIST

PROLOGUE

SUNDAY MORNING

8.30 a.m.

The newest security guard, Melvin Jones, stopped still on his way across the first floor of Langley & Co's smart London office, his thermos flask of tea crashing to the floor.

A minute ago, Melvin had been enjoying a crafty smoke on the fire-escape, before his shift started properly. Weekend working was a perk; the office was always empty, apart from the rare eager beaver cross-eyed at their computer, and no one cared if Melvin took the odd break, or watched the footie on his phone: honestly, Sundays were cushy.

Except this morning.

'Oh, sweet Jesus.' Melvin's skin turned clammy as he stared into the small glass box of a private office, one of a few off the main open-plan floor. 'What the hell—'

This morning was going to be very different...

Despite his new job, Melvin had no idea that the apparent best of the literary world had assembled in London's Savoy Hotel last night for the Book Awards. Yesterday evening, Melvin had been happily oblivious, having a kickabout with his young sons beneath the floodlights in their local park.

But the body that slumped now from the back of a door in Langley & Co's flashy London office? That was one hundred per cent right there in front of Melvin. Or rather, it had been real *once*; a living, breathing, loving, fighting human.

Now, though, all life was very obviously extinguished - by its own hand, Melvin would guess, given the nature of the death.

As Melvin swallowed, dry-mouthed, and reached for his walkie-talkie, his eyes never moving from the gruesome sight before him, he knew that this body was stone-cold.

And he knew who the body was: someone he recognised only too well.

CHAPTER 1

SAVANNAH: SATURDAY NIGHT

The Langley & Co. table was turning out to be *the* table at tonight's National Book Awards ceremony. Savannah Wexford-Langley – Savvi to her closest friends, but never her enemies – was quite sure of that. Holding out her glass for yet more bubbly, she turned her hand carefully, so the brilliant diamond on her ring finger winked beneath the chandelier's crystals.

Thank you, Tiffany! And *thank you* to Savannah's to-die-for fiancé, Dex, Publishing Director at her family's firm, Langley & Co. In his Hugo Boss tux, Dex had really surpassed himself tonight; looking so foxy with his salt-and-pepper hair slicked back, Savannah could have eaten him all up. If she had any appetite left; Mounjaro being the one pharmaceutical the doctors had allowed her since rehab. As a wise woman once said, you can never be too rich or too thin.

Tonight, the great ballroom of London's grandest hotel was almost as shimmering as Savannah's own dress as, around her, Champagne flowed in a room heaving with the literary world's biggest names. Yes, anyone who was anyone in publishing was here tonight: the great, the good – and the very, *very* bad. And Savannah Langley was feeling kind of bad herself, in the most excellent way; currently relieved the interminable prize-giving had paused for a while before the final award was announced: Book of the Year.

True, she'd been looking forward to hanging out with big brother Seb – but Leo di Caprio had offered him a last-minute lift on his private jet to a St Tropez pool party, so Savannah was the only Langley here, representing her family's publishing dynasty as their Comms Director. And that was fine by Savannah – lapping up the attention like a pedigree cat.

‘No dessert for me, honey.’ She wrinkled her expensive snub nose at the cute waiter, who was wafting something hideously tasty like trifle in front of her.

‘I’ll have yours.’ Jackson Rayne, Dex’s number one author, locked eyes with Savannah, his steely gaze as piercing as her own manicured nails.

‘Be my guest.’ It was strange, the mystery that shrouded Rayne’s first career made him feel dangerous in an exciting way. Savannah imagined him staggering off the battlefield; cradling a dying colleague, saving another. She thought of the muscly author killing men in any of the world’s current wars – far too many, these days – and a thrill shot through her.

But as Savannah eyed the ex-soldier, she was shocked by a warm hand sliding between her thighs.

‘Not hungry?’ Dex kissed her creamy neck. ‘Or just not for food?’

Was her fiancé guarding his territory? He was never usually jealous – quite the opposite, in fact; he’d spent the last year propelling her into an open relationship; one she’d felt ambivalent about initially, and now hated.

She was working hard on Dex giving it all up for her.

‘Always hungry for you, baby.’ Savannah nibbled Dex’s earlobe, before unfolding her elegant frame from the chair. ‘See you in a sec.’ Now the boring ceremony was nearly done, let the afterparties begin. Savannah was born to have a good time...

In the powder room, she tried to focus on herself, and not her growing paranoia about Dex’s other ‘fancies’. She checked her glossy updo, slicked Chanel’s Rouge Allure over her almost-natural pout and admired the sparkle in her green eyes, carefully ringed with glittery kohl.

‘Too kind,’ Savannah said, dropping a twenty-pound note in the tip bowl with a flick of a ruby-encircled wrist. The attendant’s dull eyes

reflected Savannah's silver sheath dress; the way it left nothing to the imagination, all set off by a recent Seychelles tan.

'Hi, Savannah.' A young woman had appeared silently behind her.

'God, you made me jump.' Savannah tensed as their eyes met in the mirror. The girl's name escaped her – but she recognised her as Dex's drippy assistant; they'd sat opposite each other all night. 'Viola, is it?'

'Violet. Sorry to bother you, but – I just wanted to ask...' The girl stopped, her deep-set eyes troubled.

'What?' To Savannah's horror, Violet looked like she was going to cry.

'It's just...' The girl – a funny little thing with dull, badly-cut hair and a northern accent – hesitated. 'I don't know who else to—'

But before she could finish, Orion's publishing director trotted in – ridiculously full of herself, Savannah thought absently, for someone wearing such a cheap high-street dress.

'Darling, so well deserved, the romantasy award.' Savannah suppressed a smirk as they air-kissed. All romantasy editors were perverts in her opinion: Sex with a unicorn? No thanks. When she remembered the girl and looked around for her, she'd gone. No loss to Savannah.

But by the time she reached her table, Savannah's mood had dimmed. She'd had to pass her bastard ex-husband Simon Wexford; pawing a female colleague, who looked suspiciously like a younger Savannah. His awful antics had pushed Savannah into far-flung rehab last year and now Simon's sickly PDA reminded Savannah that the whole of Langley & Co. was on tenterhooks right now, fearful about any whisper of scandal.

'We cannot afford to lose another big author,' the CEO and Savannah's half sister, Ruth Langley, warned key staff recently. She'd made it crystal clear to Dex that Jackson Rayne was Langley's new golden goose, and if any other publisher got near Rayne, there'd be trouble. Especially since Richard

Osman's mega-sales at Penguin, and the recent Elizabeth du Toit affair at Langley. They couldn't lose another bestseller.

Dex didn't seem worried, though. 'All under control. And all work and no play makes me a dull boy,' he'd grinned through the hot tub's steam in the garden last weekend, his strong fingers on Savannah's naked thigh.

And honestly, Ruth was nothing if not paranoid herself, Savannah realised, since the horrible incident in her house last year. Rarely seen in public these days, recently, her big sister preferred to pull strings from her new Chelsea Harbour apartment, or her private office at Langley & Co. *Almost as if she's protecting herself from something else sinister*, Savannah thought. And she felt sorry for Ruth, who was so work obsessed, and so personally guarded, she never allowed herself love – but still, at the end of the day, Ruth was a good egg really.

God, now she was even depressing herself. Savannah tapped her fiancé's arm. 'Ready to party, darling?'

'I'll give it a go, angel.' Dex stifled a yawn. 'Lived it up too much in Beverly Hills.' Hollywood was knocking at Rayne's door, and Dex and his author only flew back this morning, on the LA red eye. 'The flight was so bloody turbulent, I barely slept.'

'Nothing like adrenaline to keep you going,' Jackson Rayne said loftily.

Savannah winked at her sweet assistant Ishan, sitting opposite her. He'd been chatting to Violet all evening, the girl who just approached her in the ladies' – and who, to Savannah's relief, now averted her eyes.

Dex had invited Violet as a reward for hard work, so Savannah invited Ishan to keep Violet company and also, if she was honest, so their table didn't look so very white. Langley had to do better in the diversity arena; something Savannah's twin Bella was trying to impress on the whole board. Terribly woke, darling Bella, since marrying her eco-warrior husband.

Dex was texting someone now, and his grin made Savannah's stomach lurch. She sat up straighter, sneaking another glance at Jackson Rayne.

Not very tall, maybe, and not her usual type; not privately or even university-educated. But very handsome, his muscled arms bulging beneath his tux; no doubt tattooed with military and blood-brothers type stuff. Yes, Rayne was definitely a rough diamond in the Langley crown.

'Who'd have thought big ol' Smoke Silva would do so well for you, eh?' Dex toasted him. 'A one-eyed Alaskan marine-turned-cop, giving Jack Reacher a run for his money. And wait 'til we unleash your memoir on the world!'

'A memoir?' Clinking Jackson's glass, Savannah angled herself to let her cleavage spill over her bodice. 'How exciting. I bet you've got tales to tell, darling!'

Dex had filled her in on Rayne's passion project: a memoir detailing his terrible poverty-stricken childhood on Britain's east coast. There'd never been enough food, nor enough room in their two-up, two-down; mum dead too young, and a violent dad. Rayne joined the army at sixteen, was poached by the elite military services and had seen battle and bloodshed by eighteen. But today, Rayne has turned his back on death – or real death, at least – to write about it; next step, with Dex's guidance, working out how to use his skills to help young men's mental health.

'Wait 'til you read it.' Jackson held eye contact with her; powerful, like his novels' protagonist. 'If Langley wins the bidding war!' He winked at Dex.

No wonder Ruth's so desperate to keep Jackson sweet, Savannah thought, when mousey Violet choked on her trifle.

'Here you go.' Jackson offered the young woman his glass, as Harlen Coben passed their table and blew Savannah a kiss.

Beaming, Savannah kissed the air back, thrilled to be the centre of attention again, and keen to keep it that way. 'Nightcaps at Langley's when this finishes?'

But Dex just yawned again. 'Sorry, angel!' He looked a bit sheepish.

'It's fine.' Trying to smile, she made a mental note to tell her Botox injector to not go so hard, next time. 'But I've got the world's most expensive tequila in my office, dying to be slammed...' And she'd always wanted to shag Dex on her desk. 'Fancy it, Jackson?' she asked as the background music stopped.

The two presenters bounced onto the stage; one as circular as a billiard ball, the other lanky; a rubbish comedy duo who'd looked awkward all night, especially when making terrible jokes about books.

'So, my lords, ladies and publishing twats,' the taller, uglier one began. 'It's nearly time for you to be leave, completely pissed, and slag all your peers off -'

Nervous laughter rippled through the audience.

'Yep, it's the big moment, tonight's award for Book of the Year! As they say, always save the best to last -'

'Which is why you went first,' his small, round partner interrupted. 'In fact, why you always go first -'

'All tonight's results were independently verified,' the tall one ignored him. 'Unlike your book jacket quotes, people. "*Brilliant*", by your mum.'

'Dear God,' muttered Dex, still studying his phone. 'Get on with it.'

'So, without further ado, the nominees for Most Useless People in Publishing ...' the taller, uglier one started - and then stopped in confusion, 'Sorry, I thought this was for Book of the Year -'

‘My dear friend’s not got his contacts in.’ The smaller, rounder presenter took over the autocue. ‘So, for the Book of the Year, the nominees are...’ he hissed offstage, ‘Hurry up and put the names up, eh?’

‘Wow.’ Savannah’s assistant Ishan raised his eyebrows. ‘Cock up.’

‘Indeed.’ Why had they hired such useless has-beens, Savannah was wondering, when a woman’s terrible sobs came over the speaker-system.

‘Oh my gosh!’ Violet jumped a foot in the air, spilling her wine.

As Dex handed over his napkin, the crowd fell silent; the eerie noise echoing off the walls, and Savannah shivered.

All eyes swivelled to the stage, as big bold words looped onto the screen behind the two presenters:

THE LIST BEGINS: (SKULL 🦴)

NOMINEES FOR TONIGHT’S SPECIAL AWARD:

1. Langley & Co.’s Dex Harris.

‘Dexy!’ Savannah clapped her hands. ‘I didn’t know you were up for an award!’

Dex frowned. ‘I’m not up for anything. Definitely not the best Book.’

The writing continued to loop across the screen as the sobbing faded and now a strange little girl’s voice whispered over the speakers: ‘Who’s Next?’

Across the table, Jackson Rayne’s craggy face was baffled, and scrawny little Violet was gazing at Dex. What *is* that look on her face, Savannah wondered? A mix of bewilderment and... *Oh*, of course. The poor thing was lovestruck. That’s what she was going to confess in the ladies’

But before Savannah could react, something heavy dropped from the ceiling.

With a gasp, the whole crowd looked upwards, and people started to scream. Horrified, Savannah realised this might not be a planned part of the event after all. She stared at the thing now swinging above their heads.

A body, blood dripping down the front of its white dress shirt; a body, hanging from the end of rope...

CHAPTER 2

CLARA: SATURDAY NIGHT

Late on Saturday, twenty-four-year-old Clara Voss woke on her mum's old sofa to the sound of screaming.

For a few frantic seconds, Clara thought it *was* her mum, shrieking like she did when her brother Adam got bitten by next door's Pitbull. Except, no – Clara remembered as she began to wake properly – her mum was far from London right now, thank God.

But the terrifying noise went on and on, until all the tiny hairs on Clara's neck were on end; until she groggily groped for the remote control. Full of the head cold that knocked her out tonight, she must have nodded off in front of the National Book Awards on TV, and the show had been followed by some kind of slasher flick...

Only it wasn't a horror film at all, Clara realised, blinking at the screen: it was a live stream, still coming from the ceremony in London's Savoy Hotel ballroom. Clara could even see some of her colleagues from the publishing house, Langley & Co., right there on the small screen, their table groaning with empty wine bottles, under a huge chandelier.

As Clara watched, her Comms Director, the gorgeous Savannah Wexford-Langley (*Savvi by name, Savvi by nature, darling!*) suddenly turned to the camera and stared straight out towards Clara. *Oh my God*, Clara thought. *The woman looks completely terrified.*

Reflexively, Clara glanced behind her: what on earth was Savannah gazing at, her scarlet lips shaped in a perfect *O* of horror? But the camera was already moving on, and now Clara's friend Violet was also in shot, dwarfed by bestselling crime author Jackson Rayne; mousey little Violet looking as out of place as Clara would feel at such a flashy event. Probably terrified by Rayne, who's super famous, and both handsome and intense,

but also out of place for an ex-marine, in his black tie and starched white shirt.

What was stranger was the way the whole Langley table were still staring into space. Clara gaped at the telly, desperate to know what they could see and she couldn't; wondering what the hell was going on until, amid the chaos, she watched the hot-shot Langley publishing director Dex Harris stand, and start shouting at someone not visible from Clara's sofa.

What was clear from her living-room was the writing on the screen behind Dex: a list of names, looping across the huge projector screen on the stage. Then the camera panned again, just catching the edge of a large object that had just dropped from the ceiling.

It was on a rope, and... was it a *hanging body*?

'Oh no!' Clara half-stood in shock – and then her TV screen went black.

*

Rooted in horror, Clara texted her friend Violet.

'What the hell's going on, there?'

After the black screen, a silly show about naked dating came on. Clara turned it off and texted Violet again.

'Is someone dead?!'

But Violet still didn't answer.

Heart still thumping, Clara pulled the family iPad off the coffee table; perhaps there'd be some news about the awards online. She was scrolling frantically when her phone rang, the number withheld.

She snatched it up. 'Hello?'

'Clara Voss?' The voice was strange; robotic sounding, probably male.

‘Yes?’ A new flash of terror travelled up Clara’s spine as the voice paused; its laboured breathing all that was audible down the line.

‘Who is this?’ she demanded, more bravely than she felt.

‘This is a warning,’ the electronic voice was cold. ‘Oh, and - Clara?’ Heavy breathing, like Darth Vader. ‘This is just the start. You want to watch out. Before it’s too late...’

Before she could ask what on earth they meant, the line went dead – just as the living room door swung open, a tall figure looming there in the shadows, and Clara let out a yelp of fear.

*

In her terror, Clara stood too fast, the iPad crashing onto her bare foot. ‘Oh my God.’

‘Did you think I was a ghost?’ Her little brother Adam burst into laughter, walking towards her, arms extended. ‘Woo-ooo...’

‘Hilarious. What I think is that I’ve broken my toe,’ Clara hopped round in pain. ‘Don’t creep up on people like that, you idiot.’

Of course, Adam wasn’t little anymore; twenty-one and six foot tall and, since finishing a year at college in the States, drifting in a way Clara worried about. Recently, he’d started airing all sorts of weird and not wonderful views about women, and their place in the world. Then, to Clara’s huge surprise, he’d dropped out of his degree, which he’d been acing. He’d given up fiddling with computers – his first love – turning from IT geek into a weightlifter, and qualifying as a personal trainer. At the moment, he was obsessed with muscle mass, protein shakes and sculpting his beard, but he also enjoyed winding his sister up about ‘femi-nazis’.

‘Us blokes are being sidelined,’ he’d stated over a recent Sunday roast at home. ‘Even though it’s men who go out to war, fight, lose our lives,

defend the nations,' he'd insisted, shovelling potatoes in. 'We protect the women and kids, and we get nothing but a hard time from you lot.'

'But if women were in charge,' Clara said drily, 'there wouldn't be any wars. Pass the gravy, please.'

'Men should be in charge, though. Like, obviously,' Adam had said, defiance in his eyes, and Clara nearly choked on her carrots.

'He's just finding his way, aren't you, Ad?' Their mum had heaped more chicken onto Adam's plate. Her blue-eyed boy, Clara was well aware, could do no wrong. Especially since their dad had left them all high and dry.

So, Adam was the man of the house – and Clara had to put up with it, until she got her own place again.

Which, given Clara's promotion to full editor, along with the little sweetener her CEO, Ruth Langley, had slipped into her pay a few months ago for keeping quiet after the Elizabeth du Toit disaster, would be sooner rather than later. She found herself craving peace and quiet.

And if Adam was going to terrify her in the middle of the night, creeping round the flat like that, it couldn't come soon enough.

Though that wouldn't stop horrible phone calls like the one she'd just received. Clara had no idea who had made it or what it was about, but nor was she dying to find out...

CHAPTER 3

SAVANNAH: SATURDAY NIGHT

Under the flags of the Savoy Hotel, waiting for the doorman to hail their cab, Savannah suddenly felt like a small child.

‘Why was your name on the screen?’ Anxiously, she slipped her hand into Dex’s, as he texted with the other.

Dex shook his head. ‘No idea, angel.’

‘It was horrible.’ In the ballroom just now, Savannah had refused to look back at the gently swaying body, but her irritation flared now. ‘Why didn’t they get him down quicker, for God’s sake?’ She wished Dex would put his phone away.

‘It’s probably not that easy. Maybe I should have helped...’

Only as the crowd was herded out did panicked staff run over to the body – two young men wielding a stepladder, a third on a walkie-talkie.

‘It looked like it was too late, though.’ Ishan’s eyes were round behind his specs, and Violet let out a small sob.

‘Oh God.’ Shivering despite her fur jacket, Savannah clasped Dex’s arm in a way she wouldn’t, usually. ‘What a terrible sight.’

‘It wasn’t real.’ Jackson Rayne caught Savannah’s eye.

‘What wasn’t?’ Savannah frowned, which was about as hard as smiling had been earlier, given all the Botox.

‘That body.’ Rayne leaned against the wall and struck a match, holding it to the end of the cigar. ‘It’s a good attempt, but that body is a fake.’

Something about his confidence made Savannah stand up straighter. ‘Oh,’ she said slowly. ‘You think?’

‘I think.’

But as the cab pulled up, something Savannah couldn’t put her finger on was still bothering her.

As Jackson opened the car door, Ishan helped mousey Violet in first, to Savannah's further chagrin; beauty, wealth and age before drab little assistants, surely? And they weren't part of her game plan, but it seemed too late to stop them. The girl had been crying quietly since they'd left the ballroom, gentle Ishan comforting her. *Very tolerant*, Savannah thought wryly, as Dex helped her in, now. Catching his grimace, her heart sank; Dex was clearly getting one of his migraines.

Only Jackson Rayne remained unperturbed as he took the jump seat.

'I want to assure you, the appropriate authorities are on their way.' On the stage, the harassed event manager had offered a tense smile. 'We need you all to leave immediately, as calmly as possible.' She'd indicated the exits like an air hostess. 'And please don't post about this on your socials.'

'Good luck enforcing that,' Savannah had muttered, though she couldn't imagine posting about it herself. The whole thing was a terrible downer. She had to pull herself together, or the whole night would be as dead as the poor corpse. *Fake it till you make it* was a mantra her mum Lissa had drummed into Savannah and her twin Bella as children.

But still, the thing Savannah was trying to remember kept slipping through the cracks of her mind.

*

'Great night for Langley though, wasn't it?' Ishan smiled nervously as London slid by outside the cab windows: dark streets, bright lights.

'Fabulous. And what will make it even greater now is a tequila at the office.' Savannah shifted against Dex, her slinky silver dress riding up to reveal a shapely thigh. She was hyper aware of Jackson Rayne opposite her; shirt sleeves rolled up now, broad where Dex was lean and sinewy. 'Let's

not write off the night.' She nudged her fiancé, who was still texting. He didn't look up.

'Gotta say, I really wanna win something next year.' Rayne yawned widely, displaying gleaming white teeth. 'Or it's just a waste of energy.'

'You will, mate, don't you worry.' Dex managed to flash the writer a smile, which irritated Savannah more.

Rayne was so successful already, she thought. What did one little prize matter? But authors were a needy breed; horribly sensitive and ego-ridden, always banging on about themselves and their boring books. For all her publishing lineage, Savannah secretly detested reading – the odd *Sweet Valley High*, maybe, as a kid; *Black Beauty* as an audiobook, at a push. Dogs and horses had been far more her thing – replaced by boys, holidays and designer clothes as she grew up.

'Rayne's one of the few willing to put his money where his mouth is.' Dex had told Savannah recently; his idea being to use Rayne's macho brand to fight toxic masculinity. Honestly, it all just bored Savannah.

'They shouldn't let that kind of thing happen at an event,' a quiet little voice piped up. Violet: whom Savannah had almost forgotten was there.

'They need to stop men jumping to their death when we're having fun,' Savannah snapped.

'Angel!' A flicker of a frown crossed Dex's face, and Savannah understood she'd probably crossed a line.

She looked at her phone. Someone from Langley called Clara was posting on Insta about how worried she was about the Awards debacle -

'Who is Clara Voss?' Savannah had a vague recollection of someone involved when her sister Ruth's house burned down; when Ruth had nearly died. It had been deeply distressing, though Savannah had never been close

to her older sister. They hadn't grown up in the same house, and their mothers had been at war for a long time, which made sibling warmth hard.

'Clara? She's an editor, and my best friend.' Violet cheered up a bit. 'Langley's lucky to have her.'

'Yeah, I heard she's ace,' Ishan agreed.

'Really?' Honestly, Ish should know his place: sweet, useful for keeping Savannah's rampant expenses in check, and easy on the eye – if you liked Hugh Grant hair and a boyish vibe. But Savannah preferred older men - thought drippy Violet was probably dying to get off with him.

'I do feel a bit freaked out by that whole stunt,' Violet was saying.

Dear God, put a bloody sock in it. Who'd asked them to get in the cab anyway? But Violet smiled tentatively. 'Don't you feel worried?'

'Well -' Savannah tried to meet the smile without an eye-roll. Some people were just sensitive, she reminded herself – like her, but she hid it -

'Like I said, it's just a lame joke.' Jackson Rayne nodded at Violet.

'Yeah, let's not worry.' Savannah patted Dex's thigh, but he just looked in pain. Except - was he pretending? The fear crept in: if Dex left now, was it to meet whoever he'd been texting all night?

But it was too quiet in the cab to ask him.

Pull yourself together, Savannah imagined her mum saying. *Don't let a man ever even sniff your insecurity.*

And she wouldn't dwell on the fact that if Dex went home without her, she'd been abandoned yet again.

The therapy group in rehab had ramped up this fear of abandonment; stemming, no doubt, from being dumped at boarding-school aged eight along with Bella; waiting hopefully for either parent to arrive at weekends or half-terms, only to be informed yet again by Matron that 'no-one was coming today, poor pets.'

Truthfully, the memory of sitting waiting in those school windows; gazing out at the empty drive, never seemed to fade.

No, Savannah thought, sticking her chin in the air as the taxi rattled round a night-time Picadilly Circus: with or without Dex, she'd go into the office. Strong drink and distraction was needed after the terrible shock in the ballroom. Even if she wasn't meant to be drinking at all.

CHAPTER 4

CLARA: SATURDAY NIGHT

Adam sloped off to his room, laughing about Clara's outburst, leaving Clara reeling, and nursing a sore toe. Still confused about the evening's events, she startled as her phone rang again.

She forced herself to pick up, even though the number was withheld. If it was that weirdo again, she'd challenge him this time – or get Adam to talk to him, though that thought pained her deeply.

She didn't want to rely on any man to save her.

'Clara!' A woman, in a bar, maybe? Loud music, voices calling in the background, people laughing.

'Violet? Hang on...' Clara gave a loud sneeze. 'Sorry, I'm still feeling rough.'

'You sound terrible.' Not Violet at all, but Clara's mum, calling from the Canary Islands. 'I hope you're tucked up with a Lemsip, and not out on the town.' She sounded typically reproofing; ironic, given that someone near her was whooping loudly, and 'Club Tropicana' had just started playing.

'I'm on the sofa. You okay?' Right now, Clara didn't want to hear about her mum's last-minute holiday in Tenerife with the bloke she'd met only weeks ago, though at least it meant Clara had the flat mainly to herself. Since she'd come home, newly single and traumatised, she'd tried hard to understand her mum was just looking for a bit of fun after Clara's dad had turned out to be so unreliable; a fact neither Clara or Adam had really come to terms with yet.

And Adam was there, of course. But for some reason, Clara didn't feel reassured by that.

*

Clara's mum promised to have a 'Sex on the Beach for you' and hung up, leaving Clara's mind boggled at the thought. Picking up the blessed iPad again, she scrolled for news about the book awards.

Nothing yet about the body she was positive had just fallen from the ceiling. Some stuff about the various awards won, and a PR girl called Angel from Hodder had just tweeted a blurry photo of the bewildered presenters on stage: a supposed comedy duo from the 1990s:

'Gassed to see these two has-beens fing it right up!! LMAO 😊'.***

The iPad was running slow. Plugging it in, Clara started closing tabs: her mum's Facebook habit, her own Vinted one, the Netflix sign-in.

But the final tab came to life before she could close it: *'Armed for Action!'* and a video with the *Platoon* theme tune, showing grown men running around a muddy field, all wearing vests and camouflage, chasing each other, wrestling each other to the ground.

'Join our group now: no more being kicked to the kerb by dumb bitches!' barked the transatlantic voiceover. *'Learn how to combat fight, how to kill a man, and how to get as much pussy as you'll ever want!! Don't be a simp – no room for soy boys in our dojo!'*

Now, two thick-set grinning men stood shoulder to shoulder in front of a concrete gym, the caption announcing *'The Most Sick Dick of all Dojos, Romford, Essex'*; both in camouflage trousers and vest tops, their bulging muscles oiled, their weirdly slick chests completely hairless.

'Sign up now, and we promise to make all your dreams come true. No more rejection, ever! We swear to show you how to make the girls fall at your feet and pant, and what to do with them bitches if they don't! #looksmaxxing'

Women have gone too far in their ugly power. It's time to learn how to take them down with us – #MensRightsActivists in action #beckys #foids'

Clara's belly rolled at the horrible sexist language.

Below it, a stream of excited comments from men with tags like JockHard69, and ShowEmHow. And a comment from Adamski04:

'Muscle=Money, pussy don't date down 🤪 learn 2 control the femoids!

Was that *her* Adam? And what was a Becky, or a femoid? Derogatory words for women, she assumed.

Honestly, Clara was already worried about some of the conspiracy theories she'd heard her younger brother spout recently, but this was even worse. What on earth was Adam getting into?

Nothing good, by the looks of things.

But before she could question him, she heard the front door slam shut. He'd left – despite it being the middle of the night.

Where the hell was he going?

CHAPTER 5

SAVANNAH: SATURDAY NIGHT

As the taxi pulled up outside Langley & Co., the great stone liger prowled on the roof like a ferocious sentry, lit by floodlights positioned in a deep trench inside the gold-plated railings. The effect was spectacular.

Savannah's big sis Ruth had bribed a couple of local councillors on the QT to allow the Langley family to dig out the front wells, despite the building being listed and historic. Constructed over the bones of a medieval graveyard, nowadays it was glossy and modern, and Savannah felt a rush of pride that her own dad had created all this; that her family name was written across the building. She glanced at Jackson, who met her gaze boldly. She grinned: was he also impressed by her proximity to power?

'Sorry, angel.' Her fantasy was broken by Dex, squeezing her hand sadly. 'I'm good for nothing.'

'Baby!' Savannah's heart sank. 'Shall I come with you, then?'

'No, sweetheart, it's fine,' he was firm. 'Have a drink or three for me.'

'Okay.' But the little voice in Savannah's head asked again: why was Dex really leaving? 'Poor darling.' Trying to quieten her anxiety, she kissed him a slow goodbye, hoping he'd be jealous leaving her with Rayne. But now another voice in her head chimed in, *what might Jackson be up for?* He was definitely still looking at her. 'I'll tuck you in when I get home.'

'Can't wait. Jackson.' Dex shook his author's hand. 'I'm dying to read the memoir's first draft.'

'I've taken all your suggestions on board, mate.' Rayne pulled a wad from his pocket and offered Dex a fifty for the cab, which amazed Savannah. Authors rarely paid for anything in their editor's company. 'See you for golf on Thursday?'

‘Definitely.’ Dex declined the money, looking paler now. *Honestly*, Savannah thought as she slid to the taxi door, *being unhealthy is unsexy*. Still, it was better than the other possibility -

‘I can see you home, Dex,’ his little assistant said. ‘You look really poorly.’

‘I’ll be fine, love.’ Dex extended his weary smile to Violet, and the young woman gazed at him like a kicked puppy.

So, I was right! Savannah had warned Dex he was too nice to his staff. ‘It’s not good to blur boundaries,’ she’d snapped once, after hearing him praise a new editor called... *Aha!* So *that* was Clara; the penny dropped, now. ‘They get the wrong idea, then where’ll you be?’ she’d told him.

‘Like the boundary we totally blurred?’ Dex had pulled her into his arms.

‘Touchée, my darling!’ Savannah had giggled happily as he’d slid a hand under her skirt.

‘Have a nightcap on me.’ Jackson pressed a few fifties into Violet’s hand. ‘You guys work far too hard for our glory. Go and have a laugh.’

He’s such an alpha, thought Savannah, smiling demurely under her lash extensions as he pocketed his roll of money. But she didn’t feel demure anymore; she felt a thrill go through her as she watched him.

‘Oh, thanks so much!’ The tiny young woman was all surprised gratitude. ‘That’s so kind.’

‘Have fun, Ish.’ Savannah blew him a kiss, and when he flushed, she smirked. She felt Jackson’s eyes on her, and she shivered with excitement.

‘C’mon, Vi.’ Ishan took Violet’s arm. ‘Maude’s in town. I’ll message her.’

But Savannah wasn’t listening anymore. When she had something or someone in her sights, she was like a guided missile and, tonight, Jackson Rayne was her target.

Swaying up the stairs into her family's offices, Savannah only aim was to eliminate every fear about Dex's fidelity, or the memory of the swaying body...

Good tequila and Jackson Rayne could help her do that...

CHAPTER 6

THE STRANGER: SATURDAY NIGHT

As the woman dressed in silver trotted into the splendid Langley building, followed closely by a man in a tux, the figure stubbed out his cigarette and stepped back into the shadows.

It was good to have had a heads-up; the text that had come through about half hour ago had given him time to hire the Lime bike and cross the city swiftly.

What havoc might this whole venture wreak?

A lot, most probably – that was the plan.

On his phone, he had a copy of The List, and he didn't give a toss, to be honest, about the destruction; it was all about starting the game. Life had dealt him an unfair hand, but now he'd been given the chance to even things up.

He pulled the device from his bag, and began to prime it.

These privileged bastards: they wouldn't know what had hit them by the time he'd done his job. It was high time they paid the full price for what they took without thinking.

CHAPTER 7

ISHAN: SATURDAY NIGHT

It was bitterly cold on the grand London square as the wind picked up, and Ishan shrugged deeper into his jacket as they headed away from Langley & Co.'s office.

'I don't know about you, but I don't trust that man,' Violet said quietly as Ishan shepherded her towards Soho.

'Who, Jackson Rayne?' Ishan noticed how solemn his friend's heart-shaped face was. She'd seemed really freaked out by the hanging body. Personally, Ish was doing his best not to think of it again right now.

'He's a killing machine. I've had to type up his biog that many times, it's etched on my brain – unfortunately.'

'Really?' Ishan considered her words for a second. 'You mean, like, he killed loads of people in the army?'

'He was in the Special Forces before he wrote that first book. Loads of death, apparently.' Violet pulled a vape out of her coat pocket. 'It's his schtick.'

'Not really my bag.' Ishan grinned down at her. 'I prefer Martians and asteroids to battle scenes.'

'Ha! Don't blame you. But it's not just the crappy career choices.' Violet exhaled a cloud of cherry-flavoured smoke into the freezing night air. 'It's the fact he owes everything to Dex, except he never acts like he does.'

'But isn't that true of most authors and their editors? Though I'm surprised he's a good writer,' Ishan said as they scurried across Oxford Street, a red double-decker bus bearing down on them. 'He definitely hasn't got the gift of the gab.'

'Is he a good writer, though?' Violet muttered. 'A lot of it has to be rewritten.'

‘He must be, mustn’t he?’ Ishan looked down at her. ‘He sells enough.’ He began to navigate the raucous Saturday night crowds, protecting tiny Violet. ‘He must have something, cos he certainly scores with women.’

‘Yeah, Savannah Langley looked keen, but’, she frowned, ‘Dex has done so much for him.’

‘He’s got that brooding Heathcliff vibe about him, I guess. Strong and silent.’ Rueful, Ishan considered his own skinny frame. ‘Maybe that’s what Sexy Sav likes.’

‘Sexy Sav? Euch.’ Violet rolled her eyes. ‘And Heathcliff was a proper bully, wasn’t he? Like, nuts. I don’t know, there’s just something – off about the dude.’ Violet pocketed her vape as they turned onto Wardour Street, a jumble of late-night activity; busy cafes and candlelit bars playing throbbing music. ‘In my humble opinion, anyway. Also, poor Dex worships Savannah.’

‘Maybe,’ Ishan agreed absently, checking his phone. It was cold out here, and he wanted to get back inside, plus Violet’s vibe was bringing him down. ‘But she’s hot, too. And she can be super generous.’

‘Really? But God, it was all a bit cringe just now.’

Ishan had walked on a few metres before he realised Violet had stopped in her tracks. ‘What’s up, Vi?’

‘Can I tell you something? Something I found out.’

‘Sure.’ But he was distracted by a small group further down the road, in a huddle of cigarette smoke, by a neon-lit door. ‘Hey!’ He hurried forwards, waving. ‘Oh, sick, Maude’s already here -’

‘Sick,’ agreed Violet quietly.

‘Sorry,’ Ishan turned back. ‘What were you saying, Vi?’

‘Forget it,’ she mumbled.

‘C’mon then, let’s celebrate.’ He strode on towards the group, choosing to ignore the fact Violet didn’t look very keen.

CHAPTER 8

SAVANNAH: SATURDAY NIGHT

'Dex'll be so sad he missed this,' Savannah breathed half an hour later, as Jackson Rayne flicked her silk G-string over her ankle, extended as elegantly as her precarious position allowed on the boardroom table.

'Not the jealous type then, our Mr Harris?' Jackson's eyes glinted in the dim lighting.

'Sadly not,' she said as Jackson clasped her hips in strong hands. She pushed away her sorrow about Dex's attitude to sharing her – which was helped by all the tequila. She hadn't drunk this much since before rehab.

'*Sadly* not?' Jackson gazed down at her. 'What d'you mean?'

'Dex's definitely not jealous. He's kind of -' the word stuck in her throat. 'He's into us being open.'

'His loss.' Jackson pulled her towards him, stopping her thinking, *and I'm not*. Jackson was like one of those studs from the telly's *SAS Rescue*; such real men, and he had both brains and brawn – oh, and money and fame. What more could a girl want?

Undying love? Fidelity?

Savannah hit pause on those thoughts as Jackson licked her naked inner thigh. Wriggling, she waved a hand in the air above Jackson's head. 'But I've always wanted to make *him* jealous...'

'Who?' Jackson looked around.

'Daddy,' Savannah pointed at the huge portrait of her father that glowered down at them. Never one for smiling, her dad; too busy making money and breaking hearts – and spirits.

'Is that right?' Jackson growled in her ear; so deliciously near, tingles went through her whole body. 'You got daddy issues, then?'

‘Very probably.’ Savannah half-giggled, half-moaned with pleasure as he licked her neck. ‘He either ignored me, or wanted to control what I did. I always wanted to fuck someone while my daddy was watching – just to show him I could.’

‘You naughty girl!’ Jackson flipped her over in another masterful move. ‘I’ll show you what happens to naughty little girls, shall I?’

‘Yes, please!’ Savannah sighed, her face to the oak table, so she was inhaling beeswax polish. ‘I’m dying to find out.’

‘You will be.’ With his hands on the back of her skull, he pushed her down so forcefully, she could barely breathe.

And with a nasty flash, Savannah remembered the thing she’d been grappling with since they’d left the Savoy: the fact that, for a few seconds in that ballroom, she’d recognised the face of the dummy.

But in her drunken haze, she couldn’t think whose face it had been, and the memory slid from her head again as she let Jackson take the lead.

It felt electrifying. Electrifying – mixed with something else darker; something she didn’t want to acknowledge right now.

Something that smelled like death.

CHAPTER 9

SUNDAY MORNING

Upstairs in the Langley penthouse, someone was banging on the internal front door so loudly, it sounded like a hammer. Meanwhile, nearby, a phone rang insistently.

It took a second or two for Savannah to register it was the family's mock-1920s landline vibrating on the bedside table, its horrid tone drilling into her poor splitting head. It rang off, then began again; rang off, began again. Aware she might throw up any minute, Savannah crawled across the bed to answer.

'What?' she snapped, just about containing the urge to retch.

'How delightfully cordial.' Her big sister, Ruth. 'Good morning, Savannah.' Ruth refused to call her Savvi, like most of the family did. It was babyish, apparently – a view which summed up Ruth's view of Savannah generally. 'How are you?'

'Okay.' Savannah yawned, feeling like she'd swallowed the Sahara Desert during the night. 'How did you know I was here?'

'Little birds, dear.'

Spies on every corner, you mean, Savannah thought fiercely. She had no time for niceties when she felt this sick. 'What do you want?'

'Well, obviously...' Ruth fell silent. There was a first time for everything, Savannah supposed.

'Obviously, what?'

'I'm so sorry about the terrible news...'

'What news?'

'Ah.' Ruth's own intake of breath was audible. 'Are you sitting down?'

'I'm bloody lying down,' Savannah drawled, then thought she'd better pull herself together. Clutching the silk sheet, she dragged herself up,

catching a glimpse of her own bedraggled reflection in the long mirror, opposite. Not a pretty sight. 'Sorry. I'm not feeling very well. Getting flu, I think...' On top of about three hours' sleep. Jackson Rayne had proved himself a bit of a goer. Although, honestly, she thought, noticing her bruised wrist, he had been a bit rough...

'Listen, Savannah,' Ruth's brisk tones cut across her memories. 'There's no easy way to say this. It's Dex.'

'What's Dex?' Savannah could see last night's smoky eye makeup smeared across her face. 'What d'you mean?' She had a bad feeling in the pit of her belly, and a sudden craving for her little dog Kylie. Kylie always made her feel better, the way she depended on Savannah, the trembly warmth of her tiny body...

'I'm so sorry, but Dex is dead,' Ruth said, as someone banged on the penthouse door again. 'Did you really not know?'

'Dead?' Savannah's brain slowed to frozen. 'What do you mean, *dead*?'

'I mean dead, dead, Savvi.' For once, Ruth's tone softened as she used the family nickname. 'Most definitely gone, for which I am truly sorry.'

'But...' Savannah's whole world was reeling. 'It was only a migraine!'

'Migraine or not, I'm afraid he's...' there was a beat as Ruth obviously debated saying the word yet again. 'Yes, he's gone. Now I'm trying to keep it out of the press -'

'I don't understand...' This must be a bad dream, surely? Savannah tried to catch her breath, but her sister carried on.

'Now, listen. I know you were his fiancée...' Ruth's often acerbic tones were still softer than normal as she used the past tense. 'But the police are on their way, and you're his fiancé. I know it's going to be really hard, but I have to ask you to come in to talk to them. We've got to be seen to help in every way possible -'

Savannah had dropped the phone to throw up into a nearby peace lily, so she missed Ruth's parting shot, but she could have guessed it.

Family comes first, remember?

The sad thing was none of them really liked each other much, and recently it had been her darling Dex who'd protected Savannah from that knowledge.

But now Dex was gone. Just as she'd feared, in the end, Dex had left her too.

The horrible and burning question was – why?

CHAPTER 10

SUNDAY MORNING

Clara woke late on Sunday morning, feeling more human than she had for days, though a bit worried when she remembered she'd spent a few hours in bed thrifting online; impulsive shopping being a comfort to her, along with impulsive cake eating.

Relieved her cold was finally breaking, and she could (almost) breathe through her nose again, Clara switched her phone back on, impatient to see if her friend Violet had got back to her.

'Aha, there you are!' Rubbing sticky eyes, Clara saw Violet had finally answered her text, around 1.30 a.m.

'Creepy night, horrible people, except Dex and Ish. Could have rilly used yr company. Yeah the dead body thing so weird @ Call you tomo. X

Clara padded into her mum's kitchen to put the kettle on. Still perplexed about what had happened at yesterday's Awards, she checked her socials; a few comments on her post, saying the dead body was a 'hoax.' Not a very funny one though, to Clara's mind: no more funny than her discovery last night on the family iPad – which was seriously worrying.

'Adam?' she called, flicking the radio on. Her main priority today was to assess how deeply her baby brother had been drawn into this misogynistic bullshit. And that would be tough, given how hard he was to reach, both literally and metaphorically.

'Ad?' She knocked on his bedroom door – but it was empty.

Maybe he hadn't come home last night, after she'd heard the door slam? But he worked in the gym near the station, so she could pop in on her way to do her weekly food shop. Their mum lived on tinned soup and Super

Noodles, while Adam lived on chicken and protein shakes, but Clara wanted at least some of her five fruit and veg a day.

She'd just chucked a teabag into a mug when the radio newsreader interrupted her dark thoughts:

'Renowned editor Dexter Harris has been found dead at the London HQ of publishing firm, Langley & Co., where he worked for the past five years...'

Clara nearly dropped her mug.

'Only 46, Dexter Harris began his career at Penguin Random House, and quickly went stellar with his publication list. Engaged to Langley & Co. Communications Director Savannah Langley since September, most recently, he's been known for helping authors like Maddy Keo, and the enigmatic ex-soldier, Jackson Rayne, become superstars. His employers have yet to release any sort of statement, but Jackson Rayne was briefly available for comment, this morning. Understandably devastated, the bestselling author said he'd never worked with such a 'stand-up guy' as Harris.'

Dex Harris – dead?

No way could that be true, could it? Clara realised her mouth was hanging open as she sat down with a thump.

After a minute, she pulled her phone from her dressing-gown pocket. But Violet's phone went straight to voicemail; no doubt Violet would be asleep, horribly hungover, if the number of bottles on the Langley table last night was anything to go by.

Still shocked, Clara turned the radio off as her work WhatsApp group started pinging.

WT actual F? Ruth Langley's PA Maude was first. ***Have you heard the news?***

Fake news, surely? commented Paul from the mailroom; another possible flat-earthier – not unlike her brother, Clara thought, with a stab of fear.

I heard he had a heart attack after too much chang at the awards, someone from the Comms department wrote, followed by a broken heart emoji, and Clara felt a surge of anger.

Dex wasn't like that, she thought, shoving her phone away; not as far as she knew, anyway. He was one of the good guys at Langley & Co.; quiet and serious and popular. He'd always been polite to Clara, and she liked listening to his wisdom in any meetings they'd both attended.

Dex Harris, editor to some of the greatest writers: and someone she'd hoped to work more closely with as she climbed the Langley ladder. It seemed bizarre and, also, completely tragic that he was dead.

Throwing her latest vintage tracksuit on and washing her face, Clara tried Violet again. Surely she would have some answers -

Violet was Clara's biggest ally at Langley & Co. Sure, she was quiet but with a wicked sense of humour and a passionate nature that occasionally made itself known – like when that huge kids' author killed off his hero's dog on a clifftop, and Violet sobbed in distress, before petitioning for Dex to edit out the death.

Still waters run deep, as Clara's dad used to say, though Clara tried not to think about him these days.

Clara had met Violet when she'd been designated Clara's 'buddy' – Langley's wanky term for a mentor – for the first week of her Langley & Co. internship programme - a scheme targeted at working-class candidates, and they'd remained fast friends. Both entirely state-educated, the two young women found the office poshos a bit terrifying: rich girls with expensive glossy hair and Daddy's credit card on hand; girls who used

publishing 'like finishing school', as Violet muttered to Clara in Langley's top-floor café, that first week.

'What exactly do you finish, there?' Clara said, eyeing up a jam doughnut on the counter as they queued to order.

'Yourself, darling,' Violet grinned, mimicking the Comms Director, Savannah Langley – clearly a woman who never considered herself finished – judging by her multiple 'tweakments'.

'I did think you were posh, actually, before we met,' Violet had admitted to Clara as they sat. "Cos of your name. I thought you'd lied about the working-class bit.'

'Oh God, no.' Clara passed Violet her weird green tea and ladled sugar into her own cup. 'My mum saw *The Nutcracker Suite* ballet on the telly, and loved it so much, she named me after the girl in it. But I grew up on a council estate in Hackney, for my sins.'

Where she was now, as she listened to Violet's phone go straight to voicemail again and absently read a fridge magnet she'd bought her mum: *Dream big or you stay small*.

And, as Dex Harris's death had just confirmed, life was horribly short.

Putting her own phone down, Clara felt a wave of anxiety that wouldn't land. Violet was the type to never let her battery run down; why on earth was her phone still off?

CHAPTER 11

SUNDAY MORNING

‘Why?’ A tear-sodden Savannah had wailed to her sister Ruth as they stood helplessly in the Langley offices, waiting for the police to finish assessing the scene. ‘Why would Dex take his own life? We were so happy together.’

‘I really wish I knew, Savannah. I’m so sorry.’ For once, Ruth had no more idea than Savannah about something. ‘It’s such a terrible loss for the literary world,’ she’d murmured, staring at her phone.

‘What about *my* loss?’ Savannah yowled at Ruth. And how inappropriate for her sister to be more interested in her phone than in Savannah, or in Dex’s body, lying next door. Or was he still hanging? *Oh, no-*

She shoved the thought away as Ruth kept gazing at her device. Standard behaviour – Ruth was always on a screen of some sort: wheeling, dealing, keeping on top of things. Being in control, which Savannah definitely wasn’t, right now. Thank God, she’d found a bottle of diazepam tablets earlier in the Langley penthouse bathroom: always well-stocked with medication, alongside Clinique cosmetics. Despite having been very careful since rehab about any sort of drug, Savannah had allowed herself a single pill, hoping it would blur the edges of her despair.

‘I know it’s terrible, but do stop crying if you possibly can.’ Putting her phone down, Ruth snapped to attention. ‘I don’t think it’s healthy for you to get hysterical.’ She touched Savannah’s arm – which was weird, in itself. ‘And I’m very sorry, but we’ve got to think about optics right now, or we’ll all be paying the price.’

‘Optics?’ Savannah was stupefied. ‘Is that seriously your priority?’

‘No. You’re my priority.’ Ruth looked uncomfortable as she stated something Savannah wished was true, but didn’t believe. ‘However, and not to put too fine a point on it: *Dex* might be dead—’

‘That’s not a fine point, no.’ Savannah glared at her sister.

‘...but we aren’t. And obviously, as Comms Director...’ Ruth sighed. ‘I mean, ideally, you’ll manage the comms on his tragic demise.’

At that, Savannah burst into tears so hysterical, Ruth propelled her swiftly into the nearest private office off the main floor. ‘Shush, dear. We’ll talk about it when you’re calmer, okay? You don’t have to do anything you’re not up to.’

But Savannah just sobbed harder. The twee little office belonged to the Editorial Director for romance, and it was full of plush stuffed hearts, snow globes of New York at Christmas, and pink and gold paperbacks emblazoned with cavorting couples – all of which just made Savannah’s heart ache more.

‘Make yourself useful, please,’ Ruth barked at the security guard who’d found *Dex*’s body. ‘Shut these blinds. Everyone’s gawping at my sister.’

‘Of course.’ From the speed of the guard’s reaction, almost tripping over in his hurry to shut the room’s internal blinds, it was clear he was relieved to be useful.

‘Excuse me,’ Savannah heard Ruth call the paramedics, also standing around like spare parts now. ‘Can someone help my sister, please, before she drowns in her own tears.’

‘Of course.’ A motherly paramedic bustled over with her bag.

‘And may I just add...’ Ruth clapped her hands once for attention, and addressed everyone in the open-plan office. ‘A small warning. If I see or find anyone take a single photo of this scene...’ She lowered her voice, while

everyone gazed at her, rapt. 'Believe me, you'll feel the wrath of the Langley legal team. Capeesh?'

Open-mouthed, the paramedics and guard looked a bit stunned but, sheep-like, they all nodded their agreement.

Ruth Langley often had that effect on people.

*

'Lie back, please,' the paramedic instructed Savannah, checking her pulse. 'As long as you're on no other meds, pet, I can give you a small sedative.'

'Oh, lovely.' Savannah cheered up a touch. 'No other meds, no.' One little diazepam didn't count, surely, and at least someone understood her sorrow. Ruth might be trying to be kind, but she'd always put the family business first. That's how it had always been, and always would be – whereas Savannah herself was far more sensitive.

In fact, lying back and gazing at a full-size mock-up of a book called *Love Comes Knocking* (the suggestive cover featured a woman's arm and fist in a long black glove), she had no doubt she was the most sensitive of the five Langley siblings – though her twin Bella might have something to say about that.

"Scuse me, ma'am?" A uniformed officer approached the office door. 'We found this on Mr Harris' desk. Does it make any sense to you?'

Ruth appeared behind him. 'Show me.'

As instructed, he handed it over: a note, on a jagged bit of paper, torn out of something like an exercise-book. Savannah could see the hasty scrawl was most definitely Dex's messy handwriting. 'What does it say?' she croaked.

'It says -' Ruth read the words aloud '*She's broken my heart.*' Then she turned the note over and, from the back, read -

'I can't go on.'

'Oh, my good God!' Savannah felt so terrible again, she collapsed back on the office sofa and refused to open her eyes until the sedative kicked in.

CHAPTER 12

SUNDAY, MIDDAY

Clara arrived at FitBods, the local branch of the gym franchise where her brother Adam worked, hoping it was his lunch hour. If he wasn't on some weird dietary regime – which he usually was, these days – she'd take him for a coffee. Or a protein shake, more likely.

'Adam Voss?' The gormless-looking guy on the front desk barely looked up from his phone. 'He's not in, today.'

'Are you sure?' Clara was surprised. Saving for a new car, Adam usually worked every hour he could get – and especially Sundays, when he earned what he called 'double bubble'.

'Adam? He's not been in all weekend.' A pretty girl with braids emerged from the back office. 'He was meant to be working, but then he asked for it off last minute.'

'Oh.' Clara frowned, confused. 'Any idea why?'

'Don't know, no. But...' The girl lowered her voice a bit. 'I reckon he might be at one of those weird meetings.'

'What weird meetings?' Clara's heart sank, but before she could clarify, the girl was called to a customer.

'Do you know what she meant?' Clara asked the gormless guy.

'Dunno.' The man seemed uninterested. 'He's kind of like into those mad YouTubers though, isn't he?'

'Who?' But feeling a clutch of dread, Clara realised she might have an idea what he meant.

'Like, the Red Pillars.' The man finally looked up at Clara and pulled a face. 'Proper twats, if you ask me.'

*

Rattled, Clara walked back to the bus stop. She'd lost her appetite and couldn't be bothered with the big shop, after all; she'd just have Super Noodles for supper. She was urgently searching up the Red Pillars when her WhatsApp group started pinging again.

Oh my God – have you seen this?

Like OMG?

I'm sooo glad I'm not on this!!!!

It was accompanied by a screenshot of a tweet, which read:

THE LIST: Prepare to Die For your Sins!

Attached was an image of a typed list. And the names on it?

Dex Harris

Violet Childs

Jackson Rayne

Clara Voss

? Langley

All is not forgiven (👁️ Skull face)

Clara nearly fell over her own feet in shock.

Prepare to die? Why the hell was *she* on this list? What sins was she meant to have committed?

And, even more terrifyingly: if Dex was already dead, who was next?

CHAPTER 13

SUNDAY MIDDAY

When the detective sergeant from the London Met arrived in Ruth's swanky private office on the third floor, at least he'd interrupted the talking-to Savannah's older sister had been subjecting her to.

'Try to pull yourself together, now.' Ruth had filled two heavy tumblers with whisky from her Waterford crystal decanter, and thrust one at Savannah. It seemed like her earlier patience was wearing thin. 'I hate to point out that you can't be *that* upset about Dex, given you were shagging Jackson Rayne last night on the boardroom table. Which, let me just check – you were happy about, right?'

At that, Savannah had gone first pale, then completely scarlet. Bloody Ruth: she had eyes in the back of her head – as well as a top-notch in-house CCTV system Savannah had totally forgotten about in the heat of last night's moment. A CCTV system no doubt bordering on intrusive, if not downright illegal.

'I do hope you didn't watch.' Savannah downed half her drink. She hated whisky, but it was better than nothing. Anything was better than nothing right now.

'Don't be common, dear. It's up to you who you have sex with, though I don't think he's the one for you. But as long as it was consensual, your call,' Ruth downed her own glass in one, which surprised Savannah. Ruth had never been a drinker, she was far too controlled. Or controlling – like their dad. 'Still, crucially, I don't want our name dragged through the mud. I'd warned the whole company about toeing the line...'

'Of course,' said Savannah dully. 'Sorry.'

'And we need to protect Rayne's brand. I mean, this whole fucking thing is already a complete nightmare,' Ruth's swearing indicated how

upset she really was. 'The implications of our best editor topping himself in our actual offices?' Ruth tapped the side of her empty glass, as if it might produce a solution. 'Jesus, Dex, what the hell were you thinking?'

Savannah, starting to feel gratefully floaty from the meds the paramedic had given her, didn't bother to reply. She couldn't care less whether it was a nightmare for the company; it was just an utter horror show, for her. Her chest was tight with dread, and something she couldn't name; something that took her back to her childhood desperation when she got left at school. It felt like she was drowning in her own distress -

Savannah knocked back the rest of her drink so fast, the glass clinked on her teeth.

*

'DS Addo, London Met.' The policeman, who looked like a retired boxer, shook Ruth's hand. 'Sorry about your colleague.' He inclined his head quickly, reminding Savannah of one of those nodding bulldogs that drivers put on their car dashboards. 'To clarify, ladies, if it is suicide, there'll be an inquest. But if it wasn't suicide, obviously, it's a criminal investigation.'

'Hang on, what do you mean, if it's not suicide?' Ruth demanded. 'Isn't it obvious that it was?'

Savannah gazed at the man. He had a very thick neck, she noticed.

'It certainly looks that way, ladies, but there are a few anomalies, at this stage.'

And who on earth said 'ladies', these days? This guy was prehistoric.

'What are you talking about? It's pretty cut and dry, I'd say.' Ruth's composure was legendary in both her family and the publishing world, but she seemed almost flustered, now. 'To be frank, my main priority right now is keeping Dex's death out of the press.'

‘You can try.’ The policeman shrugged. ‘But I’m betting that’ll be hard in a company of this size. I understand you also worked here with the deceased?’ He nodded at Savannah again.

‘I’m a Langley,’ Savannah croaked, the word *deceased* bouncing round her head like a savage squash ball. ‘Savannah.’

‘Congratulations,’ DS Addo said drily.

‘And he – Dex,’ she almost choked on his name. ‘He was my fiancé.’

‘I see. And when did you last see your fiancé, Miss Langley?’

‘Ms Langley. I’m a divorcée. I saw him about eleven, last night. Dex took a taxi home after the National Book Awards ceremony. He had one of his migraines.’

‘And where were you, if not at home with him?’

‘He wanted me to celebrate.’ Savannah bristled at the policeman’s tone. ‘We came back here for a few drinks.’

‘We?’

‘Yes. Me and...’ Savannah couldn’t meet her sister’s eye. ‘Jackson Rayne. The, er, the author.’ She hoped she didn’t look as guilty as she felt.

‘Oh, yeah.’ The cop perked up a bit. ‘Writes those thrillers about the Alaskan cop? My wife bought me one for my last birthday. Not bad, I thought – better than a lot of the crap out there.’

‘Yep, Smoke Silva.’ Ruth looked pleased. ‘Jackson’s new book’s due out for next month, and it’s a cracker, so you can put it on your Christmas list.’ Pleased with her own joke, she added, ‘A Christmas cracker!’

Christ. Never one to miss a marketing opportunity, the silly cow, Savannah thought, but she was feeling too woozy to retaliate.

‘I mean, some of the police procedure was a bit off, but I guess it was American...’ DS Addo began, then remembered himself. He turned back to Savannah. ‘So, it was just you and Mr Rayne, here?’

Savannah was sure he was looking at her crumpled dress; the same dress she'd had on since last night. And off, and on again – *God*, she'd been so drunk and reckless last night, which seemed a million years ago, right now. Those tequila shots had a lot to answer for.

'Ms Langley?'

'Sorry.' She forced herself to concentrate. 'No, there was that little assistant of Dex's, the mousey one. Viola something. Oh, and my assistant, Ishan.'

'That's a weird mix of people.' Ruth's eyes narrowed. 'Even for you.'

'Not really, and I'm nothing if not liberal, darling.' Savannah found herself wondering absently if Ruth's hairdresser cut her hair using a ruler. She'd never seen such straight lines on a bob, apart from maybe on *Vogue's* Anna Wintour.

'So your party decided to drink together, after?'

'No. Dex took his assistant Violet to the awards because he was so kind.' Savannah tried to swallow the lump in her throat. 'I took Ishan for all his hard work. Afterwards, the youngsters went on clubbing or something. Can I go, now?' Standing too quickly, she nearly lost her balance. 'The dog's been on her own for ages.' Actually, her housekeeper Maria was there, but Savannah's little Chihuahua was as sensitive as her mistress – with similar abandonment issues, probably.

'Not quite yet,' the policeman said slowly. 'Just a few more questions, ma'am.'

'Fine.' Savannah's shoulders slumped. She just wanted to crawl into her giant Vispring bed and sob herself to sleep – alone. *Oh, God* – to never see Dex again! She bit the inside of her lip super hard, to stop the tears; a trick learned around the time her mum Melissa refused to kiss her goodbye that first time they were dumped at boarding-school, Melissa too busy to

come in the car, so the family driver, Danvers Snr, deposited them there and gave them both a fiver, patting their heads awkwardly.

Savannah could still hear Bella's terrible wails in her ears. Older by five minutes, she'd had to be the tough one, back then.

'Do you have CCTV?' the cop was asking Ruth. 'If so, I'll need access to it, please.'

'Of course.' Ruth inclined her head graciously. 'We have the most up-to-date systems going. Our Head of Security will assist you.'

CCTV? Savannah clutched the nearest chair for support. Could this day get any worse? Was Ruth really going to hand over her shame to the police?

But Ruth caught Savannah's eye, and she thought she interpreted a certain reassurance. Please God anyway -

'I think I should share with you—' the policeman looked very intently at them both, '—we received a call about Dex Harris this morning. It raised some alarms.'

'What kind of call?'

'I can't go into detail, now. Obviously, we're checking the authenticity. But the caller suggested Mr Harris had things to hide.'

'Dex? No way.' Ruth was vehement, shaking her head, so her sharp bob swung symmetrically. 'Must be a prank.'

'Maybe.' The policeman was calm. 'No stone unturned, though. And finally, while I'm here, I wondered, have you seen this list?'

Savannah realised the officer was addressing her, too. 'What list?'

'Calling itself a Death List.' He fished a phone out of his pocket. 'Pretty sure it's just online hoaxers, but we'd be remiss not to check it out.'

'A *what* list?'

‘Thing is,’ the policeman extended the phone, ‘it mentions one of you Langleys.’

‘Us?’ The voices around Savannah had gone kind of echoey, like she was in a public swimming pool, she imagined – not that she’d ever frequented one. ‘Are you sure?’

‘Fraid so. It doesn’t specify which one. Look, if you want.’

‘I believe you.’ She couldn’t see that tiny screen, but she wouldn’t be caught dead in her reading glasses. ‘And who else?’ Savannah was feeling faint, now.

‘Well, Dex Harris was top of the list.’

‘Dexy?’ Savannah swallowed hard. ‘But – who wrote it?’

‘Well...’ The policeman stared at her. ‘Given it comes from an account calling itself the *‘Real Dex Harris’*, I was rather hoping you could tell me.’

CHAPTER 14

SUNDAY EVENING

When the news announced that Dex Harris had committed suicide, Clara had never been more relieved to hear someone had died by their own hand. But that thought was followed by a huge stab of guilt. Clara didn't want Dex to be dead, any more than she wanted to die, herself – and she *really* didn't want to die.

'How terrible.' Her mum's eyes had widened childishly on FaceTime when Clara told her the news about Dex – so Clara couldn't bear to admit her own name was on the same weird death list.

But she'd watched all afternoon as the list went viral, speeding across the internet in a way that was terrifying – like a forest fire, Clara thought. Mainly, she guessed, because Dex was already dead, and the infamous Jackson Rayne was on it, too.

The author was also at the top of all the news websites right now, wearing a long coat and dark glasses, and looking deeply pensive; a cross between Mr Rochester and one of those fit Special Forces guys on the telly. Rayne was shown walking by the sea with a very pretty 'female friend', both with takeaway coffees in hand, and Clara felt a twinge of sorrow for him.

Dex had showed Clara a few paragraphs of Rayne's memoir proposal, so she had an idea what the writer had been through, growing up. Now this, on top of his early tragedies.

But honestly, Clara was more worried about herself right now than Jackson Rayne: he could afford all the security in the world if he needed it, while she was on her own, in an old council block with a shared walkway and no security at all.

After reading the group messages on the bus home, Clara had combed Twitter (now the hideous X), until she found the original List. To her shock,

it had been posted by an account called *@TheRealDexHarris*, which had a recent photo of Dex himself as the avatar.

But that couldn't be right, could it? Why would Dex have posted something he'd called a 'Death List', and then killed himself? Someone must be posing as him – unless he'd lost his mind before his suicide? Stranger things had happened, Clara supposed – and it was all *really* strange.

Chilled to the bone, Clara put her phone away, telling herself the horrible list was just malicious trolling. After all, everyone knew the online world these days was full of nut jobs; it wasn't something to be taken seriously. Like the horrible phone call she'd received...

For once, Clara wished her mum was coming back tonight, and not midweek, so she had company in the flat. She even texted Adam, offering pizza and beer as bait to come home and hang out with her – but she got zero response.

'Atishoo!' Clara sneezed again, dejected, her nasty cold feeling worse again. Giving the day up for a bad one, she decided to have a hot bath and an early night. And before she went to bed, she would make very sure she'd double-locked the front door.

Not that the flimsy door on their flat would be a match for anyone who really wanted to get in.

CHAPTER 15

SUNDAY AFTERNOON

In the back of the company Mercedes on the way home to Notting Hill, Savannah had taken a deep breath and called her twin sister Bella. They had a love-hate relationship at the best of times, and Bella would possibly, if not definitely, be full of opinions about the tragic news.

Still, she was also the one person who knew Savannah as well as she knew herself; better, potentially, given the amount of therapy Bella had paid for over the years. Savannah had some small hope that, if it was one of Bella's good days, she might get some comfort from her twin.

'Have you heard?' Savannah croaked as soon as her sister picked up. 'Dex has...' But she couldn't bring herself to say the words.

If she said it, it meant it was real.

'Dex has what?' Bang in the middle of her eco-activism era, led by her husband Omari, Bella was probably abseiling down an Indonesian volcano, or halfway up a coconut tree on a palm oil plantation, trying to save an orangutan. 'I can hardly hear you.'

'Dex has...' Savannah's tears seeped out. 'He's taken his own life.'

'Sav? It's a terrible line—'

'Dex is bloody well *dead*!' Savannah screamed and slumped back on the seat. In front of her, Danvers Jnr shifted his head just a millimetre or two to the right. He'd been with the family for years, taking over from his dad, so he was used to overhearing all sorts of lunacy.

'*Your* Dex?' Bella was saying. '*Dead*? My God, Savvi, I'm so sorry.'

'You and me both,' Savannah tried to joke through her tears, but it just made her cry more. *Most unladylike, Savannah*, their mother would say if she saw her now. It didn't matter that Melissa had been born above a bookie's in South London; she'd honed her own accent like cut glass,

carefully shaking off her working-class roots – and she expected her twin daughters to behave like royalty at all times – not that royalty always behaved well.

‘But why?’ her sister demanded, the phone line crackling like crazy. ‘God, and I actually liked this one!’

Bella had been bad at romance before meeting Omari, and her own failures in love had often made her scathing about Savannah’s choices. But with Dex, it had been different: for once, her twin and her man had liked each other. The four of them had even spent a weekend together in Cannes last year, drinking rosé, swimming in the crystal-blue Med, and zipping out on the speedboat to sleep and shag on the company yacht. Savannah had drawn the line, though, when Dex had mooted the idea of a bit of partner-swapping with her twin. It was one of the few huge arguments they’d had in their time together.

‘How did he die?’

‘He...’ Scared she’d hyperventilate, Savannah squeezed her knees together hard, like she’d been taught during her brief stint in rehab therapy. ‘He killed himself, Bel. But it’s even worse than that...’ She dropped her voice. ‘His note said *she broke my heart*.’

‘My God!’ Bella breathed. ‘Poor man. What did you do to push him over the edge?’

‘Really, Bella? Just piss off.’ Savannah chunked her phone into her bag without even disconnecting the call.

In the seat in front of her, Danvers’ ears were turning red.

But the truth was, Bella had only said what Savannah was already thinking.

*

At home, Savannah took a scalding shower and put on her cashmere comfies, trying not to think about Dex's clothes hanging in his dressing room next door.

Scooping her shivery little dog Kylie into her lap, the two of them curled up on the maroon velvet sofa downstairs – a sofa big enough for a family of five. It had certainly seen some sights this past year, Savannah thought fondly – but when she looked up on the mantelpiece and saw the Polaroid from their recent Seychelles holiday, Dex toasting her with his coconut-shell cocktail, the tears started again, and she thought they'd never stop. What had she done to Dex to make him leave her like this?

But above all else, why did it feel so wrong – how could she not have realised he was suicidal? *God*, the guilt.

Wiping her eyes, Savannah got up again and went upstairs to the spare bedroom Dex used as a study. There must have been a sign somewhere that Dex had or hadn't been suicidal, and she was going to leave no stone unturned until she found it.

Because if she couldn't squash the fear that her own actions were to blame for his death, she didn't know how she'd be able to live with herself.

CHAPTER 16

SUNDAY AFTERNOON

Savannah found nothing of significance in Dex's desk, apart from two tickets to *Swan Lake* at Covent Garden, which he must have bought for her birthday. The sweet sentiment nearly broke her completely; even though she hated ballet, having been expelled from the Royal Ballet School at sixteen, for selling pills nicked from her mum Melissa to the other students.

It was about the same time she realised medication was a relief.

Before she met Dex, badly burned by her toxic first marriage to Simon Wexford, Savannah had convinced herself she wasn't ready to settle down again. And the Langley family ethic forbade mixing business with pleasure, so when she'd been partnered with Dex in a team-building exercise at a 'fun' Langley day in the Cotswolds, it had ended up being much more fun in her four-poster bed, at the olde-worlde Lamb Inn.

For once, Ruth hadn't interfered when she found out. Perhaps secretly, she'd thought Dex was just what her poor flighty sister needed.

Savannah quickly began to think Dex was 'the one', so it was a shock to understand Dex himself didn't believe 'the one' existed. He loved Savannah deeply, she knew that; he was beyond kind, and very tolerant of her insecurities – but he was also into a few exotic pleasures, sexually. And against her will and all her instincts, Savannah had accepted that, because she'd fallen for Dex so hard.

Now she picked up the old fleece that smelled of Dex and wrapped herself in it; dozing in the study's armchair until something woke her with a start - the buzz of the front gate.

'Maria?' Savannah called, heart in her mouth. The idea of visitors felt unbearable. 'Tell them not today.'

No response; not even from her tiny dog, and yet more frantic buzzing.

Savannah stumbled downstairs to the hall, peering at the tiny video screen at the control-box by the front door.

Out on the pavement by her gate stood a child, dressed in jeans and a big puffa jacket, its hood up. Except – no, hang on. As the figure tilted its face up, most probably unaware she was on camera, Savannah saw it wasn't a child at all, but someone she recognised: that small young woman, Dex's assistant, Violet.

Gazing at her now on the screen, Savannah remembered how Violet had looked at Dex the previous night at their table at the awards ceremony, and then in the cab, afterwards. There was no way Savannah could deal with a poor girl's broken heart, when her own misery was so all-consuming.

'Maria!' Savannah waved at her housekeeper, who'd finally appeared on the curving stairwell with a bucket of water and some kitchen towel. Kylie must have been up to her old tricks. 'Answer the door, please.'

'Madam?' Maria bustled down, followed by the skittering dog. 'Are you receiving?'

'Definitely not. Say I'm out, or in mourning, or just something, but I can't see that girl right now. I can't see anyone.'

Grabbing Kylie, Savannah ran upstairs with a sob and took to her bed, her secret stash of pills mocking her from the bathroom cabinet. Whatever else, her own sleuthing would have to wait.

CHAPTER 17

VIOLET: SUNDAY AFTERNOON

In the November gloom on the smart London street, the likes of which too many people only see in magazines and films such as *Notting Hill*, Violet hurried away from the house; a house so grand, she could hardly imagine going inside, let alone living in it.

And the street was very quiet; no one around, no one walking; they were probably all chauffeur-driven round here, or in posh gyms, or sunning themselves in the Bahamas.

Terrified it was only a matter of time before everything came crashing down around her, she'd had to try, but she'd failed – and she was still alone.

Even though she was sure Savannah Langley was in the house.

Crossing the street to hurry towards the bus stop, Violet checked the time anxiously. She knew there was someone behind her; someone who'd been following her since she'd left her flat earlier...

She broke into a half walk, half run – and so did the figure following close behind her.

CHAPTER 18

CLARA: SUNDAY NIGHT

The fierce winds that had threatened all weekend were picking up, tonight; the big bins in the alley behind Clara's block of flats rattled as she drifted in and out of sleep.

Around 2 a.m., she woke with a jump to the noise of something tapping methodically against her window. Half-asleep, she recalled a spooky story the boys at school used to tell, of the couple whose car broke down in a forest. The husband went for help, while the wife sat terrified, until a rhythmic noise began: a banging above her. When the woman finally left the car, it turned out to be the killer hitting her husband's severed head on the roof.

Terror clutched Clara now and, for a few seconds, she was too scared to get out of bed to look out of the window. Eventually, she forced herself up and saw it was only the old willow tree, whipping across from her neighbour's tiny yard.

Except, now she was sure she could hear something else: another noise, beneath the tapping of the spindly branches.

Be brave, Clara scolded herself. Finding an old umbrella by her chest of drawers, she held it in front of her as a defensive weapon and crept to her bedroom door. Peering out, her pulse quickened as she saw a shadow in the hall. Her heart began to gallop as she yelled 'Who's there?' and charged towards the shadow.

The figure spun round. 'Get off, you idiot!'

'Adam!' She'd knocked her brother off-balance as they collided, sending something clattering to the floor.

'Yeah, you nutter, who else?' Her brother righted himself. 'And ouch, that hurt! Stop being a loon.'

‘But why are you creeping around *again*?’ Filled with sudden anger, Clara gave him a shove, causing him to drop whatever he was trying to pick up from the floor. A phone, she saw, as he fumbled with it. ‘You scared the living daylights out of me.’

‘Cos you’re mental.’ He was defensive as he snatched the phone up. ‘I wasn’t creeping around!’

‘What are you looking at?’ She grabbed at the phone, reading something like *THE PAIN EFFECT* on the screen. ‘Is it porn? Or those incel weirdos again?’

‘What incel weirdos?’ Adam snapped – a standard response from him, recently. ‘I’m going to bed.’

As she watched him slope off to his room, a wave of sadness hit her. Eight years younger than Clara, he’d always been such a sunny little boy, the absolute apple of both her and her mum’s eyes. They’d babied him, sure; spoiled him rotten, she supposed. Had they ruined him?

Or was it the fact their dad had run out on them that pushed Adam into this weird state recently, where he acted like he barely knew her?

Clara suddenly felt far beyond her twenty-eight years, and very depressed. Perhaps it wouldn’t be a bad thing if she did get knocked off on the Death List, she thought glumly, traipsing back to bed.

But this time, she locked her bedroom door too.

CHAPTER 20

CLARA: MONDAY MORNING

By the time she arrived at Langley & Co.'s offices early on Monday morning, Clara was already exhausted. What with all the stormy weather last night, and then Adam's secretive behaviour, along with her name appearing on the List, she'd barely slept at all.

Clara loved her job, especially since her promotion to Editor, but, today, she was extra glad to be in the office. She needed the company, and to ask Violet what had really gone on at Saturday night's awards. Maybe then, they could start to work out why they were both on the bloody List.

But the atmosphere in the hushed offices immediately felt odd. No one was gossiping in the kitchen, or by the water cooler, like they normally did after the weekend – and Violet's chair outside Dex's door was as empty as his office.

As Clara hurried to her own desk at the far end of the floor, she tried not to stare at that small room where she assumed Dex had died, less than thirty-six hours ago. Switching her computer on, she felt deeply unsettled – not least because she had no idea who she would be reporting to, now her boss was dead.

*

Half an hour later, Savannah's assistant Ishan nodded as he passed her – on his way to the nearest espresso machine, no doubt. Langley supplied endless rocket-fuel coffee from expensive machines – much nicer than the big tins of cheap instant stuff her mum nicked from work and brought home.

'Hey, Ishan.' Clara hurried after the PA. 'Getting coffee?'

'Oh.' He turned, surprised. 'Yeah. Sorry, remind me of your name?'

‘Clara, Violet’s friend. You were at the awards together, weren’t you?’ Clara fell in step with him. Sure, they barely knew each other, but Clara was alarmed enough to be forward. All bets were off, right now. ‘Have you seen Violet, today?’

‘Er, no...’ He looked more surprised, pushing his floppy hair out of his eyes, half-hidden behind black-framed glasses. ‘Why?’

‘I’ve been trying her since Saturday. Got to say, the whole thing looked so weird on TV, that horrible body falling down like that! Creepy.’

‘It was a bit odd, yeah.’ He shrugged. ‘Guessing it was just a stupid publicity stunt for the Awards Best Book that went tits up. Not that we ever found out what that book was, actually -’

‘Maybe.’ Clara leaned on the kitchenette wall. ‘And did you go partying, after?’

‘Not really. Me and Violet got a cab with Dex and Savannah.’ Ishan chose the blue coffee pod – the strongest – and slotted it in the machine. ‘Oh, and Jackson Rayne.’

‘What’s he like?’ Clara was intrigued, despite herself.

‘Like, a bit... full of himself? Handing out fifty-pound notes like sweets. I dunno, there was kind of an off vibe in the cab. Then Dex went home – said he had a headache, but I reckon he’d probably just had enough of Rayne.’

‘And what did you do?’

‘Me and Vi went to that new Buzzy Bar in Soho. Maude was there, and some of her mates, and Phil from IT. D’you know him? Right laugh.’

‘Vaguely, when he came to help Tom with his laptop once, maybe.’ Clara was always so busy recently, she didn’t often seem to mix with colleagues from different departments. ‘Did you stay long?’

‘I stayed till closing, but Violet said she wasn’t feeling well.’ He added hot water. ‘I think she left about half hour after we got there.’

‘I can’t imagine how awful she’ll feel about Dex,’ Clara felt a lump in her throat, but she couldn’t cry here – it was too unprofessional. ‘It’s so hard to believe, I can’t really get my head round it.’

‘Yeah, super sad.’ Ishan looked like he was going to say something else, then stopped. ‘Make you one?’

‘Oh. Yes, thanks.’ Clara hated coffee, but she passed him another cup for the machine. What had he meant about Violet being poorly?

‘I saw...’ Ishan started to speak before she could ask, then he hesitated again. ‘Sorry. That weird List online. You’re on it?’

‘Ha! Thanks for reminding me.’ Clara tried to look cool. She didn’t feel very cool about it though; she felt downright rattled.

‘It’s obviously just a crackpot though, isn’t it?’ He pressed the coffee button again as the internal Tannoy chimed. ‘Who wrote the list, I mean.’

‘Can all editorial staff gather in the Boardroom at 12 p.m.,’ an HR minion’s voice droned, ‘to pay respects to our colleague Dex Harris. The weekly acquisitions meeting has been moved to 1.30 p.m.’

‘Good to know a bit of death affects nothing here.’ Ishan ran a hand through his thick hair ‘til it stood on end. ‘Bloody Langleys. Can’t say I feel like discussing sales targets today.’

‘No,’ Clara replied dolefully. ‘Me neither.’

She still didn’t know where Violet was, and she was starting to have a very bad feeling about it.

CHAPTER 20

SAVANNAH: MONDAY MORNING

Savannah spent most of Monday morning asleep, having swallowed two strong sleeping pills on top of the paramedic's sedative, after tossing and turning for hours. She'd hidden them in a drawer before jetting off to rehab, aware one never knew where the next crisis was coming from.

Every time Savannah woke, Dex's face swam in front of her, and she clutched her tiny dog, shutting her eyes tight against the reality of her lover's death. But in the early hours, lying alone in the giant bed they'd shared so briefly, the finality of it hit her like a juggernaut: not only had the best and kindest man she'd ever dated just died, but worse than that – he'd actually *chosen* to. And now, Maria had brought a message saying the police wanted to talk to her – which meant what, exactly? That they thought she knew something about his death?

Or that she'd actively encouraged him to die?

It was unbearable.

At last, though, Savannah gave in to her needs and got up. She was only human after all, and even she got hungry and thirsty. Trailing downstairs, she found both her iPhone mailbox full, and her landline answerphone flashing: tens, if not hundreds, of messages – from friends, old acquaintances, and some Langley colleagues, commiserating. Less sympathetic were messages from both Ruth and also their boring brother, Miles, the Langley COO.

'Mrs Savannah,' the housekeeper interrupted Savannah's trawl through her sympathy messages. 'The young lady yesterday left you note.'

'This?' Savannah turned it over to see the note was written on one of her own smart cards, her name embossed in swirly black font at the top.

She gazed at Violet's handwriting: large and neat, childish even. 'How did she get one of my cards?'

'I give it to her, Mrs Savannah.' A fleet of emotions crossed Maria's face: anxiety, then something like stubbornness. 'She was crying, poor thing. So sad about Mr Dex.'

Savannah felt yet another lurch of guilt. So many feelings coming thick and fast were alarming. But she'd always been a real empath, she reminded herself. 'It's okay,' she reassured the housekeeper. 'Can I get a macchiato, please? Super strong. And get one for you, too.' She patted Maria's arm, and Maria looked at her hand like it was about to bite her. *Honestly, staff!*

Savannah sat on the breakfast-bar stool and read the card.

'Dear Ms Langley,

Please can you call me ASAP? I think I might know what happened to Dex and I'm really scared. Call any time, Violet 079887666533

At the bottom of the card, a tiny PTO was scrawled....

'PS I think you might be in danger yourself! Please take care!!'

What the hell? Holding the card, Savannah retreated to her giant sofa as the landline began to ring. Lying down, she ignored it.

'Mrs Savannah?' Maria disrupted her respite. 'Is your sister, Ruth.'

'No way,' Savannah hissed, flapping a hand at her housekeeper. 'I'm out.' Too late, the phone was in her hand.

'I heard that. Where are you?' her older sister demanded. 'You should be here, in the office, to instruct your team.'

'My fiancé has literally just died, Ruth,' Savannah snapped. 'I'm taking the rest of the bloody week off. Read your own employee handbook. I'll send Ish a directive to divvy up projects.'

'You're on the board; you don't count as an employee. And we've got a major problem.'

'I don't care about your problems, right now. I'm bereaved.'

'I know. And it's your problem actually that I'm talking about.' Ruth's sigh was weary. 'You were very stupid on Saturday night.'

'I don't need reminding, thanks.' Savannah tried to peer into the kitchen without moving from the sofa. An actual bell to summon her housekeeper had seemed a bit too *Downton Abbey*, but at times like this, when she was literally dying for her coffee and green smoothie, it would be super handy...

'Maybe not,' Ruth cut across her thoughts, 'but the evidence exists.'

'What do you mean?' Suddenly alert, Savannah sat up.

'I think someone else might have seen the footage. Of you and your... friend.'

'The CCTV? Of me and...?' Savannah was so horrified, she couldn't speak for a second. 'Of me and Jackson? How the actual fuck, Ruth?' She thought of catching her sister's eye yesterday in the office. 'I thought you would delete it -'

'Yugi's wiped it, but it was on the company CCTV, because of your own stupidity, Savannah. Plus, the police have demanded access to the system. I can't be seen to tamper with something if they know it exists. And given I received an email this morning that's a little worrying, it's not good. If you'd done a bit less partying, we mightn't be in this mess.'

'Gah!' Savannah threw herself backwards on the sofa so hard, the Chihuahua let out a yelp. 'What kind of email, for God's sake?'

'And it's getting worse.' Ruth said, ignoring her.

'How can it possibly be worse than this?' Savannah groaned.

‘Penguin are making a bid for Jackson Rayne. Dex was in the middle of negotiating his new contract, so we’re vulnerable. Curtis Brown are not returning my calls today, and Penguin are pulling out all the stops. We can’t afford to lose him *and* Dex– it’ll look terrible. The other authors will get cold feet.’

‘Is that all?’ But fear clutched at Savannah as she saw Violet’s note on the coffee table. Why the hell hadn’t she let her in last night? It was stupid; she should have welcomed the pathetic little thing, and had a proper chat.

‘You might be in danger!’ she re-read. What on earth did Violet know that she didn’t?

‘You tell me if that’s all.’ There was a clang: Ruth slamming a drawer shut. ‘You’re just lucky the police haven’t seen you and Jackson in the boardroom yet. You need to be straight with me, for once.’ Ruth’s sigh was gusty. ‘What exactly did you do to Dex? And more importantly—’

‘I didn’t *do* anything to him.’ But anxiety consumed Savannah.

‘Be honest – do you need a lawyer?’

‘What the hell, Ruth? All I need now is to start planning Dex’s funeral.’ But Savannah remembered the policeman’s words, and the young woman’s desperate face last night on her front gate video – and a ghost walked over her grave, as her old nan in South London might have said.

‘Do you know where Dex’s phone is?’ she asked. ‘Was it in his office?’

‘Not that I’ve heard, but he probably had it on him, don’t you think?’

‘I don’t know.’ Something was going on here that Savannah didn’t understand.

As she hung up, distraught, the call of the diazepam from upstairs had rarely been louder. She needed to find Dex’s phone and go through it; it was where he kept every single note and secret in his life. Only then might she start to get some answers. And she had the feeling that if she didn’t get to

grips with it pretty smartish, she was going to be in even worse trouble than she already was.

CHAPTER 21

CLARA: MONDAY, MIDDAY

To reach the biggest Langley boardroom on the second floor, the whole company had had to file past Dex Harris' empty office. It was still in darkness, the internal blinds firmly shut like dead eyes and, even though she'd kept her own gaze firmly averted, Clara could still feel the shivers down her spine as she entered the boardroom.

Far more crowded than she'd ever seen it, the staff stood two-deep at all sides of the room, the air strangely expectant; heavy with the scent of white lilies in huge glass vases. Clara shuffled into a corner, searching the faces for Violet, but there was still no sign. But then Clara expected her friend would have taken Dex's death incredibly hard. Maybe she'd been given compassionate leave...

Surprise rippled through the crowd as the company's Chief Operating Officer Miles Langley walked in. Rarely seen on the editorial floor, Miles didn't sweep into the room, but sort of clip-clopped in on bandy legs: a weedy-looking man with not much chin: the Langley who'd inherited none of his mother, the first Mrs Langley's looks, nor any of his dad George's bullish vitality. What he lacked in physical stature, though, Miles made up for by being ultra-slimy.

'I thought Sebastian was coming,' someone murmured. 'But he's still abroad.' Along with Bella, Sebastian Langley was one of the two Langley siblings Clara had never spotted in the offices. She'd only ever seen them in pictures or, usually in Sebastian's case, celebrity Instagram feeds.

'Shame,' a young blonde PR assistant murmured to her neighbour; both part of the toxic group Clara and Violet had secretly named 'The Henriettas'. 'Seb Langley is so hot.'

‘Emily!’ Henrietta number two jabbed her mate in the ribs. ‘Shush, babe.’

Exhibiting a bit of decorum, Clara thought drily, considering the news.

‘Welcome, all.’ Miles looked around from his position at the head of the long, polished table, his smile forced. ‘I know you’re all as devastated as we, the Langley board, are about Dex Harris’ untimely death. One of our literary family and a truly inspired editor. Please, let’s all take a minute to remember dear Dex.’

The room fell unnervingly silent. As the uncomfortable tension rose, Clara found herself again wishing Violet was here, for the solidarity.

‘So...’ Miles broke the silence after about twenty-three seconds, according to the wall clock. ‘We’ll keep you posted about the memorial service. I’m sure you’ll all want to attend. Still,’ Miles bestowed another mirthless smile on the packed room. ‘I also know you won’t hesitate to keep doing your best work, for Dex’s sake.’

God, was he way off-key. Violet would have agreed, but Clara’s immediate neighbours inclined their heads, as if in church.

‘Even if Langley & Co. will be much poorer without our good friend.’

It’ll be even poorer if Jackson Rayne dies too, Clara thought, digging her nails into her own palm to stop thoughts about the List spiralling. Still, she felt the nerves in her belly as she cast her eyes around the room. What if the instigator was here, right now? What if the person who wanted to harm her was standing right beside her? What if they had a... a knife, or a gun or...

But she mustn’t give into stupid trolls, because, surely, that was their aim.

‘Those who reported to Dex,’ Miles was saying now, ‘you will report to Dodo Evans now.’ A cheery redhead with a retro pudding-basin haircut stuck her hand up in greeting. ‘Thanks, Dodo. More soon.’

*

As she left the meeting, Clara could see the Henriettas giggling with Maude in front of her, their shiny heads in a cluster.

‘And then he chucked her knickers onto the—’ Maude dropped her voice to whisper something, making the other girls all squeal in outrage.

‘No way!’ the girl called Emily groaned in delight.

‘What’s so funny?’ Clara couldn’t help herself.

‘Haven’t you heard?’ Another blonde Henrietta smirked. ‘Savannah and a bloke we’re guessing we might just recognise.’

‘Who?’

‘Shush. Gossip is undignified,’ Maude wagged a finger at the Henrietta, who carried on regardless.

‘Caught on CCTV on Saturday night, in the boardroom.’

‘Doing what?’ Clara blinked, her brain turning to mush.

‘Shagging, love,’ the other girl stage-whispered. ‘But God, I totally would, wouldn’t you? If it *is* Jackson Rayne, I’m jealous. He’s got mad rizz.’

Clara blushed – an unappealing habit; she must work on her self-confidence.

‘Mad rizz? Don’t be a tit, Henrietta, Rayne’s a chav.’ Maude looked up from filing her one naked nail, the other nine talons encased in tiger-skin acrylic. Her eyes swept over Clara. ‘I recognise you. Clara, isn’t it?’

‘Ooh, are you the one on the List?’ The Henriettas’ eyes widened.

‘Yes,’ Clara was tempted to sweep a mock bow. ‘The very same.’

‘Clara Voss. Hmm, that reminds me.’ Maude flicked her nail file at the air. ‘Ruth wants to see you – like, now.’

‘Ruth Langley?’ Clara’s heart nearly stopped. ‘Why?’

‘You’ll have to wait and see,’ Maude levelled her brown-eyed gaze at Clara. ‘Take the private lift from reception. I’d seriously suggest you’re not late.’

‘And I’d suggest you watch your back,’ said a Henrietta, and they all collapsed into delighted giggles.

CHAPTER 22

SAVANNAH: MONDAY AFTERNOON

When Savannah spotted an unmarked Audi saloon outside her long front garden, she slammed her bedroom door against whatever was coming. Ignoring the chirrup of her phone, she flung herself on her bed. She was in mourning: real life could wait.

Except it couldn't apparently, because, within minutes, Maria was calling her urgently. 'Mrs Savannah!'

Savannah stuck her head under the pillow. Why did people keep bothering her?

'Mrs Savannah.' the housekeeper tapped gingerly on her door. 'Mr Detective Addo is down the stairs.'

'Gah.' Savannah got back off the bed and straightened her silky dressing gown. They could take her as they found her, she thought, though she did a quick makeup check in the gold Louis XIII mirror – picked up for (almost) a song at a Chelsea auctioneer on Lots Road. And thank God for lash extensions. Feeling slightly more prepared, Savannah strolled down the curving stairwell as casually as she could.

'Officers.' Beneath the tiny bit of cleavage she let show, her heart sped up at the sight of two frosty-looking men. It was almost as if she was actually guilty of something. 'Can I help you?'

'Ms Langley.' DS Addo looked more beaten up than he had the previous day, and even less friendly – if that was humanly possible. Today, he'd brought an accomplice: a young man with acne scars and slicked-back blond hair who, from his incredulous open mouth, looked like he'd never been somewhere so plush. 'Sorry to bother you, but we have a few questions.'

'Fine.' She swept in front of them. 'Maria will bring coffee.'

‘We’re good, thanks.’ As they followed Savannah into her newly decorated sitting-room, with its Philippe Starck mirrors and hand-painted floral wallpaper, the little Chihuahua took one look at the two men and slunk under the sofa.

‘Ms Langley.’ DS Addo sat on the very edge of a loveseat, dwarfing it. ‘I’ll get straight to the point, if I may.’

‘Which is what?’ Savannah switched on the huge, simulated wood fire, the elegant flames licking its granite surround. ‘Do share.’

‘I’d like you to look at a photo, please.’ He stretched out a hand for the tablet his colleague held.

‘You don’t mean of...’ An image of her beloved Dex flashed through Savannah’s mind. ‘Not of Dex?’ Her eyes were swimming again. She usually prided herself on never crying; the last time she’d had was when her Pekinese dog Binkie had died a few years back. But this was far far worse.

‘No, ma’am, of course not,’ the policeman assured her. ‘We just need to know if you recognise an item from the scene.’

‘An item?’ Squinting at the screen, she saw a long thin scarf that she didn’t recognise – white, with a vibrant bright green and red graphic pattern.

‘So,’ DS Addo prompted. ‘Does it belong to you?’

‘God, no.’ She’d rather die than wear something so foul. Returning the tablet, she turned away to surreptitiously wipe her damp nose on her hand. Her mother would have kittens if she saw her. ‘It’s hideous.’

‘Have you seen it before?’ Addo was trying – and almost failing – to be patient.

‘No.’ She frowned. ‘I don’t think so. Why?’

‘Because it was around Dex Harris’ neck when he died.’ The policeman was blunt. ‘And though you say you don’t recognise it...’ The man paused, maybe for dramatic effect. ‘Your initials are sewn into the edge.’

‘Mine?’ Savannah snapped to attention. ‘But as I said, I’ve never seen it before.’

‘Yes, I heard you. The other thing is...’ Addo cleared his throat. ‘We understand you were with another man on Saturday night.’

‘You knew that already, though?’ Savannah’s internal alarm was ringing. ‘I was entertaining Dex’s top author, Jackson Rayne. It was work.’

‘Is that what you call it?’

Was he trying to be funny? But the man was stony-faced.

‘Yes, I do call it work.’ *Please God, let the Langley Head of Security have done his job*; though if these two idiots had seen her on the boardroom table, she’d bet they’d got their rocks off. She’d never had a sex tape leaked, though it might not be all bad; her old pal Paris Hilton’s did wonders for her image...

‘Ms Langley?’

‘Sorry.’ Savannah forced herself back to the moment. ‘Jackson Rayne is one of Langley & Co.’s most prized assets, so we take good care of him.’

‘Did the two of you have anything to do with Dex Harris’ death?’

‘Are you joking?’ Though obviously it wasn’t the least bit funny. Still, she gathered he hadn’t seen the footage; he’d surely have said so.

‘No, I’m deadly serious.’ Addo looked calm but sweaty, probably because of the giant fire in the room.

‘So, hang on...’ Strangely, now the cop had named his suspicion, Savannah felt a bit calmer. ‘Are you accusing me of something?’ She stood to adjust the flames, allowing her bare thigh to emerge from the gown.

‘Not yet, no, Ms Langley,’ he said. ‘But we’ve established your scarf was round his neck—’

‘My scarf? Do you seriously think I strung poor Dexy up?’ Her horror was genuine. ‘That’s ridiculous! I mean, I’m strong—’ Her PT would attest to that, not that she’d want him to in this instance. ‘—But I’m not *that* strong.’

‘That’s as may be, but we also know you weren’t alone—’

‘But why would I kill my fiancé?’ Suddenly desperate for a cigarette, Savannah opened the jade cigarette box. She’d given up smoking last summer, but luckily, two old Vogues lay inside. ‘Do you mind?’ She didn’t care if they did, but she was exceedingly well brought up, if nothing else.

‘Your house, your lungs.’ DS Addo shrugged. ‘You were saying?’

‘Please listen to me.’ Carefully, she picked up her father’s big onyx and gold lighter; its solid weight reassuring to her. ‘I really thought Dex was *the one*.’ Yet again, her eyes filled with annoying tears. ‘We had great sex and great fun, we were planning a summer wedding, and I couldn’t wait to have his babies.’ Her voice broke for a second. ‘So why the hell would I kill him?’ She lit the cigarette and inhaled slowly. ‘I definitely didn’t need his money.’

‘Because you had your eye on that other geezer? Because you’d had a terrible row? Because Mr Harris was jealous? There could be any number of reasons we don’t know about.’

Nicotine flooded her head. ‘Dex and I never rowed.’ Not strictly true, but they didn’t need to know that. ‘And he wasn’t jealous, ever.’ Which *was* true – as far as she knew, anyway.

‘This Jackson Rayne, he’s ex-SAS, isn’t he?’ The younger guy spoke now, his voice very soft. ‘And he writes about death, all the time.’

‘So did Agatha Christie, but she never offed anyone, did she?’ Savannah levelled her gaze at the blond policeman. ‘Not as far as I know.’

‘Rayne has, though, hasn’t he? He’s killed lots of people, according to his biography. Seen all sorts on the battlefield.’

‘You tell me.’ Savannah inhaled again, thought *this fag tastes disgusting* and killed it in the Conran ashtray, kept for her many gold rings.

‘But you publish him, Ms Langley. You should know, surely?’

‘If Jackson has killed people, it was obviously for the good of the United Kingdom.’ The fact neither man had succumbed to her charms made Savannah just want them out of her house, now. ‘But he’s not my business.’

‘In what sense, not your business?’

‘I’m Langley’s Communications Director. I wine and dine authors, sure, and I help them stay on brand, but I have nothing to do with their writing.’ She stood, still lightheaded from the tobacco. ‘If you’re basing this... *allegation* on a scarf with my initials on it that was...’ she faltered, ‘was anywhere near Dex when he died, that’s just stupid. His death was nothing to do with me.’ Not true, given his suicide note, but she didn’t kill him with her own two hands. ‘He took his own life.’

‘So the fact you were with another man – a man connected to Dex Harris – and the fact your scarf was used... All just circumstantial?’

‘Totally. And if darling Dex did kill himself because of me, well, I’m going to have to live with that, aren’t I?’ She stalked to the door, nearly tripping over the still-shaking Kylie. ‘If that’s all, gentlemen...’

‘It isn’t all, Ms Langley.’ DS Addo stood, the younger man unfolding himself to follow. ‘Because it doesn’t look like it was suicide that killed Dex Harris.’

‘What d’you mean?’ Savannah gazed at them, and suddenly she felt as shaky as the Chihuahua.

‘It means...’ Did Addo actually look pleased with himself? ‘It means, Dex Harris’s death is starting to seem very much like murder.’

CHAPTER 23

CLARA: MONDAY AFTERNOON

God only knew what Ruth Langley wanted with her, Clara thought, making her way to reception to take the special private lift operated by security; a lift that only went to Ruth's office.

Clara had been in it once before, but she was still very wary of Ruth. Honestly, she thought, waiting with the guard, life felt very disorienting, right now – and on top of everything else, she was probably about to get murdered by some lunatic who'd got it in for her, for some reason she didn't understand. Along with Adam's weird behaviour, things couldn't get much more stressful.

It didn't help that Clara had no clue what she had in common with the rest of the List.

'You can't publish lies!' A wide-eyed teenager with ratty hair and a long, once-white dress was suddenly yelling in the middle of the atrium. 'You must listen now, before it's too late for you all...Leila Monroe is a liar!'

"Scuse me -' The security guard rushed over to the barefoot girl as the special lift pinged open, and Ruth's assistant Maude emerged.

'God Squad?' Maude pulled a face at the shrieking girl.

'Don't know. Who's Leila Monroe?'

'The lifestyle influencer? But oh my days, you'll never guess - Ruth's just had the police on the phone *again*. This is getting out of hand.'

The excitement in Maude's tone took Clara aback. 'What's happened?'

'Don't tell anyone, but...' Maude lowered her voice. 'Do you remember that Dex bought his team handprinted, Liberty print scarves last Christmas? With everyone's individual initials on?' She made a sad face. 'He had them hand-stitched in gold on the corners.'

‘Monogrammed scarves?’ All Clara had received was a Christmas card from her old boss, Tom Arden. ‘I don’t, but how lovely.’

‘Well, not that lovely, because get this: apparently, Savannah’s scarf was around Dex’s neck when he died. It was what he used to *do the deed*. Or...’ Maude trailed off, eyes wide.

‘Or what?’

‘Or what *she* used,’ Maude murmured.

‘What *who* used?’ Clara stared at her. ‘What are you saying?’

But reception was suddenly full of the sound of pinging phones, at the same time as the filthy girl broke away from the guard. ‘Don’t believe Langley & Co.!’ she screamed, her dress flapping round her bare ankles.

‘That’s enough, love.’ The guard propelled her to the door, where a shaven-headed young man waited, equally dirty-looking. ‘Out you go.’

‘Don’t trust the capitalists,’ the girl shouted as he dragged her. ‘Purify your soul with us, the Children of Bliss.’

‘The Children of who?’ Clara frowned, worrying about the grasp of the guard. ‘He’s being a bit rough, isn’t he?’

‘I wouldn’t worry about it. These sort of nutty protestors are pretty standard here,’ Maude pulled a face. ‘Losers.’

As the girl was ejected, two young editorial assistants came in the main revolving door – both staring so hard at their phones, they trotted straight out again without realising. In the foyer, a small group of staff was gathering, staring at something she couldn’t see.

‘What’s everyone looking at?’ Maude frowned. ‘My phone’s upstairs -’

Together the two young women hurried to the doors, peering out at the electronic billboard on the corner opposite the Langley building.

‘Oh my gosh!’

Right there in front of them was a huge and unflattering photo of Savannah Langley, with faint black eyes, coming out of a smart white building. Over it, the words were superimposed

THE LIST: Updated 03.11.25

For those who never, ever listen:

Look no further than a Langley

‘Ha, God!’ Maude exclaimed. ‘Looks like sexy Savvi’s on the List along with you too -’

‘Hang on, is this what you meant, just now?’ Clara asked slowly, gazing up at the picture of the gorgeous Comms Director. ‘That Savannah Langley killed Dex?’

‘I don’t know for sure, but...’ Maude looked almost triumphant as she turned away from the doors, ‘it’s certainly starting to look that way. Don’t you think?’

CHAPTER 24

SAVANNAH: MONDAY AFTERNOON

'I don't understand. What does that mean, not suicide?' Savannah turned to the cops, feeling shaken. 'And why didn't you say straight away?'

'We can't tell you anything else now, sorry.' But Addo's face displayed absolutely no remorse. 'We're still waiting for the full autopsy report, but there's enough evidence to suggest Mr Harris didn't die by his own hand.'

'Jesus.' Savannah sat down again, her legs like jelly as the policeman's phone pinged. At a leisurely pace, he opened a message.

'Fascinating.' Addo showed his colleague, whose eyebrows shot up his scarred forehead.

'What is?' Savannah was increasingly irritated. 'Do share, please.'

'The List. It's been updated.'

'So?' she snapped.

'Have a look.' DS Addo flicked the screen towards her. 'It seems to suggest you're untrustworthy, Ms Langley.'

To her horror, there was Savannah's photo, coming out of her plastic surgeon's with faint bruises after her most recent eye-lift; wearing that nasty grey jumpsuit she'd given to charity, weeks ago – the one that made her look like a small elephant. A terrible picture, and all over the web now, no doubt. Savannah blew her cheeks out in frustration.

The policeman walked around the huge coffee table to the glass doors that led to the garden. 'You a keen gardener, Ms Langley?'

'Oh yes,' she lied automatically. The garden she rarely ventured into was not at its best right now, and she hadn't been outside for months, except to use the hot tub with Dex. Today it was covered over, the dead leaves strewn over it a reminder of everything she'd just lost. But appearing wholesome seemed important, all things considered.

‘You don’t look the type, if you don’t mind me saying.’

‘Really? I *love* the garden.’ Her sangfroid was melting faster than a snowman in hell; she was starting to feel like she’d done something far worse than just sleeping with Jackson while Dex suffered alone. If only she’d gone home with Dex, he’d still be here now, and that was a mistake she could never fix. ‘I’m out there all the time,’ she continued brightly.

‘So, that’s yours, is it?’ DS Addo pointed at a trug of garden equipment on the oak table outside – full of stuff her gardener used for the roses.

‘The basket thingy? Of course.’ She remembered absently Dex suggesting they get landscapers in the new year; now she’d be spending it alone. Or in jail, if these guys had anything to do with it.

‘Can I take a look?’

‘Be my guest.’ Addo pushed open the doors, and an arctic blast made her shiver as he stepped onto the decking. ‘I love my roses,’ she said virtuously. ‘I’ve always had green fingers.’ But only if she was wearing Chanel’s Artiste Green polish, she didn’t add. Truly, she wouldn’t know how to tend to any plant if it gave her personal instructions, but she was damned if she let this detective person know; she had a good impression to maintain.

The policeman leaned over the trug and, wrapping a tissue round his own fingers, swiped something from inside. He studied it for a minute, before striding back, holding the object between two fingers like a small trophy.

Savannah could see it was a roll of garden wire, bought by her gardener; probably to tie up the wild roses she was so partial to.

‘And this is yours too?’

‘Sure.’ Savannah felt like she was sleepwalking into dangerous waters. ‘I use it to bind the roses up when they get too heavy.’

‘Bind them up?’ Blond boy smirked at her.

‘Very interesting,’ DS Addo said. ‘We found a similar roll in your fiancé’s office.’ His smile was almost smug. ‘I’m going to inform you now, Ms Langley, I’ll be applying for a search warrant as soon as possible. Unless of course, you let me search the property now.’

‘But I’m not under arrest?’

‘No.’

‘Then you can put that down, and I’ll see you out.’ Savannah walked them both to the front door. ‘Oh, and do you have Dex’s phone?’

‘No.’ He met her look. ‘I was going to ask you the same. And we’ll need access your CCTV, too.’

‘It’s not linked up yet, sadly, it was only just installed.’

‘Handy.’

‘I hope you’re not insinuating something, Mr Addo? Thanks so much.’ Closing it firmly behind them, Savannah leaned on the door, thinking. Then she hauled out her own mobile, and read the stupid new post from *@TheRealDexHarris*, screwing up her face at the photo of her.

She thought about the picture of the scarf they’d just shown her, and somewhere deep down, a memory flickered. She had an idea that Dex had bought his team these scarves last Christmas, and maybe he’d given her one too. One she’d hated so much, she’d left it in her desk at work.

She gazed up at the CCTV camera outside, that Dex had paid thousands for, installed about a fortnight ago. She really must get it working – especially now she was on the List too.

As the two policemen got in their car out on the street, Savannah made a phone call, her hand shaking.

‘That lawyer you mentioned,’ she exhaled unsteadily when Ruth answered. ‘Is Carl Carrington in town? I think I might need him, now.’

Hanging up, she went back upstairs, and into the walk-in wardrobe where Dex had hung his suits. Taking a deep breath, she began to search Dex's pockets. His phone must be here somewhere, surely? And if not, there must be some clue, somewhere, to Dex's fate.

And if there wasn't, she needed to track down Violet; to find out why she'd come to the house – and what exactly was the danger she'd mentioned.

Savannah needed to find that out, before it was too late for her – in more ways than one.

CHAPTER 25

CLARA: MONDAY EVENING

By the end of Monday, Clara's meeting with Ruth had been postponed so many times, Clara's head was spinning; the latest instruction was to report to Maude in the morning, to see if Ruth could 'squeeze her in'.

Squeeze me in to do what, though? Clara wondered grimly, knowing it meant another night of troubled sleep. On top of which, she was behind with work – the edits for *The Stalker*, the first psychological thriller she'd commissioned, were due, but she was too tired to concentrate.

Clara knew she and Ruth had a sort of unspoken understanding after what they went through together the spring before last, but she also knew the Langley family were a wilful lot. Ruth had a work ethic stronger than a Trojan warrior, and was renowned for putting business before anything else. If Clara had done something to upset Ruth, she'd be straight out on her ear, shared history or not.

On the bus home, Clara had just perched beside a woman shovelling a packet of crisps in like she was starving, when Clara's phone rang.

'Violet!' As her friend's name flashed up, Clara fumbled to answer as fast as she could. 'Are you alright?'

'I'm—' someone started to say, but almost immediately, the voice faded out.

'Violet?' Clara couldn't hear anything, apart from the wind blowing down the line. 'Is that you?' she said insistently, but the call cut out. Clara rang the number straight back, but as soon as the phone was answered, Clara was hurled straight into the wind tunnel again.

'Violet?' Was that sobbing she could hear? 'Violet, are you okay?' she begged urgently. 'What's wrong? Where are you?'

'I need your help—' More distant sobbing. 'He's—'

‘He’s what?’ Terrified, Clara stood up, knocking her neighbour’s crisps down her front. ‘Where are you?’ she repeated frantically as the woman glowered at her.

‘She’s—’ But the line turned so static, Clara couldn’t make out the words. She strained until she heard it, very faintly: ‘—the sea. It’s so scary—’

‘I can’t hear you properly.’ Clara jammed one finger in her other ear as she lurched into the bus’s aisle. She wasn’t even sure it was Violet.

‘Can you speak up? Is it Violet?’

‘No need to shout, love.’ A bald man in a tracksuit smirked. ‘Give us a smile, darlin’. You’re too cute to be cross!’

‘Oh no!’ The voice was shouting now. ‘Clara, it’s too late, he’s not what he—’ More static hiss broke up the line. ‘Please help, he’s going to kill—’

Then the call cut out again.

CHAPTER 26

SAVANNAH: MONDAY EVE

A search of all Dex's pockets turned up a receipt or two Savannah didn't recognise; a book of matches from The Paris Ritz; a stick of chewing-gum. But in the inner pocket of his navy Ralph Lauren blazer, her hand alighted on a scrap of paper, folded tightly. Opening it, Savannah's pulse quickened as she read, scrawled in blue biro capitals,

U ARE GORGEOUS. LET ME SHOW U HEAVEN.

Her heart flipped over. Who was the recipient or sender of this?

Sitting on their giant bed, exhausted by grief, Savannah texted Violet's number - but the message didn't go through. She tried WhatsApp; one single grey tick. *Hmmm.*

The lawyer Carl Carrington hadn't been in touch yet, and Savannah was starting to feel horribly trapped. With a lurching stomach, she typed her own name into Google – and then wished she hadn't. Social media was awash with bitchy comments:

You get what you get when you don't work 4 it #Nepobaby

And online press sites featured delightful headlines like:

Agatha Christie plots got nothing on this mess!

Worse than Succession - drama @Langley & Co!

or

Publishing heiress's fiancé dead – foul play? beside a photo of her and Dex exiting Scotts in Mayfair, her huddled in a fur, his arms around her.

God, how happy she'd been back then; not a care in the world -

Savannah was the only person right now who knew for sure she was innocent – and she also knew how fast gossip travelled in the publishing world. Plus, however hard she denied any involvement with Dex's death, she'd grown up used to being disbelieved.

‘Savannah just made it up,’ her twin Bella had often claimed when they were kids – which, to be fair, had quite often been true. Sometimes it wasn’t a bad thing – like the terrible time Miles and Sebastian had lured the twins down into the old icehouse on their dad’s estate, locked the grill, and left them. Stuck in the dank, pitch-black tunnel, freezing and petrified of the scuffling and scampering around their feet, Savannah had improvised a story for Bella: a voyage on a spice ship in the Indian Ocean, which calmed Bella until a rat bit her finger – whereupon both girls became so hysterical, their smirking older brothers let them out again.

But Savannah’s imagination had helped them then, briefly, though it also meant a hatred of dark, enclosed spaces – a phobia the boarding-school bullies took advantage of. It was only when Savannah learned money could help buy safety that things got easier.

Still, who cared if she’d been a bit of a fantasist when she was a kid? She’d never been a liar, and she truly didn’t know why or how Dex had died. All she wanted right now was some relief from these terrible feelings.

‘Stay at home,’ Ruth had instructed Savannah earlier. ‘Don’t be seen in some swanky spa or bar, and do not look like you’re having fun.’

‘Fun?’ Savannah almost laughed. ‘I’m not having any fun, believe me.’

‘Just stay put ’til Carl gets in touch, and I get the PR firm onto crisis management.’

For once, Savannah did what she was told. But Savannah also hated being on her own. She’d always struggled with it – and it was even harder when everything in the house reminded her of her beloved fiancé.

*

Trailing downstairs, she poured herself a small vodka and tonic. But vodka didn’t really count as alcohol, she reminded herself, so she topped it up a

bit. In front of Dex's giant TV, Savannah switched on a true-crime drama about some murderous sisters, which she didn't listen to a word of. She sat, fiddling with her phone until, almost as if her fingers were sleepwalking, she did the thing she'd debated all day.

'Hey! Just wondered how you're doing, all things considered? I'm devastated ☹ also, what do you think about this List? Have you seen it?

Typing the text did make her think how nice it would have been to have heard from Jackson Rayne first – but *c'est la vie*.

Her mum Lissa would say: *men are such Neanderthals, sometimes*, followed by a hoity-toity sniff. *Take the initiative – you always need a man in your life...*

All Savannah craved right now was a bit of comfort: a hug, a soft voice – maybe she should actually call her mum?

Good God, no! her sensible voice screeched, *you'll only be disappointed*. And, anyway, Savannah knew her mum was probably busy playing happy families in the Cotswolds with husband number two, the moody race-horse trainer. But the fact she'd even considered it meant things must be very bad.

Savannah's phone pinged, and she scrabbled to pick it up:

I'm OK ta, shall I cum & keep you company? List is crap, ignore!

Jackson! Ignoring the way he'd spelled 'cum', Savannah typed *yes please* and hovered her finger over the 'send' button. Her schoolmates from Bedales had always said that the only way to get over a man was to get under one... But she couldn't sleep with Jackson again, tonight. Ruth would go mad – and

anyway, Savannah couldn't stomach anyone touching her again, apart from darling Dex.

Reluctantly, she deleted her first message and wrote:

Oo normally that would be lovely! Misery loves company 😊 but my boring big sis says no visitors right now. Sorry ☹

The infamous three dots bubbled up on her screen while she held her breath, and then...

'Like the film Misery? No probs, bin at my c-side place enjoying c air. Keep smiling beautifull 😊

Savannah squinted at his text. Obviously, the weird spelling was a joke.

She checked her message to Violet – still not opened. She tried the number, but it didn't even connect. Hanging up in frustration, Savannah tucked little Kylie under her arm and went upstairs for a bubble bath. It might only be a matter of time before the police returned to read Savannah her rights, so she better enjoy her freedom and privilege now, she thought wryly.

But, as she ran the water as hot as she could bear, Savannah's head kept returning to Violet – regretting her damn stupid decision not to see her when Violet was right there on her doorstep. She texted Ishan, asking him to message Violet and get her to call Savannah ASAP.

Maybe Violet could shine at least a little bit of light on what had happened to Dex, or – and Savannah had to slow her breathing when she thought of this – on why both women were both now on this cursed List.

CHAPTER 27

CLARA: MONDAY EVENING

Unable to reach Violet again, Clara jumped off the bus at the next stop, straight into the driving rain, and dialled 999.

‘Which emergency? Police, fire or ambulance?’

‘I don’t know!’ Clara’s heart was racing; her hair already soaking and plastered to her face. ‘Maybe all of them?’

‘You can only choose one.’

‘I don’t know which one, though -’ Panic rose as she edged under a shop canopy for shelter.

‘I can’t decide for you,’ the bored-sounding operator said.

‘Police, then.’ It was the most obvious decision – but when Clara got through to the police operator, he said they couldn’t do anything without an idea of Violet’s location.

‘Can’t you find her from my phone? Like, location drop?’ Clara’s teeth were chattering with cold and adrenaline, the rain slanting and insistent, despite the canopy.

‘I’m sorry, but it’s not that simple in real life,’ the operator said. ‘I’ve made a note of her name, but any more info and I suggest you go to your nearest police station to report it. Can you do that?’

‘I guess.’ But Clara still felt horribly worried as she hung up; the fear in the voice on the phone had been all too real.

*

The nearest police station was at Bishopsgate, in among the shiny high-rises of the City’s financial district.

Walking into the station, Clara sat in reception for over ten minutes before she even got the chance to tell the desk sergeant what she'd come about.

'I'll create a case number for you,' the middle-aged woman on the other side of the plexiglass said. She took a note of the call, Clara's concerns and Violet's name and number, though she remained less than warm throughout. 'I've created a file for your friend. Here's your reference number, if you need to follow up. Someone will contact you if we need more info.'

Clara wished she felt an iota of reassurance, but she didn't.

*

Shaking with cold, Clara squelched into the flat, trainers full of water. She'd been hoping Adam might have been there to make a hot cup of tea, at least, but the lounge was in darkness.

In her bedroom, Clara stripped off and wrapped herself in a big towel, rubbing her freezing hands as she tried to get her head straight. If the police couldn't help her find Violet – and they had nothing to go on right now – who could?

Violet's parents were dead, and she had one sister who lived abroad, but Clara had little idea of where exactly: the Middle East, she thought, Dubai maybe. She'd only met Clara's flat-mate once, briefly, and Violet was something of a workaholic; she didn't seem to socialise much. Clara would have asked Dex except – no one was asking Dex anything ever again.

Clara considered her fellow entrants on the List:

Savannah Langley was out: she looked more like a suspect in Dex's death than an innocent victim, though Clara didn't understand how or why. And Clara had never met the gorgeous Savannah properly, despite working

for the same company. She'd seen Savannah in the office, or fetching Dex to go out somewhere, but as a director and board member, Savannah orbited in higher circles than Clara.

What about Jackson Rayne – the infamous thriller writer, also on the List? She'd met him once briefly when she was an intern, but they'd never spoken for longer than a few minutes, and she doubted he'd remember her. Why would he? She felt like maybe she remembered being told he liked the ladies, but he was such a huge deal, and she didn't want to approach him.

So what the hell could she do to help Violet?

Nothing, it seemed. And that left Clara with a terrible feeling that, if Violet didn't turn up immediately, it was going to be too late.

On top of that, if Violet was next on the List, well, surely that meant Clara's card was marked, too?

CHAPTER 28

SAVANNAH: MONDAY EVENING

Lying back in the freestanding copper bath, lavender bubbles up to her ears, Savannah was almost dozing off to the comforting sound of the rain outside when her landline rang.

She pressed the panel attached to her bath that allowed her to screen incoming calls.

'Carl Carrington,' the robot voice announced on the room's inbuilt speakers.

'Hey,' she picked up remotely, more awake now. 'Carl.'

'I'm so sorry for your loss, Savannah.' The lawyer's mellow drawl reverberated round the humid room. 'How are you doing?'

'I've been better, thanks,' she sighed, though hearing Carl's deep voice was immediately soothing. She'd always fancied Carl; gosh, was he handsome, like a young Jamie Foxx but, sadly, she was the wrong sex for him. And he had a super-hot partner, the youngest King's Counsel in town.

'Sorry to be slow,' Carl rumbled. 'I was on my way back from the Berlin office. Ruth said you need help, so I've cleared my diary after lunch tomorrow. Does that work for you?'

'Darling Carl, that would be fantastic,' Savannah was sighing with relief when the bathroom window reverberated with a resounding crack. 'Oh -' her shriek was involuntary. 'What the hell?'

'Savannah?' Carl sounded worried. 'What's going on?'

'I don't know.' She stood up, suds and bath water streaming off her; panicked to see that all the automatic lights had come on in her back garden. 'I think someone's outside.'

‘Where? Do you need help? I can call the police—’ Carl was saying as Savannah stepped out of the bath and grabbed a towel, inching over to peer down into the back garden.

And then a face leered at her, through the first-floor bathroom window – a cruel laughing face with tiny eyes and a huge gaping mouth, and Savannah screamed louder than she’d probably ever screamed before.

Her phone slipped through her fingers, straight into the soapy water, drowning out Carl’s worried voice.

‘I don’t want to die here alone and naked,’ she moaned to herself, but no one was listening except the wind and the rain – and the jeering face at the window.

CHAPTER 29

CLARA: MONDAY EVENING

Clara had just sat down at the kitchen table with a big cup of tea and some buttery toast, and was preparing to make an action plan, when her phone pinged again.

The message was from an unknown number; a digital file attached.

‘WATCH ME NOW!!!’ it instructed.

Blindly, Clara downloaded the file, which appeared to be a video, dated yesterday: *Sunday*, the time stamp: *15.23*.

Against her better instincts, Clara pressed play.

First, a close-up on a train station sign: *Eastbourne Station*. Clara knew Eastbourne was a town on the South Coast, easily accessed from London. She’d never been there, but she’d had a school friend whose grandma lived right by the sea, near the South Downs.

Next, footage of a train pulling in. Commuters disembarked onto the platform, rushing past whoever was holding the camera. Clara squinted at the images until after a minute or so, Violet came into view, hurrying down the platform, very small in her long puffy coat. She looked like she was studying a pale square of something she held in her hand and, as Violet got closer to the camera, Clara guessed it was likely to be a map.

Then another clip: a wooden sort of street sign, saying *Beachy Head*.

Jeez – everyone in Britain knew that name: the most idyllic setting, on top of a set of rugged white cliffs over-looking a perilous stony beach, and the English Channel. Beautiful – and deadly as, sadly, Beachy Head was also renowned as one of the UK’s top suicide spots.

Clara pressed pause for a moment and took a sip of tea. She didn’t want to watch any more, but she felt beholden to Violet so, hand shaking, she took a deep breath, and pressed play again.

The next clip was dated the same day – i.e. yesterday – but it was later, because the sky was much darker. Gradually, as Clara watched, a distant figure came into view, buffeted by the strong winds, walking across a grassy heath towards a bench.

It was still Violet, Clara thought: the same long puffy coat, hood up now, hands in pockets, head down as she sat alone on the bench and got something out to look at – a phone, maybe?

After a minute or two, the little figure stood, looking around her, and then began pacing up and down in front of the bench, the body language suggesting that Violet – if that's who it really was – was waiting for someone. The wind must have been frantic and strong, because it pushed the trees behind the little figure almost to the ground.

But the thing that really freaked Clara out was the way the person kept looking over their shoulder: like they were beyond scared. Who the hell was filming this?

The next clip showed Violet seated on the bench again. Her face was etched with terror as the camera got closer – it was horribly clear that whoever was approaching Violet was someone who scared her.

As Violet stood up, fast, Clara saw her body tense – for a second, frozen, before she began to inch back, too near the edge of the cliffs, and Clara wanted to shout, *No, don't go backwards – watch out!*

But Violet kept stepping back anyway, ever nearer the perilous edge, creeping away from the person coming towards her.

Feeling desperate, Clara leaned forwards, praying she wasn't about to watch Violet go over the cliff edge; her breath was caught in her throat, but before she could see anything more, the picture became a white blizzard.

'No!' shouted Clara, jabbing at the phone, but there was nothing else to see.

CHAPTER 30

SAVANNAH: MONDAY EVENING

Slipping on the shiny marble tiles, a frantic Savannah skidded her way out of the bathroom, across the hall to her bedroom, and slammed her palm against the panic button beside her bed.

Thank Christ she'd listened to her big brother Miles, for once.

The bedside phone rang immediately. 'Mrs Wexford-Langley, are you safe?' a woman asked calmly. 'Or can you get to safety?'

'If I was bloody well safe,' Savannah snapped, 'I wouldn't have pressed the stupid button, would I? And it's Ms Langley now. I'm divorced.'

'Apologies, Ms Langley. I'm dispatching a patrol; they should be there within five minutes.' The voice remained calm. 'While you wait, please lock yourself into the most secure room. I can stay on the phone with you.'

'Okay.' But Savannah didn't know which the most secure room was. She never needed to lock doors normally, and she wished fervently she'd installed the panic room that Miles had also suggested when she bought this place. But it was Miles' fault she didn't have one, because it was he who'd instilled such a hatred of small spaces in her.

And with no panic room, Savannah had to make do with the patronising woman on the end of the line now, waffling on about mindful breathing. Sure, she was doing her best to keep calm as she fumbled for something to wear, but she kept thinking that being murdered when completely naked seemed far worse than being killed when clothed. It wasn't a logical thought, of course, and she'd just managed to get one foot in a trouser leg when there was a loud knock downstairs.

'No way.' Surely that was too fast for the security company? Terrified, Savannah peered down into the front garden.

Below her on the path, in black jeans and a dark Canada Goose jacket, stood the solid breadth of Jackson Rayne.

'Hey.' She tapped the window, the rush of relief intense at the sight of him. 'Jackson, up here.'

He looked up and waved. 'Hey to you too, babe.'

Savannah didn't think she'd ever been so glad to see someone in her whole life. 'Give me two minutes.'

*

'Because I heard the lady loves chocolate.' Jackson mimed a bow as she opened the front door, and handed her a big box of Milk Tray.

'Oh, thanks.' Despite her thumping heart and the fact she'd never eat such cheap chocolate, Savannah was charmed. Honestly, her emotions were all over the place; her pulse still racing from the shock of the face at the window. 'Wasn't expecting you, though...'

'I was passing, on my way into town,' he said, craggy face half-hidden by his five o'clock shadow. 'I don't have to come in, but I just wanted to check you were okay? Such a shit time.'

'You can say that again.' She held the door open. 'Please do come in. I'm glad to see you, actually. I've just had a bit of a shock.'

'Oh? I'm bloody gutted about Dex.' Rayne stepped past her into the hallway. 'Can't believe it.'

'Yes.' She stifled a sob. 'Gutted is about right. Shall we have a drink?' It wasn't a question, and she wasn't interrogating her desire to drink, right now. Needs must.

'Sure. So what's up?' Jackson narrowed his eyes as Savannah directed him to a Heal's armchair. 'You look stressed.'

‘I’m not stressed, darling, I’m petrified.’ Savannah opened the drinks cabinet. ‘I was upstairs in the bath just now, and there was someone at the window.’

‘What window?’ Jackson stood up again, his gaze alert. ‘Let me look.’

‘I was up there.’ She pointed at the ceiling above them. ‘They must have got in the back garden, somehow. I think they were wearing a Halloween mask, something like that. They looked just ghastly.’

‘Stay here and I’ll check outside.’ Jackson strode to the glass doors, just as the front gate buzzed and Savannah pressed the intercom. ‘Hi?’

‘Parliament Security here. That Mrs Langley?’ The guard sounded American. ‘Are you alright, ma’am?’

‘Well, I’m alive.’ She sighed. ‘I’ll buzz you in.’

Opening the front door again, Savannah waited in the porch, watching two uniformed men and a huge Alsatian come up the drive.

‘Ma’am. We’ll need to inspect the grounds immediately,’ the first burly man said. The second followed with the dog, which strained on its lead. ‘If you’re okay, can we check the back garden first, please?’

‘She’s fine.’ Jackson appeared at Savannah’s shoulder. ‘I’m here. And so is she,’ he grinned, pointing at Kylie who’d pattered out, baring her teeth at Jackson, and yapping a warning to the huge dog.

‘There’s a side gate.’ Savannah pointed. ‘But you’ll need it to be unlocked.’

‘I’ll do it. You come with me.’ Jackson led Savannah inside like a child, and she submitted to his calm authority as he settled her and her tiny dog by the fire.

‘You’re an angel, Jackson. There’s a key rack in the utility room, near the back door.’

‘No problem. I’ll keep an eye on these clowns.’ He indicated the security team, and turned the fire up. ‘Stay warm, babe, and relax. You’re safe, now.’

‘Thanks.’ As he zipped his jacket back up and left, Savannah sat shivering; Jackson’s kindness was making her feel teary.

She really mustn’t cry now, she thought, forcing herself up again. Dex’s array of whiskies and rums were in the Art Deco drinks cabinet and the vodka seemed to have run out, so she poured herself a small glass of Havana Gold.

Savannah had never been a brainbox – as a teen, she’d been far more interested in finding escape routes to the nearest nightclubs than in attending school – but she was naturally bright and, unless she was very much mistaken, right now, it seemed like someone wanted to ruin her life.

Swirling the amber liquid in the heavy glass, she tried to think rationally: who was doing this, and why? Or was the more pertinent question *what had she done to deserve this?*

CHAPTER 31

CLARA: MONDAY EVENING

After Clara had watched the horrible clips of Violet standing too near the edge of Beachy Head twice through, she dialled 999 again, her hands trembling with fear, this time.

‘Police, please,’ she said, immediately. ‘My friend is in terrible trouble on Beachy Head,’ she gabbled to the operator. ‘She needs help. I have a reference number.’

But even as she said it, Clara thought, *but the video date was yesterday* – which meant it might be too late, already. Still, Clara was directed to the East Sussex Constabulary; at least someone was finally taking her seriously. A kindly sergeant took her details, along with Violet’s description.

‘But what about this video?’ she croaked. ‘And the phone call?’

‘Send us the digital file, please.’ The sergeant gave her an email address. ‘I promise we’ll follow it up straight away.’

After Clara emailed what she’d been sent, she sat on the sofa, staring blindly at the telly. She ought to haul her laptop out and do some work, but she felt numb, waiting for some sort of news; praying the police – or even better, Violet herself – would call her back.

But... was Violet even alive, anymore?

Her friend was such a sweetheart; so enthusiastic, and full of plans. She hadn’t even minded when Clara got promoted to editor; she said she loved working for Dex. She’d been so supportive when Clara was miserable about her ex; even suggesting and arranging a weekend for the two of them in February next year – a trip to Venice for the Carnival. Violet had seemed eager for a project after a heartbreak of her own that saw her light dimmed for a while, during the summer.

Head in hands, Clara thought back to that time. What did she know about the person who'd hurt Violet so badly? She'd barely spoken about it, apart from one drunken night in a club with the junior editorial team. And to be honest, Clara had still been in such a mess after Sam, she'd been all over the place, herself.

She just about remembered that they'd all been in the club, dancing, when Violet had suddenly got very upset; perhaps from a message on her phone. Clara had gone with her into the ladies', and then ordered an Uber on Violet's phone, to take Violet home. But however hard Clara tried to remember it now, her main memory of that night was drinking far too much on an empty stomach and kissing a guy she'd never met before in a dark corner of the club; a guy she'd not seen since. The whole night was horribly hazy....

But, oh dear, had she missed something important?

Had someone been after Violet – the ex that Clara had never met, but had broken Violet's heart? Surely Violet would have told her, though, or mentioned him again, if that was so.

Huddled in the corner of the old sofa, arms around her knees, Clara thought about her friend. It seemed like she was in terrible danger – or worse... Because who the hell had sent Clara that awful video?

And how did they have *her* email and phone number?

She needed to start getting ahead of the game, but she wasn't sure how, unless...

Heart sinking with exhaustion and fear, Clara knew she needed to get dressed and jump on the first bus to Victoria Station, to catch a train to Sussex. She needed to at least try to find Violet – and soon.

CHAPTER 32

SAVANNAH: MONDAY NIGHT

‘Ms Langley,’ the tall American security guard appeared at the living-room door. ‘Can I ask, is that normally there?’

Savannah peered through the curtains, following his finger to a ladder, leaning against the back wall of her house.

‘My gardener must have left it out,’ she said feebly. But she didn’t remember having seen it when the police had been there, earlier.

‘You should never leave ladders out unattended,’ the security guard was remonstrating as Jackson came back in. ‘It’s tempting to intruders.’

‘I see.’ Savannah’s mind was racing; she’d almost thought she was imagining things, but it seemed there really had been a face at her window.

‘There are footprints in the back flowerbed, by the fence.’ Jackson seemed exhilarated by his search. ‘Either me or the guys should stay.’

The implications of Jackson staying with her this soon after Dex’s death were bad, but she didn’t want to articulate that in front of the security team.

‘Well...’ she began, but thankfully the guard spoke at the same time.

‘A night patrol’s no problem, ma’am. Shall I arrange that?’

‘Please,’ she nodded gratefully. ‘That’d be good, thanks.’

‘And we can verify there’s no intruder here now, ma’am. I understand your CCTV isn’t switched on, do you want me to see to that?’

‘God yes please.’

‘No problem.’ The two men bowed their heads politely, like they were all in *Upstairs, Downstairs*, and left to move their van into her drive.

They parked it behind Dex’s abandoned silver Aston Martin, the sight of which broke Savannah’s heart every time she looked at it.

It had been Dex's beloved toy, but it wasn't going anywhere with him, ever again.

CHAPTER 33

CLARA: MONDAY NIGHT

Online, studying the Eastbourne train timetable and lost in a world of worry about Violet, Clara was almost shocked to hear the front door open.

‘Alright?’ Adam stood in the doorway, his nose pink with cold. Dressed all in black, he swung a carrier-bag that smelled like Chinese takeout from one hand. ‘Wow, you look like a proper drowned rat! And hey, what the hell did you do to get on this Death List?’ Adam looked almost impressed. ‘Did you kill that dude in your office?’

‘It’s not funny,’ Clara said automatically. ‘And actually, no, I’m not very alright.’

‘What’s up?’ Adam threw himself down beside her on the old settee with the busted springs. ‘Wanna share? I over-ordered at Orient’s Best.’

‘Oh, thanks.’ His generosity surprised Clara. He’d been so distant, recently. She was pleased to see him, she realised, looking at his baby face, his attempts at stubble. ‘I wouldn’t say no, actually, if you’ve got enough.’

‘For you, big sister, anything.’ Getting up again, Adam fetched a couple of plates. He seemed upbeat, elated even, humming to himself.

‘Where’ve you been?’ His change in mood intrigued her. ‘Work?’

‘Yeah.’ Taking his jacket off, he chucked it on a chair, something bright trailing from the pocket. Then he set the takeaway containers neatly on the table. ‘And, you know, out and about.’

‘On a date?’ she pointed at his jacket pocket. ‘Were you tying her up?’

‘Clara!’ He looked shocked. ‘That’s a resistance band from the gym, thanks very much. I can help you work on your core, if you like.’

‘No, thanks.’ Absently, she watched him walk back and forth, getting napkins and cutlery, and remembered the horrible comment on the dojo

website she'd read. 'Do you call yourself Adamski online, by the way? Have you been writing awful sexist comments?'

'No?' He pulled a face. 'And that's a stupid name. Adamski? Ha.'

'Ad, your boots are filthy!' Clara noticed a trail of muddy footprints on the threadbare carpet. 'Take them off please, before you get dirt everywhere.'

*

The TV news had been wittering away to itself in the background as they ate, but Clara sat upright when she saw Dex's photo on the screen, turning the volume up in time to catch the newsreader talking about Langley & Co. being one of Britain's top publishing houses.

'That's your company, isn't it?' Adam sat back beside her. 'Langley?'

'Fraid so. It was really weird there today -' A montage of Langley's bestselling authors flashed up.

'This guy's a pretty cool character, isn't he?' Adam said as Jackson Rayne strolled into shot – old footage of the writer about to speak at Oxford's student union.

'Oh, d'you know him?' Clara was surprised by Adam for the second time this evening. 'Have you read his books?'

'Me? No way. But his socials are cool. Look.' Adam grabbed the iPad and swung his socked feet up on the table as he searched Instagram. 'His whole ethos is like, *work hard, and you'll reap the rewards*.'

'What kind of rewards?' Clara peered over her brother's shoulder.

'Oh, you know, the usual. Fit birds, flash holidays and cars, a great life.'

'Fit birds, Adam?' Clara bristled. 'It's not the 1970s.'

'Sure.' He shrugged. 'Nice looking girls.'

Indeed, Jackson Rayne's feed was full of him at book signings or sitting in a red Ferrari; driving a monster truck fast over a bumpy field; snowboarding in Aspen, along with some almost pornographic shots of him topless, chopping wood outside, tagged *#ARealMansWorkIsNeverDone*.

Then there were shots of a sweaty Jackson bench-pressing weights in the gym, with the numbers pinging up the sides, and arm-in-arm with various gorgeous women; a model Clara recognised from a reality show, an actress from a big British soap. The final reels were Rayne exiting a helicopter on top of a London skyscraper, then arriving at the National Book Awards in a black limo.

'Boring!' Clara shook her head. 'I mean, it's all pretty predictable, no?'

'Look at this, though,' Adam scrolled for a bit, then showed Clara a thread where Rayne had liked a load of posts from an account called *@MyPronounsAreEffOff*.

'Jeez, Ad, that's pretty neanderthal.' Clara was really surprised that Dex or Langley & Co. would have let it go. They were hot on their authors' profiles, and expected their employees to avoid expressing any political views.

'Is it, though? He's only saying what we're all thinking.' Adam threw the iPad back on the table, just as Clara's phone began to ring.

She snatched it up. 'Hello?'

'Miss Voss.' It was the police sergeant she'd spoken to earlier. 'I'm so sorry, but would you know who Miss Childs' next of kin is?'

'Me,' Clara said without thinking. Well, it was nearly true. Violet's mum had died two years ago, her dad before she was born; she had the one sister she barely spoke to, who'd lived abroad. 'I mean, I'm definitely her best friend.'

'But – next of kin? Partner? Parents?'

‘No, she has neither. I mean, her parents are dead, and she’s single. Her sister lives in Dubai, I think.’ Clara racked her brain. ‘I vaguely remember an aunt and uncle in York, but I don’t know their names. Why?’

‘Right, then,’ he said. ‘I’ll make enquiries.’

‘Why, though? Clara repeated, her belly flip-flopping. ‘Please, tell me what you know?’

He cleared his throat. ‘I’m very sorry to say the Coastguard notified us earlier that a young female did go over the edge, last night. No body has been found yet, but that’s often the case. The tides are very strong, sometimes bodies are washed up along the coast. Or sometimes, not at all.’

‘Oh God.’ Clara’s blood ran cold.

‘However, I can share that a jacket was found this morning on the clifftop, with ID belonging to Miss Childs in the pocket.’

‘No.’ Clara let out a low groan as Adam gazed at her in consternation.

‘Suffice to say, Miss Voss, I’m sorry to say that it doesn’t look promising, right now.’

CHAPTER 34

SAVANNAH: MONDAY NIGHT

In Savannah's warm and sumptuous living room, her fragrant Rose Diptyque candles throwing beautiful shadows over the hand-painted wallpaper, Jackson poured them both a large glass of red wine from a bottle he'd magicked out of nowhere.

Or rather, from her expensive wine rack, Savannah suspected, looking at the vintage. But that was fine; she was happy to share. She moved nearer the fire, still feeling as if she'd never get warm again.

Jackson must have read her mind, because he put his glass down, and came towards her, opening his strong arms, and after a second's hesitation, she allowed herself to walk into them, resting her head on his shoulder. He stroked her back until she was able to relax more, enjoying the warmth of him; the pure physical connection.

'Savannah,' he said quietly, and leaned in to kiss her. For a few seconds, she kissed him back, feeling his stubble beneath her lips, allowing her body to push against his as she felt a gentle stirring of lust, somewhere deep.

But then the Alsatian barked outside, and a sudden flash of that horrific mask at her window broke the spell.

'I'm so sorry.' Savannah pulled away. 'I don't know what's got into me.'

'Not me, sadly.' He smiled, raising a hand and, surprisingly gently, stroking her hair back from her face. 'Listen, I get it, babe. Dex's death is a huge shock for us both. You must be so incredibly sad.'

'Yes, I am.' Savannah sat back on the sofa. 'Grief's so tiring.' She gave a heartfelt sigh. But it wasn't just the grief; she was also distracted by everything else going on. And if she went to bed with Jackson now, well, it

would feel like much more of a betrayal of Dex than it had on Saturday – because she'd known then she had Dex's blessing.

Or at least, she'd thought she had. And that was what was really bothering Savannah. The idea that her drunken actions had pushed Dex into a terrible place – except now, maybe it wasn't suicide after all. It was all so confusing. 'Sorry, Jackson, but my head's all over the place.'

'No worries, babe.' Jackson finished his glass of wine. 'Let's make a dinner date when you're feeling better, yeah?'

'Sure,' she agreed. *Look at me*, she thought, suppressing a yawn, *being sensible, for once!* But something else was niggling at her – something she couldn't put her finger on. It kept happening, these past few days. Must be the stress of the trauma.

'Try not to be too sad.' Jackson leaned down and kissed her cheek, and she inhaled his musky aftershave and hair product.

'It's hard.' For all her appreciation of his company, truthfully, right now, she just wanted to go back to bed, weep profusely, and then sleep.

'I'll do one last quick recce of the garden and let myself out.' He stood and stretched, miming a phone to his ear as he strode to the door. 'Call me, yeah? And don't let the bogeymen scare you, 'cos remember, that's all they are – bogeymen!'

*

Honestly, Savannah thought sadly, watching him make a final sweep of the garden before he headed down the side-reach, she'd completely lost her mojo.

'Sorry, darling Dexy.' Kissing her fingers, Savannah touched the last photo of them together: the holiday Polaroid on the mantelpiece. 'I'm letting the side down.' Dex wouldn't want her to be this sad, she knew; he'd

always wanted the best for her. *How can those bastard police think I killed him, when I know I'll never meet another man like him?* she thought, noticing with vague irritation that Jackson had left dried mud on the cream carpet.

Maria would sort it tomorrow, though.

As Savannah turned the fire off, she saw the security van in the drive, the ferocious dog silhouetted in the back, and she felt a little better. Trailing upstairs behind a scampering Kylie, she doubted she'd sleep without Dex there. The house was so huge and empty, the rooms all echoey and, although now she had some protection from the horrific intruder, she felt incredibly tense.

Savannah was so tired, though, she just about resisted another pill, which meant she woke in the early hours. Getting up to peer out of the window, she could see the guards were still there, thank God – but as she went back to bed, she realised what had been bothering her earlier:

How the hell had Jackson got past her electric security gate, to be standing in the porch when she opened the door?

CHAPTER 35

CLARA: TUESDAY MORNING

Walking into work, already tired from yet another bad night, Clara went straight to find Ishan. Sitting at his desk outside Savannah's empty office, he was tapping away diligently, his dark-framed glasses taking up half his face.

'Have you heard from Violet?' Clara asked before he'd even looked up. 'I'm really worried.'

'No.' He shook his head. 'I texted her yesterday, but nothing yet. I imagine she's not taking Dex's death at all well.'

'It's worse than that.' Clara leaned closer, aware of the Comms team arriving around Ishan. 'I got a terrible call from her last night. I could hardly hear her, but she was really distressed. I reported her missing, but then—'

'Missing?' Ishan stood now, shocked. 'That sounds bad.'

'It doesn't just sound bad, Ishan, it *is* bad. The police contacted me to say a girl went over Beachy Head last night.'

'Not Violet? No way.' Ishan's eyes were huge with panic, which irritated Clara. Typical male; she needed him to be resourceful, now. But he obviously had no more information, so he was of no use to her.

'Let's pray it's not.' She hurried across the office to Violet's desk, to look for clues.

'What are you doing?' one of Violet's posh neighbours asked, as Clara rummaged through the top tier of Violet's in-tray. 'That's Violet and Dex's stuff.'

'I'm worried about her,' Clara said shortly. Had this girl ever been at all concerned about Violet's privacy or belongings before? Doubtful.

'Because of the List?' the girl breathed. 'Is that why?'

'Something like that.' Clara saw a file marked *Jackson Rayne*; beneath it, another few, labelled with the names of some of Dex's authors.

Keeping an eye out for any senior staff, Clara dug around the lower tray now until she came across a set of small keys, attached to a blue-haired gonk. *Very Violet* – Clara smiled fondly.

After a few attempts, she fitted one to the lock of the drawers beside Violet's desk.

All very neat: Post-It notes, coloured highlighters, stacks of blue and red biros in rubber bands. Delving right to the back of the second drawer, Clara's fingers closed around something: a thin, battered notebook, full of pages of scribbled shorthand she couldn't decipher. Violet's secrets? Feeling like she'd seen something she shouldn't, Clara shoved it back in.

Frantically, she went back to the in-tray and scrabbled through the files. As Ishan waved across the room for her attention, something fell out, drifting slowly to the floor.

Picking it up, Clara realised it was a handwritten note.

'I love him. It's unbearable. I can't go on and I can't tell him.'

'Shit.' Without thinking too hard, Clara pulled her phone out and called the number she had for the police in East Sussex. On hold, tamping down her panic, she turned away to avoid the next-door neighbour's curious gaze. Waiting, she saw one of the Comms team – Savannah's next-in-command, a guy called Luiz – walk up to Ishan, and she watched as Ishan stood in consternation at something Luiz had just said.

And then, still waiting on the phone, Clara became aware of a ripple of excited energy, starting at the edge of the room and heading inwards.

'Clara.' Ishan sped towards her across the office.

'What is it?' She looked at him in fear.

'I'm so sorry.' he was breathless and sweaty, his face tight with emotion. 'I've just heard.'

'Heard what?' she said stupidly.

‘They’ve found a body, Clara.’ His dark eyes reminded her of kids’ old spinning-wheels.

‘You mean in Sussex? I know, I told you that already. They said it might be her, but not definitely...’ Clara was vaguely aware of a voice on the other end of the line now saying *hello, hello?* urgently. ‘They don’t know.’

‘But they do know. It is her, Clara.’ Ishan touched Clara’s arm gently as she stared at the torn piece of paper on the desk, the child-like bubble writing squeezing her heart. ‘I’m so sorry, but it is Violet. She’s dead.’

CHAPTER 36

SAVANNAH: TUESDAY MORNING

A bleary Savannah woke up to her new sunrise alarm – possibly the most irritating object ever, she thought – crashing one hand down on it to stop the stupid chirping birdsong.

But Dex had bought it for her only last week, with a little pink and gold card: *I know how much you love sleep, darling. Let this be a gentle wakening*, he'd written.

Oh, he'd always been so kind to her: ordering the takeout she liked best, running her bubble baths, bringing her tea in bed – her eyes filled automatically, as they did every time she thought of him.

Savannah! She bit down on her lip and told herself, *don't cry again*. If she did, she'd be red-eyed all day. Blinking back tears, Savannah cocooned herself in her goose-feather duvet, hoping Maria would read her mind and bring her a coffee in bed.

She was drifting off again when she remembered her late-night niggle about Jackson. Sitting up, Savannah reached for her phone and rang his number. Getting his voicemail, she left a message, asking him to call back immediately.

With a jolt, she realised how late it was. Given that Maria obviously hadn't learned telepathy yet and hadn't brought coffee, Savannah dragged herself up to shower, further annoyed she didn't have time to pop for one of Eduardo's blow-dries. Already running late, instead, she twisted her hair into a hasty chignon, put her smartest black Prada dress on, and trotted downstairs, dialling the Langley car.

To her deep irritation, though, it was going to be at least an hour, and she was expected at Langley & Co. at midday for her meeting. And Savannah didn't want to keep the hot lawyer, Carl Carrington, waiting.

She'd just managed to order herself an Uber when her mobile phone rang.

'Have you seen it?'

'Seen what?' From Ruth's icy tone, Savannah knew it wasn't anything good.

'I'm pinging it through.'

'Big Crime Editor meets Murderous End-Match while fiancée parties HARD!' proclaimed the *Mirror's* headline on Savannah's phone screen.

'What the hell does that mean?'

'They're onto the fact that Dex's death probably wasn't suicide. I don't know if that's better or worse. Meanwhile...' Ruth took a deep inhale of frustration. 'You and your mystery lover are all over the bloody internet.'

'Oh dear.' Somehow Savannah managed to keep her voice steady. If her siblings disowned her, a decent sex tape might mean a bit of income, she supposed absently. 'Well, thanks for letting me know.'

She hung up before Ruth could start the inevitable tirade.

Staring out at Dex's Aston Martin, Savannah knew she needed to act fast. If she didn't, she was surely an easy target for whatever lunacy was headed her way – but she had no idea right now what to do.

And she might be pretending to herself it was all fine and she felt calm, but she really didn't want to be known for a tawdry scandal; all of which just made her miss Dex even more.

Her best option right now seemed to be upstairs; a few more pills, which honestly felt infinitely more attractive than real life right now...

Savannah's thoughts were interrupted by the ding of her phone: a message from an author whose campaign Savannah's team ran last year; a

demanding if mediocre thriller writer, who pretended not to know her hefty book-deal was because of her famous husband.

Who's been a naughty girl then? ;)

Grimacing, Savannah opened the clip and, through half-shut eyes, had the dubious pleasure of watching herself and Jackson having sex.

What the hell had she been thinking?

Still - *phew*, Savannah thought, as the clip ended abruptly; it could definitely have been worse. The camera lens was angled so she looked almost decent – although obviously not entirely decent. But there was no audio and, *hallelujah*, her thighs and bum looked taut – all that personal training had paid off, she comforted herself. Nor would anyone be able to really identify the man with Savannah; he could have been almost any dark-haired man in a white shirt and black trousers.

In fact, it could have almost been Dex, which somehow made it even worse. Savannah's heart lurched as she closed the clip, her phone dinging again.

'Your driver Yannis is outside in a silver Prius.'

There really was no rest for the wicked.

CHAPTER 37

CLARA: TUESDAY AFTERNOON

Facts about Violet were blurry as the gossip spread round the office. People were whispering that she'd jumped, devastated about Dex's death.

Numb with shock, Clara sat back at her desk, trying to think straight, holding the note she'd found with Violet's things. Was it about Dex? But the video Clara had received yesterday didn't point to suicide – it very much suggested foul play. Wanting to show Ishan, Clara was frantically clicking through her mobile to find the video when her desk phone rang.

'It's time,' Maude's cool voice informed her. 'Take the stairs now.'

'Time for what?'

But Maude was gone.

*

Standing in front of Ruth Langley's curving walnut desk, Clara felt like she was back in the headmaster's room at school – except Ruth's office was a thousand times swankier. Only the Langley & Co. elite met here; someone as lowly as Clara certainly didn't get to hang out in the inner sanctum. The high and mighty Ruth Langley was renowned for keeping herself as far from her staff as possible.

The cavernous office smelled as expensive as it had last time, all Jo Malone candles and Rituals reed diffusers. The room had shiny parquet flooring and a huge bookshelf at the back, boasting every successful title Langley & Co. had ever published; in one corner, a small bar was positioned, while on the right-hand wall, a bright pink neon sign declared *Read or Die*. Clara couldn't imagine ever living in such luxury.

'It's by Tracey Emin,' Ruth Langley said, following Clara's gaze. 'She gifted it to me on my fortieth. Do you like her work?'

‘It’s lovely,’ Clara lied; she hated it. Oh God, she really must get a grip, but she was rattled to the bone over Violet. What did Ruth know?

‘Do sit down, Clara.’ Ruth frowned. ‘You’re making me nervous.’

‘Sorry.’ Clara found that hard to believe, but she did as she was instructed. ‘Please, Ms Langley, is it true—’ Clara started – did she dare go on? ‘—about Violet? And that Dex might have been—’ she could hardly get the word out, ‘—murdered? I saw the newspaper, just now.’

‘You don’t read the tabloids, do you?’ Ruth’s face closed even more, if that was possible. ‘Girl with your brain.’

‘Everyone’s reading it downstairs,’ Clara said bravely. ‘And I’m guessing it’s true, if it’s in the papers.’

‘I’d never make that assumption about the press, dear.’

‘Okay, but – what about Violet?’

Ruth actually looked bored, and Clara forced herself to carry on.

‘They’re saying she’s dead? That she jumped off Beachy Head.’

‘Oh -’ Ruth’s phone pinged and she picked it up. ‘Ha.’ A ghost of a smile played across the CEO’s neat, classic features as she tapped into it vigorously. ‘Thank God for that.’

‘Is it Violet?’ Clara’s intake of breath was audible. ‘Is she okay?’

‘No, it’s Langley business.’ Ruth threw her phone back on the desk. ‘I’m sorry, Clara, but I was informed about half an hour ago that they’ve found poor Violet’s body.’

‘Oh.’ Clara clamped her hands together tight in her lap, shocked by how unbothered Ruth seemed. ‘Oh God, that’s so awful.’

‘It is, yes. Truly awful.’

But Ruth didn’t sound convincing as nearby, a faint whooshing was followed by a loud dinging noise; Clara quickly understanding that the tears that were threatening would be deemed inappropriate right now.

‘Look, Clara.’ Ruth leaned forwards, her voice urgent. ‘It’s vital that we keep on keeping on, here at Langley. It is sad, of course, but business comes first, and that’s why you’re here...’

As Ruth spoke, the lift opened behind the room’s glass back wall. Maude stepped out, followed by a familiar-looking man.

‘At any cost, do not mention Violet now, please, Clara.’ Ruth’s concern was clear. ‘Or this stupid List.’

‘Ok-*aaay*,’ Clara agreed slowly as Maude opened the door to show the man in. Did Langley & Co really think money was more important than someone’s life though? And not just anyone – her best friend here.

‘Hello, there!’ The CEO was now wreathed in smiles, standing to greet Jackson Rayne. ‘Clara, have you met the fantastically talented Mr Rayne? Our number one author, of course.’

‘Call me Jackson,’ he said, modestly for someone with such a swagger.

‘We met once.’ Clara scrambled up, feeling even more like a schoolgirl in her headteacher’s office. ‘I brought you donuts, Mr Rayne.’ She stopped herself from bobbing a curtsy. *Get a grip, Voss*, she told herself, but it was so hard to concentrate; her mind kept flitting back to Violet.

‘Well, donuts are my favourite.’

‘Get Jackson’s drink now, Maude.’ Ruth swivelled her laser stare onto her assistant, who bowed her shiny head in deference and left.

‘So, Clara, I’m told you’re one of Langley’s “Ones to Watch”.’ Jackson Rayne turned his piercing gaze on Clara, his shoulders as broad as a small house.

‘Oh, well, maybe...’ Clara mumbled.

‘No *maybe* about it. And no need for false modesty.’ Ruth’s smile had turned wintry. ‘Own your talent, girl, or people will step over you.’

‘Poor old Dex definitely said you were cool,’ the author agreed.

‘Really?’ If Clara could have flushed hotter, she would have. ‘How kind.’ But tears pricked her eyes again at the mention of Dex.

‘Mr Rayne.’ Maude reappeared with a small silver tray as Clara stuck her nails into her palm; she mustn’t cry here -

‘Kindness had nothing to do with it.’ Jackson Rayne took the tall tumbler from Maude, whose pretty face was set in a placid smile. In fact, in her pinafore and specs, she resembled a maid from some BBC period drama, though Clara doubted that was the look Maude was going for.

‘Cheers!’ Rayne winked. ‘You’re the best, Maude.’

Was it Clara’s imagination, or did Ruth’s PA also blush?

‘You can go, Maude.’ Ruth was brusque.

If backs could shoot daggers, then the personal assistant’s was firing them willy-nilly, thought Clara, watching the other girl stalk back to her desk outside Ruth’s temple. *Stay*, Clara wanted to shout. There was no love lost between her and Maude, but maybe there was safety in numbers.

‘So, to business.’ Ruth was watching Jackson, Clara saw; rather like a hawk watching its prey. ‘With Jackson’s blessing, Clara, you’ll take over Dex’s last edits on the new Smoke Silva—’

Clara nearly choked on air. ‘Me?’

‘Full approval.’ Jackson matched Ruth’s acerbic smile. “Til you bring a top gun in, of course. If this is my last Langley book, I want it to be special.’

‘But it won’t be your last, will it?’ Ruth purred, though her eyes were hard as drill bits. ‘We’re not letting you go anywhere, my dear man. Miles is working on the contract right now, as you know, and there’s a big editorial name in the offing. Clara can hold the fort for now, alright, Clara?’

‘If you’re sure,’ Clara stuttered; then remembered what Ruth had just said about people walking all over her. With a small cough, she said, ‘I’d be honoured. I love Smoke Silva.’ Thank God she’d read one of the four books

already published. In fact, she'd sincerely disliked it – perturbed by the darkness, and a few of the sex scenes. 'He certainly gets up to some seriously interesting antics, doesn't he?'

'Hundred per cent.' Jackson looked pleased. 'He's super brave – and a bit of a tiger, our Silva. And big. A big guy.'

Meeting his smile, Clara observed Rayne was undoubtedly attractive – even if you didn't know who he was. But he was forty-five, at least. And honestly, she was tempted to say no; she just wanted to hide and be sad somewhere quietly. Plus she knew she wasn't nearly senior enough to edit him; Langley & Co. had far more experienced staff, any of whom were a better fit. It didn't really make sense –

But Clara met Ruth's eye as Jackson sat. A thought struck her – was this a bribe, continuing to keep her quiet after the Elizabeth du Toit affair? And who was she to argue, when she needed her job so badly? She could hear Violet on the sidelines, cheering: *You'd be mad to turn it down!* But Ruth's attitude left a nasty taste in her mouth.

'That's settled, then,' Ruth declared, as if there'd ever been any doubt. 'Jackson, be assured we're doubling the Silva marketing spend.' With a little *tsss* noise, she opened a bottle of Perrier on her desk and toasted the writer. 'We want to place you exactly where you deserve to be.'

'Nice one.' He raised his glass back. 'Ta very much.'

'Clara, Maude will send you Dex's latest edits, so you can get straight to work. Now, Jackson, let's discuss knocking all your complacent rivals off their perches.' Ruth handed him a bound document, the title reading: *Jackson's Publicity Brief*. 'Permanently!'

Clara wanted to ask him about the List – but she'd been warned, and she also sensed she'd been dismissed. 'Can't wait to work with you,' she mumbled at the top of Rayne's head, edging towards the door.

‘Cool.’ He didn’t look up, busy studying what Ruth had handed him.
‘Meeting tomorrow? I’ll get my assistant to ping you.’

Belatedly, Clara realised he was addressing her. ‘Oh, great!’

Rayne still didn’t look up.

The last words Clara heard Ruth say as the door shut behind her?
‘Shame the footage got out. But we’ve got your back...’

And Clara got the feeling that the footage, whatever it was, was some sort of leverage for Ruth.

*

‘You know you’re being super naïve,’ Maude muttered obliquely as Clara headed for the commoners’ lift. ‘Be warned.’

Maude was always so opinionated, Clara didn’t bother to question the comment. Her own thoughts were hard to order, but foremost was Violet, and where the awful video Clara *knew* she’d received had gone. Next were Jackson Rayne’s edits. Clara knew she should be pleased and grateful for the opportunity but, right now, it felt like too much pressure.

In the lift, Clara searched her phone yet again, desperately trying to locate the clifftop clip – but it didn’t even seem to be in her history. Honestly, Clara thought, leaning against the mirrored side, it felt like she was going mad.

Maybe she should have told someone – though who? - about the note she’d just found in Violet’s drawer, but did it actually mean anything?

Unless – *had* Violet really loved Dex? Had Clara missed that? And if so, what else had she missed?

Could she have stopped Violet going over the clifftop? She could have gone down there last night, she could have tried harder – except, as it turned out, it would have been too late.

Violet was already dead.

Crucially, Clara thought, she had to stay alive to find out more. Or perhaps it was the other way round.

She had to find out more to stay alive herself.

As if her phone had read her thoughts, it started pinging again: more messages on the work WhatsApp group.

Oh my God – now look!!! 🙄 Drama never ends!!

There, on the thread, was a new version of the List.

THE LIST – updated: 04.11.25

~~Dex Harris~~

~~Violet Childs~~

Jackson Rayne

Clara Voss

Savannah Langley

Who's next? Time's running out... 24 hrs:

Tick tock, tick tock...

Violet's name had been struck out, along with Dex's.

But worst of all, beneath the names was a live digital clock, and the time was ticking down, starting three and a half minutes ago...

CHAPTER 38

SAVANNAH: TUESDAY LUNCHTIME

Walking through her front garden, Savannah passed the security guard sitting in the Parliament van. It wasn't the tall American from last night, but the shorter Londoner. Was it her imagination, or did he smirk as she passed him?

She went back and tapped on the window. 'Can you arrange for twenty-four-hour surveillance, please? I'll be calling your office, though,' she looked at him beadily. 'I only want the best of your team.'

'Of course, Ms Langley.' He nodded. 'Simply the best.' Then he winked.

'Thank you.' Savannah sauntered on, but inside, she was seething. She'd ask for a replacement; she must only have people around her she could thoroughly trust.

And – in her dreams – only people who hadn't watched her sex tape.

*

Stuck in traffic at Marble Arch, Savannah scanned a muck-raking article that included every single bit of publishing outrage the journalist could unearth from the past decade, including the horrible List her photo had appeared on. She'd just read that Langley & Co. seemed to be top of the scandal pile when her phone bleeped.

Looking forward to seeing you. The lawyer, Carl Carrington. ***I've got good news!***

Really? But there could be no good news, unless it was to announce it had all been a bad dream, and Dex was still alive.

I don't believe you, Savannah texted back, grimacing at the gridlock all around her. ***Nothing's good, right now.***

This is. Looks like you're off the hook for Dex's death – pls read attached doc on email.

It seemed Langley's Head of Security had located the CCTV covering the Langley penthouse flat, which showed Savannah entering alone around 2 a.m., and not leaving till the following morning at 9 a.m., which was just after Ruth had broken the terrible news to her. Meanwhile, Dex had been found on camera entering the building around 2.30 a.m. – but then the main feed had been either disabled, or corrupted for some reason.

Had Ruth sorted this? Thank God! Savannah could almost taste the relief she felt - but right behind it, was the taste of her craving for something else; something to calm the turbulence of this awful stress.

Breathe, Savannah! Desperately, she tried to recall any of the techniques from Rehab; what *was* that acronym? Oh yes, HALT - if you felt hungry, angry, lonely or tired, you were vulnerable to relapse...

The bad news was, right now, Savannah was all of those. Well, maybe not hungry, but so lonely, and so tired, and so very very —

Sod it.

Savannah scrabbled in her bag, feeling for the secret compartment where she'd stashed a tiny pillbox earlier. Rehab or not, she really couldn't deal with this tragedy anymore without just a tiny bit of help from her friends. One little tablet wouldn't hurt, would it? Just one...

CHAPTER 39

SAVANNAH: TUESDAY AFTERNOON

Savannah's assistant Ishan had booked Langley & Co.'s most exclusive meeting room, the Secret Library, for Savannah's meeting with the lawyer, Carl. Given how late she was, Savannah went straight there from her car, expecting Carl to be waiting as she hurried in.

But the little library was empty. It was a cosy room on the second floor, at the end of a corridor in the oldest part of the building. Boasting red velvet armchairs, and shelves full of leather books and Langley first editions, the Secret Library even had its own ancient secret passage, leading down to the vaulted cellars that spread like a web far underground. Not that Savannah had ever ventured into the passageway, or the very deepest cellars, given her hatred of dark, enclosed spaces.

Waiting for Carl, Savannah remembered Ishan hadn't replied about Violet, and messaged him again. Then she sat at the replica of Charles Dickens' desk in the corner and pulled out her Dior compact to check her appearance. She'd got ready too quickly that morning, she thought sadly, digging an eyeliner out of her Jane Birkin bag. But as she drew a wing at the corner of one eye, a strange sound made her jump.

Savannah's eyeliner flew across her face. 'Crap!'

The noise got louder: a sort of thumping from somewhere beneath her. A bit like someone was trying to get in – or out.

'Hello?' Savannah called nervously – but the noise had stopped.

As she wiped the eyeliner off, a kind of creaking noise began somewhere nearby, followed by the weird thumping again. 'Hello?' she said, more loudly and bravely than she felt. Maybe the pill was kicking in -

Still no response – but was that crying she could hear?

Creeping towards the old wooden door in the far corner that opened onto a long passageway, Savannah laid her ear against it.

‘Help!’ she was sure she heard. It was very faint and distant, but she was sure she hadn’t imagined it – and it was a woman’s voice. ‘Help me, please.’

‘Hello?’ Now Savannah tried the handle, but the door seemed to be locked. She yanked at it again until, to her shock, it flew open, causing her to lose her balance and fall backwards, hitting her arm hard as she went.

‘God’s sake.’ Quickly, Savannah got up and brushed herself down. Then, against every single bit of better judgement she possessed, she crept into the entrance of the old passage.

‘Hello?’ she called, her voice sounding as tentative as she felt.

‘Help me.’ She was sure she heard the echo again, further away, this time. ‘Please, help!’

‘Who’s down there?’ Savannah had a sudden idea she recognised the voice. ‘Violet? Is that you?’

Without warning, something soft grazed her face and, before Savannah could move, the door slammed behind her.

*

‘Please,’ Savannah croaked, a few minutes later, ‘please let me out.’ Her heart was going so fast, she felt like she was going into cardiac arrest, and her fist was almost bleeding from banging at the door. Tears were starting as suddenly it swung open again, and Savannah stumbled forwards, almost onto her knees.

‘Wow!’ The handsome lawyer gazed down at her. ‘Are you okay?’

For a few seconds, Savannah couldn’t talk – so strong was her panic, so hoarse was her throat. She’d been trying the handle incessantly, shouting

and shouting – but the darkness had been crushing. The therapist from rehab came to mind: a daft, serene woman in a headscarf who'd suggested Savannah's fear of the dark was due to a difficult relationship with her mum.

'Something to do with being back in the womb?' The woman had gazed at Savannah like a stupid Stepford Wife, 'til Savannah realised it was easier to agree.

'Savannah?' Carl was still staring at her, his nice face perplexed. 'You okay? Let me help you—'

'Sorry. The stupid door just wouldn't open.' She took his hand. *How irritating*, she thought absently – her manicure was all messed up where she'd desperately scrabbled at the lock. 'It's so pitch-black in there, I couldn't see my own fingers in front of my face.' She tried to smile, but she felt incredibly shaky as she righted herself. It had been horrible in there, and at least one large rat had scurried past her ankles. 'I'm not great in the dark.'

'Why did you go in, then?' Carl still seemed confused - which made two of them.

'I thought I heard a voice.' It was odd, but even now Savannah couldn't stop trembling. 'I went to check, and the door slammed, and I got locked in.'

'It wasn't locked, though -'

'What do you mean?'

'The door. It wasn't locked, just now.' Carl gave her a kind smile. 'But you do have a cobweb in your hair. May I?'

'Please.' Savannah tried to look serene like that therapist had, but the idea of spiders on her neck made her shudder. 'But I'm sure it was locked. I mean, I know it was—'

‘Well, I opened it quite easily.’ Removing the cobweb, Carl pointed at a silver teapot, now sitting on the Charles Dickens desk. ‘Cup of tea?’

‘I’d rather have a stiff drink.’ Savannah grabbed her bag to look for her compact mirror. There was a rattle as her pillbox hit the floor.

‘Think tea’ll have to do for now.’ Carl gave a rueful grin, picking up the little box and glancing at it. ‘Everything okay with you?’

‘Oh yeah, it’s all great, Carl.’ She held her hand out. But obviously, Carl knew about Savannah’s last stint in rehab. His firm had been involved with drafting her divorce, and they’d had to speak a few times while she was out in America, about the counter-petition from her arsehole ex, Simon.

Life was becoming like a weird farce, Savannah thought, shoving the tiny box away. At least the pill she’d taken in the Uber was having some effect, thank God. ‘Hang on, though...’ She frowned at the tray on the desk. ‘Whoever brought that must have heard me. Why didn’t they let me out?’

‘I don’t know, hon.’ The teapot was dwarfed in Carl’s big hand. ‘You’d have to ask them.’

As he poured the tea, Savannah sensed he didn’t believe she’d been locked in. She tried to collect her wits, but the meds were making it harder.

‘The good news is your alibi’s looking viable,’ Carl said. ‘The police have watched the CCTV of you going into and leaving the family penthouse flat. Obviously, if they put more heat on you, or call you in for questioning,’ he added, exchanging the teapot for a gold pen and notebook from his top pocket. ‘I’ll be with you. But I want to check, is there anything else you haven’t shared? Anything at all they might pick up on?’

‘Just remember, it’s always *no comment*,’ said a voice.

‘Ruth.’ Savannah nearly dropped her teacup as her sister appeared as if from nowhere - the stupid secret passage, perhaps. ‘You scared me.’ Again.

'Jumpy,' Ruth's lip curled slightly. 'Ah good. Maude's followed my instruction. For once.'

'Maude brought the tea?' Savannah's eyes narrowed. 'Are you sure?'

'Of course.' Ruth took the lawyer's hand. 'Carl, thanks for coming.'

'Good to see you.' Carl bowed. 'And only if it's politic about the *no comment*, but it may not reach that point. They can't have got much to go on, Savannah, or they'd have charged you by now.'

'I really bloody hope they don't.'

'Me too.' Carl put the lid back on his fountain-pen.

'Have you both heard about Violet?' Ruth was brisk. 'Dex's assistant. It seems she took her own life on Beachy Head, poor wretch.'

'Violet's *dead*?' Savannah couldn't believe what she was hearing.

'I'm afraid so. Not great timing for us, I must say.'

'You're all heart, Ruth.' Savannah thought about the meek little thing, and how she'd spotted the girl's attraction to Dex at the awards. Then she thought about turning Violet away from home on Sunday, and a half-gasp, half-sob choked her for a second. She swallowed it down. 'How dreadful.'

'It truly is.' Carl looked sad. 'Meanwhile, it seems someone cleverly made Dex's death *look* like a suicide...'

'Not cleverly enough.' Ruth was impatient. 'Apparently.'

'The pathologist has said the marks on Dex's neck aren't conversant with the way he'd...'

Carl hesitated.

'He'd what?' Savannah asked tersely.

'The way he was found.'

'What does that mean?' Unbidden, Savannah's mind returned to Sunday – the fact she hadn't seen Dex; still hadn't been allowed to see his body, in fact. 'He was hanging, no?'

'Well...' Carl cleared his throat. 'Can you deal with more details?'

Savannah nodded.

‘Okay. So, he was hanging from the door hook-’

Savannah bit down on her lip so hard, she almost cried out in pain.

‘Jesus.’ If Ruth wasn’t always so pale, she’d have looked even paler.

She patted Savannah’s shoulder in a bad impression of sympathy. ‘I’m sorry.’

‘Not as sorry as I am,’ Savannah muttered. She would not cry again, here.

‘But the marks on his neck suggest Dex was actually...’ Carl twisted his signet ring round his finger several times before turning his clear, kind gaze on Savannah. ‘Are you sure you want to hear this?’

Savannah nodded again.

‘Apparently, it looks like garrotting. Hence the foul-play allegations.’

‘You mean, like strangling?’ Somehow, Savannah found her voice.

‘Like a movie where an assassin comes up behind the victim with a cheese wire?’ Ruth’s voice filled with something like excitement.

‘Fucking hell.’ Savannah stared at her sister.

‘Sorry.’ For once, Ruth looked embarrassed, hot spots of colour on her cheeks. ‘That was very thoughtless.’

‘Whatever.’ So that’s where that detective had been going with his garden-wire investigations, when he came to her house yesterday.

‘What did the police say about the face at your window? Carl asked Savannah. ‘Did they find anyone lurking?’

‘I didn’t call the police.’

Ruth looked horrified. ‘Why the hell not?’

‘They’re hardly my biggest fans,’ Savannah felt exhausted. ‘And I’ve got security at the house now.’ Being scared and sad really took it out of you; the reason she avoided emotions. And looking at the implacable Ruth,

now – *Ruthless*, as their brothers called her – Savannah knew she'd learned from the best.

'Very wise on the security front.' Carl nodded. "Til this all gets sorted.'

'Who was it?' Ruth demanded. 'The face?'

'I don't know, Ruth, obviously.' Was her big sister's ring fingernail missing a chip of shiny black polish? Unheard of. 'Maybe I imagined it. I'm very stressed. As stressed as when I found out Simon was using call girls.'

But deep down, Savannah knew she hadn't imagined it at all.

*

Together, the two sisters walked Carl out, Savannah's mind whirring. If she was next on the List, she didn't know how she'd find the energy to dodge whoever was behind all this.

She might be becoming paranoid, but what with the intruder and the voices she was sure she'd just heard, Savannah felt increasingly nervous.

Once Carl been swallowed by the Langley elevator, she turned to Ruth. 'We need to check the cellars.' She took a breath. 'Or rather, Security does. I've got a nasty feeling someone might be trapped down there.'

'Are you joking?' Ruth frowned. 'Why didn't you say before?'

'No I'm not joking, and I was distracted.' Savannah glared at her.

'Hearing that Dex was garrotted.'

And for maybe the second time in half an hour, but the first time in Savannah's living memory, Ruth actually looked sheepish.

CHAPTER 40

CLARA: TUESDAY AFTERNOON

On the first floor of Langley & Co., Clara was trying hard to concentrate on her edits for *The Stalker*, but the words kept swimming in front of her. She was stunned and frightened, racking her brain helplessly for answers while all around her, the gossip snowballed.

With Savannah being fingered for Dex's death (*in more ways than one*, some wag wrote on the office Slack, taking their job in their hands), and now that Violet was dead too, staff speculation was taking a new turn – though no one seemed to have any sensible idea of who might be behind the List.

'I heard the head of Hachette hates us right now,' breathed one of the Henriettas. 'What if he's hired someone to mess up Langley?'

'Don't be daft,' her friend pulled a face, but it was publishing, after all; someone was always praying for a rival's downfall.

'What if it was x ghost after Ruth let her go? Or that writer who was plagiarising everyone's work?'

Clara rolled her eyes and stuck her headphones on.

But of course, right now, no one cared more than poor Clara about who the culprit was. And what *was* the link between the people on the dastardly List? Plus, now the ticking clock had been published, who would be next – could it be her? Her stomach was jumpy and her grief for Violet was a tight band around her chest. She just needed to get through this day and retreat home.

At her neighbour Emily's desk, across the aisle, a small group had gathered round the computer, once again watching something open-mouthed and failing to be surreptitious.

Despite herself, Clara peered over.

It was the new YouTube channel, *Armchair Detectives*; so popular, it already had a million subscribers; an adjunct to the true crime podcast she'd become addicted to recently.

'In for a penny,' sighed Clara, and logged on.

'Violet's flatmate told us that Violet had been really upset on Sunday,' the incredibly young male Armchair Detective was reporting with great enthusiasm from a boxy white studio. *'The flatmate, a young paralegal secretary called Mumtaz, was out visiting her mum for lunch, but before she left in the late morning, she'd heard Violet receive a call. From who, we don't know yet,'* (from whom, surely, Clara thought vaguely) *'but rest assured we're on the case. Over to you, Fleur.'*

'Thanks, Lloyd!' Breathlessly, the female presenter took over, holding a big mic with ***Who Goes There?*** printed on it, and standing on a busy London high street. *'And I'm outside their flat, now.'* She gestured at a grey ten-storey building. *'We know that Violet left here around about one on the Sunday afternoon, with only the clothes she stood up in,'* (God, how stupidly dramatic, Clara thought sourly) *'and she was last seen by the newsagent owner here,'* she swung an arm behind her, *'heading towards the tube.'*

Now, a brightly-coloured graphic of a route from Violet's flat in Kilburn to the tube station filled the screen, with a tiny moving avatar of Violet.

'The real worry is—' the camera zoomed in on Fleur the presenter's concerned – if also thrilled – face, *'—she's not been seen since!'*

It felt so horribly inappropriate, given everything that she knew and had just been told about Violet's death. Absently, she scanned the inane comments in the sidebar until one message jumped out at her:

Capitalist trash 😏deserve everything they get, death to wankers!!

A rush of sorrow and fury filled Clara so quickly, she could barely catch her breath. How dare people be so callous and cruel? Didn't they realise actual humans had died? Her friends -

For a few seconds, her own hand hovered over the computer mouse; tempted to retaliate, fuelled by all the churning emotion that was overwhelming her. But she knew really that whoever wrote such horrible things were just trolls; a keyboard warrior, hiding behind a doubtless fake identity.

Clara fumbled with her mouse, trying to hit pause on the video; to take time to calm herself, when the whole computer crashed.

CHAPTER 41

CLARA: TUESDAY AFTERNOON

Phil from IT came to Clara's aid when she was unable to get her computer back on.

'I think it's something to do with the main frame.' He stood beside her, scratching his chin thoughtfully. 'I'm going to swap your monitor for now, though, which might do the trick.'

'Okay, thanks,' Clara said, wondering why she'd never realised how handsome Phil was before. Probably because, after her last boyfriend Sam, she'd had no desire to date or to even go near men again anytime soon. Not that Sam was really a man; he was much more of a boy-child.

But Phil had such nice red curls, she thought absently now, watching him potter about with wires, and his freckles were cute. Though she'd barely spoken to him before today, he had a sweet, calm air about him.

'Were you downloading particularly large files when it crashed?' He bent to unplug her monitor. 'Or something illicit?'

'No.' She blushed, feeling almost guilty about what she'd been watching.

'Not the Sexy Savannah show?' He grinned.

'The – oh, God no.' Clara's eyebrows shot into her fringe. 'Ugh.' She didn't want him to think she was a pervert. 'But I mean, each to their own,' she added hurriedly, not wanting to sound like a complete square, either.

'I don't think she's sexy, by the way,' Phil quickly qualified. 'It's just what they call her downstairs. I think it's what the press call her, too.'

The IT department, the post room and the security office were all on the ground floor. The IT team were known to be a bit geeky, but the post room had a reputation for being lads, while Security were generally thought unapproachable.

‘Especially since the...’ Phil himself flushed a little bit, now, ‘that sex tape thing.’

‘I wasn’t watching that, anyway.’ Clara was strangely touched by his embarrassment. ‘I was watching about poor Violet, on YouTube.’

‘Oh, no.’ Now Phil looked upset and grave. ‘Violet’s calm. It’s so sad.’

‘I know...’ Clara trailed off, wondering, could she share her fears with Phil? She had a vague idea that he and Violet might have been friendly. Dex had so many technologically inept authors, Violet practically had a hotline to the helpdesk.

‘Actually, Phil, I wonder if you could help me with something?’ She pulled her mobile off the desk. ‘I got sent this scary video of Violet, but now I can’t find it in my history at all.’

‘Scary video?’ Phil looked worried. ‘What do you mean?’

‘Wotcha!’ Ishan was suddenly there, all floppy hair and Joe 90 specs above his grey V-neck sweater. He always dressed a bit like he was still wearing school uniform. ‘What you two discussing?’

Clara looked at Phil and prayed he didn’t tell Ishan. She didn’t want it spread round the office that she’d lost the video.

‘Oh, you know, the price of eggs.’ Phil fist-bumped Ishan, and Clara breathed a sigh of relief; what a star. ‘How’s your frisky boss, today?’

‘Savannah? Haven’t really seen her.’ Ishan stuck his hands in his pockets. ‘She’s been in a meeting in the Secret Library with the bigwigs. Clara, I’m going to get some lunch, if you’re hungry?’

‘I was going to pop out for a Tesco meal deal,’ she said, as the Henrietta called Emily walked by. ‘I’m a bit skint, this month.’

‘*A meal deal?!*’ The girl’s eyes widened, as if Clara had just suggested eating a small poo.

‘Lunch would be great, Ish.’ Clara stood up. ‘Lead the way. Thanks, Phil. Any help with that thing I mentioned would be great -’ she widened her eyes subtly, hoping he got her meaning. His eyes were hazel-coloured she noticed, as he met her gaze, as she rambled on. ‘Cos I’m stuck with no computer.’

‘No worries,’ he nodded almost imperceptibly and to her great discomfort, she found her cheeks were suddenly flaming.

‘C’mon,’ she dragged Ishan by the hand. ‘I’m starving.’ Which was a lie. Clara couldn’t imagine being hungry again right now; all the terrible news was making her queasy.

*

‘People are saying that Vi had a massive thing about Dex,’ Ishan said to Clara as they queued in the upstairs café. ‘Did you know that?’

‘Er -’ Odd feelings flooded Clara yet again, ‘not really.’ So why did she feel so uneasy? ‘I mean, she obviously loved him as a boss -’ but now signs obviously pointed a different way. Like - what had that note been in Violet’s desk? Clara tried hard to qualify herself, ‘It’s just, I never heard her mention Dex in any sort of... *fancying* way.’ Had she?

The summer night filtered back into her memory – in the nightclub, when Violet said she’d been heartbroken and Clara hadn’t asked the right questions. She’d been drunk, sure, but – it seemed now it was also a night she’d let Violet down... ‘What do you think?’

‘I think she deffo had the hots for Dex,’ Ishan selected the biggest chocolate muffin from the pile; irrationally annoying Clara, who’d been absently eyeing it up. She might have lost her appetite, but sugar was good for a shock, wasn’t it?

‘I mean, he was obviously way out of league, but -’

‘Ishan!’ Too late, Clara realised she was getting tearful. ‘I mean, she’s like my best mate here -’

‘Was.’ Ish corrected gently.

‘Oh God, yes, was,’ Clara stared blindly at the pile of muffins. ‘So wouldn’t she have told me if she had been crushing on him?’

‘Maybe. But with respect, you didn’t know she was suicidal, so -’ Ish looked apologetic.

‘No, you’re right, I didn’t.’ Muffins suddenly felt horribly inappropriate. ‘I hadn’t managed to talk to her since the awards.’

‘Scuse me!’ Maude appeared between them. ‘Talking about poor drippy Violet Childs?’

‘She’s not drippy,’ snapped Clara. ‘And I’m next, thanks Maude.’ Moving down the line, she ordered some carrot soup.

‘I heard there’s a suicide note.’ Maude sighed sadly as one of her posh blonde clique joined them. ‘Yeah, I heard that too.’

Clara started. Had she left the note out? But was it even a suicide note? There was no evidence to suggest it was –

‘Except – isn’t it murder now?’ The Henrietta’s blue eyes were so big, they looked like they might pop out.

‘Where is the note?’ Ishan looked shocked.

‘It just came in the mail.’ Maude’s face shone. ‘Addressed to Dex.’

‘Honestly,’ Clara felt another rush of anger, and for once, forgot about her own lowly status, ‘it’s like you’re all enjoying this.’

‘I’m not enjoying it,’ the blonde girl was annoyed. ‘I’m not a psycho.’

‘Nor me.’ Maude took her friend’s arm. ‘I feel sorry for the poor thing. It was obviously, like, a copycat suicide, though. Not very original.’

‘But if Dex was murdered, it can’t be copycat, can it?’ mused the blonde. ‘And have you seen the new List?’ Both girls stared at Clara. ‘Poor you.’

‘Jeez.’ Clara dumped her tray, slopping soup everywhere to the server’s dismay, and hurried away.

*

Back at her desk, Clara found a new monitor, and Phil’s mobile number scribbled on a Post-It.

Any more probs, just call or text me direct, and I’ll help you ☺

Clara sat, her head spinning with ideas. Why did Violet feel so bad she’d killed herself? Was it really about Dex? And if it had been suicide, what the hell had that awful video been about? Surely it must be linked to this awful List – Clara needed information before it was too late. If Phil could help her find the vanished video, perhaps she could hack into something somehow – with his help?

Her desk phone rang, startling her out of her thoughts.

‘Clara?’ A woman’s voice she didn’t recognise. ‘Jackson Rayne will be ready for your Zoom in ten minutes. I’ll send you a link now.’

‘Great.’ Clara hung up. ‘That’s all I bloody need now,’ she muttered, and logged on quickly, pulling up the edits Maude had sent.

But her blood was racing with adrenaline and angry sorrow and, honestly, the last thing in the world she needed was schmoozing Langley’s Number One author.

Unless he had some ideas himself.

CHAPTER 42

SAVANNAH: TUESDAY AFTERNOON

In Ruth's office, Savannah insisted that her sister sent Security down to the cellar to check out her wild suspicions.

'Okay,' Ruth shrugged, hanging her boxy Jaegar jacket on a hanger; only confirming to Savannah she was a bit stressed. Ruth never undressed in public. 'But you've got to work with me to make your alibi stick.'

'But Carl just said the police have got footage that gets me off the hook?' Savannah flopped onto the leather sofa.

'Let's just say we've had some friendly assistance from IT' Ruth rubbed her eyes, exhausted. 'Because this needs to go away, now.'

There was a tap at the door, and Miles walked in. 'It's okay, girls, the cavalry has arrived, as requested.'

'Marvellous.' Christ, this was all Savannah needed – her boring oldest brother, clad in his naff golfing gear, right down to the stupid two-tone brogues. And it looked like Ruth had called him in.

'Splashed out on a little work, Milesy?' His hairline was suspiciously different from last time she'd seen him. 'Looking more virile in the lustrous locks department, darling.'

'More internal stress, Ruth? This Dex Harris thing is terrible for business, honestly,' Miles ignored Savannah's barbed compliment. 'I had to come off at the third hole.' He helped himself to Ruth's decanter of whisky. 'I hear you're in the firing line for Dex's death, Savannah. Bloody stupid.'

Oh, do put a hole in it, thought Savannah. 'You really shouldn't have bothered coming, darling. We have it all covered, don't we, Ruthy? Got all my facts straight, now.'

'Listen.' Miles leaned over her, so close she could smell the musty scent of his golfing cagoule. 'We need to manage this terrible situation to

within an inch of its life, because any more bloody scandal will kill the Rayne deal.' To Savannah's relief, he moved away again. 'We cannot afford to lose Jackson right now, on top of everything else. Such appalling optics.'

'Speaking of everything else – have you heard about this Violet girl?' Ruth said. 'Dex's assistant?'

'Yep.' Miles swigged his whisky. 'Bloody little fool.'

'Miles!' Savannah was shocked, despite herself. 'The poor girl's dead.'

'I'm sorry.' Miles shrugged. 'But it's so wet, jumping off a cliff just because your boss died. These Gen Zs need to grow a backbone. And what the hell were you thinking, Savannah? We said keep Langley squeaky clean, and you're shagging our number one writer while your boyfriend's dying.'

Beneath her bag, Savannah pinched her own hand to stop herself screaming. 'No, Miles,' she drawled. 'It was at least four hours beforehand.'

'Oh, well done you.' He started clapping, which infuriated Savannah even more than his lack of chin. 'Reminiscent of your dear mama and Pa's initial get-together. I'm warning you, if you drag us down, you'll regret it.'

'Miles,' Ruth reproved, with very little conviction. 'But he's right, Savannah. You need to rein it in.'

'What is this, the two-line whip?' Savannah didn't actually know what one of those was – something political, she suspected, but it sounded fitting. 'Did you ask him here to scare me?' She nodded at Miles. 'Cos believe me, you don't.' Nothing could be worse than the time he locked her in the icehouse. Apart from maybe when he rode her pony Velvet, who was waiting to be re-shoed, and caused her to go lame. The vet had come when Savannah was back at school and shot the pony – something Savannah would never forgive Miles for.

'I'm not trying to scare you. I'm just saying, toe the line.'

‘Oh, I’ll toe it alright,’ Savannah said mulishly, ‘*if* I’m still alive. And I didn’t care about Jackson Rayne. I’d just had a bit too much to drink – and I wish I hadn’t shagged him, believe me.’

‘I thought you were sober, now?’

‘I can still drink, Miles, it’s just medication I struggled with -’

‘And what d’you mean, still alive?’ Ignoring her, Miles downed his whisky. ‘This stupid list’s just a gimmick.’

‘How do you know? Or... you don’t mean you planned it?’ Aghast, Savannah stared at him. ‘You absolute bastard.’

‘Don’t be so bloody thick. Of course I didn’t—’

‘For God’s sake.’ Ruth’s tone had real bite to it now. ‘Don’t be heartless, Miles. And don’t raise your voice, Savannah, it’s so unseemly.’

‘And who are you?’ Savannah could hear hysteria bubbling up in her voice. ‘The etiquette police?’ She was fighting to contain herself as Ruth’s desk phone rang.

‘Saved by the bell,’ Savannah drawled as Ruth picked up; Miles went on glaring at her while Ruth listened intently.

‘Thank you.’ Ruth hung up. ‘Security have done a thorough sweep; the cellars are all clear.’

‘Really?’ Savannah frowned. ‘But I’m sure I heard someone down there. I heard them from the Secret Library.’

‘You always did have a vivid imagination, dear,’ Ruth said.

‘A mental one, you mean.’ Miles grimaced. ‘Especially if you’re drinking too much.’

‘Women are allowed to have fun, Miles.’ Fingernails dug into her palms again, Savannah managed a laugh. ‘You should ask your ex-wife what she thinks about that.’

‘Who are you to judge?’ Miles turned puce. ‘First Simon Wexford, then Dex. For all his great editing, Harris’ morals were as bad as an alleycat’s.’

‘Don’t you dare talk about Dex like that.’ Savannah stood, which turned out to be a reasonable effort; possibly, she’d overdone the pills. ‘He had more publishing talent in his ballsack than you’ll ever have in your whole body, dear Miles. Now do excuse me, but I’ve got places to be.’ Grabbing the Birkin, Savannah slammed the door so hard, Ruth’s uptight assistant outside her office looked shocked.

‘Dammit, my coat. Grab it for me, would you, darling?’ Savannah felt the adrenaline start to ebb. ‘I’m not facing the firing range again, today.’

‘Which one?’ she could have sworn the assistant muttered, but Savannah didn’t care. She was still jabbing away at the lift button when the young woman brought her Burberry mac to her a minute later. ‘Thanks.’

‘So you didn’t kill Dex?’ asked the girl.

‘Ha,’ Savannah laughed incredulously. ‘You’ve got some nerve. What’s your name again?’

‘Maude.’

‘Maude. No, I didn’t kill him. I loved him very much.’

‘Why were you screwing that Rayne writer dude, then? And thank God the press haven’t caught on that it was him -’

Savannah suddenly felt more tired than she had in her life. ‘Honestly, Maude, right now, I don’t know.’ Her eyes swam with tears as the lift arrived. ‘If I could have Dex back, I’d never look at another man again.’

‘Fair enough.’ Maude shrugged, the little Peter Pan collar on her black pinafore pristine beneath her unlined face. No help needed there, lucky thing. God, Savannah missed her early youth; how much she’d taken for granted. Gravity was a bitch, as was grief.

‘I believe you,’ Maude said gravely. ‘And I’ll tell the others, too.’

‘Thanks.’ Savannah stepped into the lift, turning to see her brother still boring Ruth with his deadly opinions. ‘I need all the allies I can get.’

‘You might be right.’ Coolly, Maude met her gaze. ‘Sad about Violet, isn’t it?’

‘Terrible.’ Savannah pressed *Ground Floor*, remembering how she’d thought she’d just heard Violet in the passageway. She was clearly losing her mind.

‘They say Violet’s suicide note came addressed to Dex.’

‘Really? God, how tragic.’ Savannah thought about her darling Dex. ‘What a bloody mess. I don’t know what the hell’s going on.’

‘Have you spoken to Violet’s friend, Clara?’ Maude blinked, cat-like. ‘I would, if I were you. Her desk’s on the first floor, near the back.’

*

When the lift reached the ground floor, Savannah stood for a minute, thinking. She nodded politely at those who murmured condolences as they passed; ignored side-eyes from less gracious members of staff.

Then she took the stairs back up to the first floor. But by the time she got there and asked for Clara Voss, Clara’s seat was empty.

‘She’s in a meeting,’ Clara’s neighbour told Savannah. ‘That way.’ She pointed at the Christie Room.

‘Right. And do you know anything more about Violet Childs’ note? The one that came in the mail?’

‘Oh.’ This young editor looked like a rabbit with a ten-tonne truck bearing down on her. ‘Um, well, not really. I think HR took it. All I heard was that her body is – messed up.’

‘Really?’ Savannah shuddered. ‘What does that mean?’

‘Like, all bloated from the sea. Someone said she looked like an old dead whale.’ The girl sighed with the thrill of it all. ‘Tragic, really.’

CHAPTER 43

CLARA: TUESDAY AFTERNOON

The last thing Clara wanted now was a Zoom with Jackson Rayne, she thought, trudging to the Christie Room with her laptop – but she had no choice. She was on Langley time and, whatever else was going on, she had to remember she had a job to do.

Checking her appearance in her phone screen, Clara winced at her roots, desperately tidying her hair before she logged on, as a matronly Agatha Christie gazed down from her portrait on the wall. Beside that was a gold-framed painting of the liger, the Langley family emblem, which was littered throughout the building. Ligers were weird creatures, Clara always thought; fairy-tale-like, despite being real – much creepier than a regular tiger or lion.

‘Alright, Agatha?’ Clara raised a brow at the great doyenne of crime. ‘Who wrote this blinking List - and am I next?’

Agatha gazed down inscrutably as Clara checked the time. Rayne was late; annoying, given he’d requested the call. Authors, she’d learned over this past year, were all too often a law unto themselves.

‘Hi!’ she said quickly as her computer pinged and Jackson Rayne appeared, wearing a red Ralph Lauren polo shirt. It seemed quite tight, and a bad tattoo of a woman’s face poked out from one arm.

‘Nice to see you.’ Clara smiled politely.

‘Alright there, babes.’ Rayne looked like he was in a hotel room; a very posh one. ‘So, a bit of a celebration, eh? You and me.’ The author’s steely eyes creased as he stared through the screen. ‘New beginnings.’

‘Oh, yes.’ But Clara had a sudden awful vision of Dex, hanging in his office not far from where she sat now. ‘And ends,’ she said, without thinking. ‘Dex, I mean.’

‘Yeah, course.’ Did Jackson’s face fall a little? ‘We must remember old Dexy, poor sod. Who’d have thunk he was suicidal, eh?’

Thunk? ‘But he wasn’t suicidal, was he?’ Clara gazed at Jackson, but he was fiddling with something out of sight – his Rolex watch strap, she realised, as he held it up to his face to examine it. Worth more than her salary over a good few years, she imagined. ‘The police are calling it murder, now.’

‘Hmm.’ Jackson closed the strap with a definitive click. ‘Shocking.’ But his expression was almost a scowl.

‘What do you think about the List?’ Clara said in a rush, ignoring Ruth’s warning. ‘And the ticking clock?’

‘Load of old bollocks, babe.’ He shook his head. ‘Forget about it.’

‘But...’ Clara was about to mention Violet, but sadness overwhelmed her. And Jackson was probably a man who hated talking feelings. Soldiers didn’t, did they? They just buried their trauma and got PTSD instead.

‘How would you like to use this meeting?’ *Please not on the edits*, she prayed, because she hadn’t had time to look at them properly.

‘Just wanted to say *hola*, and suggest a meet, go through the edits in person, yeah?’ Jackson’s smile showed remarkably white teeth. Veneers, Clara supposed. ‘Normally I’d be straight back to my Sussex pad, but I’ve got a dinner in Soho tonight, so I’ll still be in town tomorrow.’

‘Great.’ No one said ‘pad’ these days, did they? ‘Is that where you live – Sussex?’ All roads led there, apparently.

‘Yeah, Hove, mostly. Near Brighton. England’s sunny South Coast. So, how about a late morning meet? I’m always in the gym, first thing. Time-wise, military conditioning’s a bitch to break.’

‘I can imagine,’ Clara agreed, though she couldn’t, really. ‘My grandad was a para, actually. What unit were you in?’

'I was a Royal Marine, babe. Seven years, four tours of duty.'

'So brave. My dad kept my grandad's red beret, and got it framed. It's in our living room.'

'Oh nice.' Rayne nodded. 'Yeah, I've kept mine. Can't beat a red beret.'

'He wrote the motto under it – *utrinque paratus* – *ready for anything*! What was yours?'

'My Latin's terrible.' Rayne looked rueful. 'And my memory – could never remember mine, babe. Don't really need a motto when you're in hand-to-hand combat, though. Shall we get on with this then, eh?'

'Oh, course, sorry.' Clara opened her notebook dutifully. 'So, would you like to concentrate on any particular area of the book tomorrow?'

There was a faint knock, presumably from someone at Jackson's door.

'Scuse me a sec.' He got up and crossed the room, and Clara took in the breadth of his shoulders. Rayne was what her brother Adam would call 'a unit'.

Fiddling with the Post-It note Phil had left her earlier, Clara thought she heard a woman's voice. Now, Phil was much more her type; she really liked that dimple...

'Gotta go, sweet cheeks.' Jackson was back. 'I'll get my assistant to send you the address. We'll have fun with old Silva's antics!'

'Okay.' Clara tried to look excited. 'Great stuff. I look forward to—'

But Jackson had already left the meeting.

Great stuff? God, Voss.

Standing, Clara stretched out her stiff neck, relieved it was over. Looking into the main office, to her great surprise, she saw Savannah Langley, striding towards her. And then she heard a ping on her laptop, and looked down to see a message pop up from *Guesswho@gmail.com*.

'Are you next?'

CHAPTER 44

TUESDAY EVENING

‘Are you frightened?’ Clara asked Savannah as they waited at the bar on the corner of Park Lane. ‘About being on the List?’

Half an hour ago, opening the Christie room door to greet Clara, Savannah had watched the colour drain from the young editor’s face as she read something on her computer.

‘Clara?’ Savannah had extended a hand. ‘Savannah Langley. Let’s put our heads together, shall we?’

Without waiting for an answer – she was a Langley after all - she’d led Clara to this bar with all the confidence of her own privileged upbringing. But, judging by the girl’s face, Savannah was sensing it wasn’t the sort of place Clara usually hung out with its cream leather benches, marble tables, low golden lighting. Subtly expensive, like Savannah herself.

Perhaps she should have chosen somewhere more – normal, like a pub. With a shudder, she ran her broken fingernail down the cocktail menu.

‘Frightened of being on the List?’ With a sigh, knowing she ought to stay sober, Savannah ordered a mocktail, while Clara went for cheap lager. ‘I don’t know. Not really. But I am wondering why Violet sent Dex a suicide note. And don’t have that silly little beer, have a proper drink. It’s on me, darling.’

‘I like beer.’ Clara flushed.

‘A proper drink, darling, come on.’

‘Okay thanks. I’ll have a glass of, er, Chardonnay.’

‘Good. Your most expensive, please,’ Savannah told the barman, handing him her platinum Amex. ‘Run us a tab please, and we’ll sit down.’

At a corner table, they slid onto the puffy banquettes.

‘I’m very sorry about Dex,’ Clara said sadly. ‘He was a good guy.’

‘Thanks.’ Savannah felt the now-to-be-expected rush of hot tears. ‘I miss him every single second. And I believe you were friends with Violet? His poor little assistant.’

‘Yeah, good mates.’ Now Clara looked teary. ‘Very good mates.’

‘So, look, what do you know?’ Savannah fiddled with her engagement ring. ‘Did she really have the hots for Dex?’

‘She never told me if she did.’ Clara seemed very solemn, and Savannah found herself warming to the young woman, despite her terrible pink hair and bad roots. ‘But I wasn’t in a great place myself last year, after my ex. He was a -’ she met Savannah’s eyes bravely, ‘a cheating bastard.’

‘Sounds like my ex-husband.’ Savannah broke off as the waiter brought their drinks. ‘Thanks, darling. Sisters in pain.’ She toasted Clara, noticing the young woman had lovely brown eyes, clear and bright. ‘So, let’s make a plan.’

‘Sure.’ Clara’s cheeks still looked hot. ‘But I let Violet down. She wasn’t happy in the summer, and I’m sure she tried to say something about a guy who’d really hurt her ages ago. I didn’t pay enough attention.’

‘But you don’t know who it was?’

‘No.’ Clara shook her head. ‘But I bloody wish I did.’

‘Hmm. Well, no use crying over spilled milk. We need to work out who’s behind all this.’ Savannah waved the waiter over and handed him her glass. ‘Be an angel and pop a tiny shot of tequila in this.’ She grinned at Clara. ‘Tequila’s not real booze, you know, Clara. It bypasses your liver.’

‘That’s good, then.’ Clara smiled shyly and fished out a notebook. ‘Shall we go through what we know, and make our own list of suspects?’

‘You take notes.’ Savannah nodded approvingly. ‘So, darling Dexy was the first victim...’ She found herself unable to speak for a minute.

‘But who was behind the weird hanging body at the National Book Awards?’ Clara pointed out. ‘I was watching at home on telly, and it was like, properly dark.’

‘Yes, you’re right, make that event number one. You know – I had a horrible feeling at the time that the body looked like Dex.’

‘What happened to it?’ Clara looked up from writing. ‘The dummy?’

‘I don’t know, it was all so chaotic, after that dreadful thing about the ‘most useless person in publishing.’ Poor Dex. So I guess number two is him. Then the List was published online, so that’s three, then four is sort of Violet, isn’t it? Even if it was suicide, it was caused by grief.’ Savannah twiddled her glass stem. ‘So our prime suspect has to be someone with an axe to grind against Langley, don’t you think?’

‘Maybe. And I guess whoever it is was also behind my phone call...’ Clara remembered the strange robotic voice. ‘Someone rang me that night to give me a warning.’

‘Any idea who?’

‘No, no idea. But I did wonder, Ms Langley—’

‘Savannah, please.’

‘Savannah.’ Clara blushed yet again. ‘What do you make of Jackson Rayne?’

‘In what sense?’ Twiddling her drink’s little paper umbrella, Savannah hoped Clara didn’t ask about their hookup.

‘I get the feeling,’ Clara said slowly, ‘that – he’s not quite what he says he is.’

‘Why?’ Savannah could literally feel her eyes narrow. ‘How?’

‘Because... he thought Royal Marines have red berets, but they’re green. And he didn’t know his motto. I looked it up. It’s *Per Mare, Per Terram*. By land, by sea.’

‘So?’

‘I just think, elite soldiers, you know, they have their mottos pretty much written in blood on their hearts. My grandad’s was tattooed on his chest. But Jackson said he couldn’t even remember his. It’s just weird.’

‘Oh.’ Savannah gazed at the girl. ‘I mean, it’s not exactly evidence, is it? Though I suppose it’s very much part of his brand, so if he’s lied about it, that’s not good.’ She took a big slurp of her mocktail, glad of the tequila. ‘Dex must have looked into his history though. And at the moment, the police seem fixated on me. I’m not guilty, you know.’

‘I have to be honest,’ Clara said slowly, ‘I did wonder at first.’

‘I appreciate your honesty,’ Savannah clinked Clara’s glass with her own. ‘So who else have we got? My brother Miles? He’s a tosser.’

And sitting there, watching the girl scribbling in her notebook, Savannah thought *yes, of course*; the person behind @TheRealDexHarris could well be the same person trying to shame her by sharing the sex-tape – if not kill her.

Though it could be said she was doing a pretty good job of shaming herself.

As if to confirm this, her phone lit up with a message: from Ruth.

I think it’s best you stay away from the office right now. WFH, ok?

Savannah doubted she had any say in the matter.

*

An hour later, watching Clara trudge towards Green Park tube station, Savannah hailed a black cab. On the back seat, she felt gutted as she remembered her last journey in one – with Dex, when he was still alive; the last time she’d ever seen him.

Piccadilly and Marble Arch flashed by as she blearily searched for a hanky in her bag, and considered Clara's suspicions about Jackson's identity. Personally, she hadn't viewed him as a liar; his cool demeanour had impressed her – but then, her radar wasn't working well, if at all. If, indeed, it ever had. She sighed. *Okay*, so it had never worked – that was the truth. Not when it came to men.

Nor had Dex ever suggested Jackson wasn't who he said he was. Now she looked him up online, and saw Jackson hanging out with that gorgeous Victoria Secret model again, in some ritzy new bar on the South Coast. Except, were there really ritzy bars on Britain's South Coast? Savannah sincerely doubted it. The South of France, maybe...

She felt a flash of jealousy but, on top of Clara's suspicions, the sex on Saturday night had been a bit... rough. She wouldn't be sorry if they didn't do it again – it was just company she craved tonight.

Still, at least the house wouldn't be empty when she got there: she'd asked Maria to stay over, sweetening the offer with a little spa weekend incentive. She really must get around to giving the housekeeper a raise. And, as Savannah arrived home, the security patrol was still on hand, too. Their van was parked in her drive; a guard and the dog patrolled the grounds every hour. Ishan had been instructed to get them to replace the smirking guard; fortunately, he wasn't there, now. Exhausted and a little unsteady on her feet, she went straight upstairs to bed, without even dipping into the medicine cabinet.

Hours later, a loud knocking stirred her out of her amazing dreams of Dex. Feeling dreadful at being woken this way Savannah realised it was the early hours of Wednesday, and someone insistent was at the door.

Someone who Savannah had no desire to see ever again.

CHAPTER 45

TUESDAY NIGHT

At Green Park tube, Clara had stood on the escalator, swaying very slightly, and realised how very near Victoria Station she was.

Maybe the huge glass of Chardonnay helped, but she had a brainwave: instead of catching the underground home, heading east across London, she'd take the Picadilly Line to Victoria - where the fact she arrived just in time for the next train to the South Coast seemed like a sign.

Not stopping to interrogate whether it was guilt sending her dashing across the country, Clara felt like it was the very least Violet deserved.

But the officer at Eastbourne Police Station didn't share her view.

'Please,' Clara begged, tearfully. 'I've come all this way.'

'We can't, miss.' The desk sergeant shook his head sadly. 'Her body's already gone to the hospital mortuary. There's always an autopsy for suicides.'

'Can I go there, then?' Clara was starting to feel a little crazed, herself. The alcohol had totally worn off, and she was exhausted. 'I just - I want to see her. Say goodbye properly.' She clutched her bag like her life depended on it. Maybe it did. Danger lurked round every corner, now.

'I wouldn't bother, love. Only next of kin. Anyway,' the man lowered his voice, 'from what I hear, her face was shredded by the rocks. I hate to say it, but she won't be a pretty sight.'

'Oh God.' Clara felt a huge wave of nausea at the thought. Poor Violet. 'That's so awful.'

'Best you get off home, eh?' He patted Clara's hand. 'Remember your pal the way you knew her when she was happy.'

When was that, though? Her head filled with images of a ruined Violet, Clara trailed back to the station, where she just managed to catch the last train back to London.

She walked down the carriages 'til she found the busiest one. She didn't want to be a sitting duck for the mad person who was hunting her, if indeed there was one.

Leaning back in her seat, the train rattling through the dark countryside, Clara cracked the small can of lager she'd bought at the concourse shop, and considered her drink with Savannah Langley – a drink that cost the same as Clara's weekly lunch budget.

She'd been surprised by Savannah – amazed at how calm she'd felt in her presence. Up close, this Langley had seemed a very different kettle of fish from her big sister, Ruth – and far more gorgeous, with her sleepy green eyes, delicate bone structure, and elegant neck, a bit like a swan's. The only way Clara ever felt like a swan was when her legs frantically paddled beneath the surface, trying to keep afloat.

And nor could Clara imagine ever being friends with Savannah, whose life was a million miles from hers. The only thing they had in common was the awful List.

As more passengers boarded at each station nearing London, Clara didn't suppose she was in immediate danger, but during the past few days, she'd started to feel so on edge, her right eye kept twitching. Not only that, her appetite was diminishing. *Some small mercies, then*, she thought ruefully, as she stared at the list in her notebook that she and Savannah had started in the bar:

Miles Langley – suggested by Savannah, who had some family axe to grind. No evidence, other than she said he was a horrid man.

Maude? No evidence. Just a gut feeling.

And whilst at one point Clara might have thought Savannah Langley herself was guilty, given the fact she was shagging Jackson when Dex died, having met her properly now, Clara's instinct was that Savannah was as innocent as she was.

Clara added *Jackson Rayne* – though he was on the List himself, obviously, and again, she had no evidence against him. Plus Savannah had shagged him – or was shagging him, Clara wasn't sure which, even though they hadn't discussed it.

Honestly, this list was kind of pathetic.

Clara opened her laptop and tapped on the keyboard, thinking she'd google Jackson, when her work email pinged:

'Jackson'll see you at 11am sharp, Soho Vibes Hotel, Dean Street.'

She looked back at the list, and the name she'd just written down.

Fantastic. Not.

CHAPTER 46

WEDNESDAY MORNING

By the time a groggy Savannah made it down to her hallway, Maria had let the visitors in: a small group of uniformed police officers, DS Addo at the front.

‘Couldn’t it have waited ’til the morning?’

‘It is morning. Search warrant.’ Addo brandished a bit of paper. ‘No time like the present.’

‘Be my guest,’ Savannah purred. She was damned if she’d let him see her discomfort. ‘I’m going back to bed. Maria’ll look after you.’

‘We’ll search around you, then.’ He gave her a ghastly smile. ‘You need to be where we can see you.’

An hour later, they’d found nothing, apart from Dex’s laptop that Savannah had already trawled – to no avail. They left, taking the disconnected Ring doorbell with them that she hadn’t thought to look at. And Dex was still dead, and she was still (practically) widowed. Alongside her sadness, the next day held only yet more stress and misery – and she’d need to tidy up after the police, or tell Maria to. Then a hideous meeting with the PR firm Freuds, which Ruth and Miles had made abundantly clear she *had* to attend, to manage her ‘optics’, or some crap.

Unable to get back to sleep, Savannah watched a reel on her phone of her and Dex looking horribly happy at Goodwood Racecourse. Her sassy little fascinator had really suited her – but even that didn’t cheer her up. Refusing to cry again, Savannah fumbled in her bedside drawer for something to take the edge off, and searched up Dex online.

The *Mail* had a tribute by an awful romcom writer whose politics and values he’d secretly despised – the silly cow insinuating they’d had to fight to contain their attraction to each other. *Ha!* If only the old bat knew the

truth. And yet, it was one of the many things Savannah had loved about Dex, the way he was so kind and welcoming to nearly all; he'd never sneer at any of his authors behind their backs.

Tomorrow – or today, even – Langley & Co. would put out a statement about Violet. Of course, it was terribly tragic – but Savannah couldn't help thinking it was also kind of pathetic. The poor little thing had obviously had it bad for Dex, just like Savannah had seen on Saturday. But honestly, why take your own life when you were so young?

Frankly, Savannah liked life too much. Sure, she'd dabbled with one aspirin overdose at boarding school, after her first serious boyfriend shagged her archenemy in the gym block, but it really hadn't been worth the puke-inducing stomach pumping that ensued.

Anyway, poor Violet was gone, which was obviously sad, as was the fact she and Clara hadn't got far with their own list. She was nice, Clara, though. An ally, Savannah hoped, even if by far her inferior.

Just don't let me be next, she prayed, though God probably didn't have much time for her – she was too badly behaved. And there was a part of Savannah that agreed with Miles that the list was a gimmick. It was the kind of thing her own Comms department might have put out – far more tastefully, obviously – to promote an author.

With a sigh, Savannah got out of bed and traipsed into her ensuite bathroom. Exhausted, she gazed at her reflection and then, in horror, she turned very slowly, heart in her mouth.

On the wall behind her, words were written in some kind of green pen: words she hadn't noticed before. Words, in fact, she was pretty sure hadn't been there yesterday.

SOMEONE IS WATCHING YOU 🦴💜

CHAPTER 47

WEDNESDAY MORNING

At the crack of dawn in her kitchen, a yawning Clara went through Dex's edits for Rayne properly. There seemed to be an awful lot of rewriting required, and she was starting to suspect that Rayne had relied heavily on Dex to produce anything actually saleable.

Sample sentence: *Smoke Silva was big - but big thighs and big shoulders did not make him a complete tank except he thought he was and so luckily did the ladies.*

By the time the early morning sun flickered through the clouds, Clara felt washed out. She'd barely slept for days and contacting Violet's bereaved sister was on her mind – Stacey, Clara thought her name might be; a bereaved young woman with no close family left at all. Did she also keep imagining her sister's horrific death? For Clara, that awful image was now peppered with the officer's words about Violet's damaged face.

But it was Violet's terrified expression in that awful video that really haunted Clara – the video that had vanished into thin air. She hoped Phil might be able to help today; it felt vital to see it again and, maybe, there might be a clue there - if she could just locate it.

She sent Phil a quick voice note:

Could you help me when I get into the office later, please?

Remember what I asked you? It would be so helpful.

Except – did it even matter anymore? Violet was gone, and Clara had failed to save her. But as she chose her most dowdy dress and wearily brushed her hair, tying it back, instinct told her this wasn't done. If the author of the List was sticking to their own order, it would mean Jackson Rayne was next – and Clara was headed to him now...

Anxiety building once more, she sorted her stuff: notebook and phone, her new work laptop, and at least two pens. Check, check, check. Quickly, Clara brushed her best coat down – already two seasons old and a bit shabby, but it would have to do.

The nine a.m. news came on the radio – no mention of Langley & Co. today thank God – but Clara realised she was about to run late for the most prestigious writer she'd worked with in her short career.

'Bollocks!' Hunting for her boots in the hall closet, Clara tripped over Adam's gym bag, knocking something out of the side pocket.

'Leave it.' Her brother stood in the kitchen doorway, unpeeled banana in hand. 'I'll pick it up.'

'It's fine.' She grabbed the book. 'Are you off somewhere, today?' Clara glanced down at the copy of *Smokin' Gun* in her hand – the first thriller by Jackson Rayne. Inside, she could see a signature – *To Adamski. Keep smilin'*. 'Er – Adam, I thought you said -'

'I said *leave it*.' Snatching it from her, he disappeared into the kitchen, slamming the door.

'Keep your hair on!' Bemused, Clara hesitated in the hallway, but she was already cutting it fine. 'But hey, didn't you say you don't like books?'

No response, just the slam of a kitchen drawer.

She was torn – but she didn't have time to argue now.

*

Hurrying to the tube station, Clara could barely think straight. She was resilient; she'd had to be since her parents split up and her mum fell apart. But this confused heavy feeling was more than sadness, she thought, glancing over her shoulder.

She felt utterly alone and almost blank with fear.

Entering the station, Clara scanned the other commuters and found herself wondering, her hands tingling, now she was off to meet Jackson at the Soho Vibes Hotel – what if the author of the List struck again, and got them both in one go?

She stepped onto the escalator. And why the hell was her brother lying to her?

CHAPTER 48

WEDNESDAY MORNING

Pulling a cashmere throw round her shoulders, Savannah ran out of her room, screeching for Maria. 'Where are you?'

'Mrs Savannah?' Maria, in curlers, emerged blinking in the doorway of her room in her pink nightie, awoken for the second time in a few hours. Savannah had completely forgotten she'd given Maria the morning off.

'Who's been in the house since yesterday?' Savannah danced from foot to foot in agitation. 'Who did you let in?'

'No one – just you and me, Mrs Savannah.'

'Someone's been here, Maria.' Savannah stared at her housekeeper. 'Tell me the truth!'

'Only us, I swear.' The woman looked at once put out, weary and perturbed. 'You know I never lie to you.'

Which Savannah imagined was probably true – except she felt she didn't know anything, anymore.

*

A few hours later, cleaning her teeth in the guest bathroom to avoid the writing on her wall, the front gate buzzed and Savannah felt such a flood of terror, it almost knocked her off her feet. She grabbed onto the basin, heart hammering.

Darling girl, it's okay, just be smart. She heard Dex's voice so clearly, she almost looked round. *You're not in danger, right this second.*

The gate buzzed again, and Savannah reminded herself that whoever it was, they were on the far side of the gate; they couldn't get in. Plus, the last time she'd avoided someone at the front door, it had been that poor girl Violet – and now she was gone, too.

The door buzzed for a third time. Savannah picked up the upstairs intercom phone. 'Yes?'

'Mrs Langley, hi! You don't know me – my name's Fleur,' said a breathless young female voice. 'I'm from the *Armchair Detectives* YouTube channel, and I'd love to talk to you about the List.'

'Armchair *who*?' Savannah felt lightheaded from stress and fear. 'And how the hell do you know about the bloody List?'

'Everyone knows about the List, Mrs Langley,' Fleur's fresh young face beamed up at the camera. 'It's all over the internet. if you let me in, I can share what I've learned so far.'

'Hmmm.' Kylie skittered across the hallway towards Savannah as she considered her options. Would talking to this girl help? Perhaps they had information she needed to have, too...

'I'll give you ten minutes, then I've got to go out.' She buzzed the gate open. 'And it's Ms Langley. Make sure you walk up to the house with the security guard, right?'

But even as she said it, Savannah acknowledged with gut-wrenching sickness that whoever had scrawled on her mirror last night had got into the house somehow, guard or no guard.

CHAPTER 48

WEDNESDAY MORNING

The moment she walked through the doors of the Soho Vibes Hotel, Clara knew it was the kind of place that made her instantly nervous. The clientele was mainly young: ‘too cool for school’ types with stupid job titles like ‘Media Creative’ or ‘Design Jedi’. Here, they rubbed up against the usual trust-fund babies who peopled London’s private clubs and bars, alongside Euro-trash and American tourists, in town for a club or a show. The odd older finance or tech bro was here too, usually bald, too often on the lookout for young totty. Nothing made it a natural stomping ground for Clara.

‘I’m here to meet Jackson Rayne,’ she told the intimidating receptionist, who had slicked-back purple hair and a bad attitude. Clara wished she’d got round to re-dying her own hair – the pink was really faded now, but she’d either been too busy or too sad to bother, this past week.

‘Who shall I say?’ The receptionist picked up the desk phone.

‘Clara Voss, from Langley & Co.’

Waiting, she studied the brightly-lit lobby, full of weird modern art. A young couple, both wearing lurid fake fur, sat in one corner, kissing passionately over a pot of steaming tea; the bar behind them was busy, despite the relatively early hour.

‘He’s just finishing his current meeting, but he says please go up.’ The receptionist came round the desk and led Clara to the lifts. ‘Mr Rayne has the Greenhouse Suite on the top floor. He asks you to wait in the living room.’ He flashed her a fake smile. ‘I’ll send coffee up.’

*

On the top floor, Clara got out of the lift, ever more out of her comfort zone.

Have a word with yourself, Voss, she thought sternly. He’s only a man.

The Greenhouse Suite seemed to be the only rooms up here – big double doors at the end of the lushly decorated corridor. Unclenching her hands, Clara knocked and waited. When she got no response, pushing the doors took her into what was a small lounge, by the looks of it, with a retro sofa and small armchair; a big vase of roses on a table beside a bowl of unseasonal peaches; an ice bucket, full of Evian bottles. Beside them, an open laptop and a messy-looking notepad, covered in scrawls. The room was stuffy and warm, and full of exotic scents.

Taking her coat off, Clara sat cautiously at the table. Somewhere nearby, she thought she could hear Jackson, presumably on a call behind the lounge's far door. Pulling her Langley laptop out of her bag, Clara checked her notes.

By the time she'd gone through them again, Jackson still hadn't appeared. Bored, Clara peered at his notebook. His writing was illegible, a bit like a child's. Then she looked at his open laptop. His email inbox was on the screen, but a text message pinged up from Savannah Langley:

Hey soldier! You didn't answer my question: How the hell did you get past my gate on Monday night?

Clara flushed guiltily – presumably some kind of sex-talk. She was about to turn away when another name on the screen caught her eye – Violet. Surreptitiously, Clara pulled the laptop closer and started to read down the inbox list. Messages from Dex and others at Langley & Co., from last week.

Sliding her hand onto the mousepad, Clara scrolled a bit higher; a few from people she obviously didn't know; Barclays Bank; a girl called Sammi. And then a whole cluster from Violet; though only to be expected, given Violet had been Rayne's editor's PA.

But the last one she read leapt out: ***'LEAVE ME ALONE!!!!'***

Dear God! What the hell did that mean?

'Miss Voss?' A voice behind Clara made her jump, and she shoved Jackson's computer away.

'I brought you some coffee.' A young waiter moved across the thick pile carpet to deliver a cafetière and, with an amiable bow, dissolved back into thin air.

Clara wasn't sure caffeine was a good idea: it was already impossible to relax. Why was Rayne taking such a long time?

'You're not in danger, Voss,' she murmured, steadying herself with a deep breath. It was perfectly safe here, surely, she thought as her phone dinged.

Got your message – sure thing! Also, want 2 check the new monitor's solved the problem? Lemme know if u need more help ☺

From red-headed Phil in IT.

Ordinarily, Clara would have felt a twitch of excitement to hear from a guy she fancied, but right now, she was too on edge to appreciate it. Still, she was about to tap a message back when a voice called, 'Come on in, babe.'

Slowly, Clara stood and walked towards the next door. And she couldn't help wondering, for no good reason other than being completely frazzled, was this it, finally? Would the reason she was on the List now become clear?

Without thinking too hard, she texted Phil back:

If I vanish I'm at the Soho Vibes send help!

CHAPTER 49

WEDNESDAY MORNING

By the time the YouTuber called Fleur had reached her doorstep, Savannah had changed her mind about talking, not least because the youngster had just walked up the garden path with the smirking security guard.

‘Damn it.’ Ishan hadn’t done what she’d asked.

Savannah voice-noted him: *‘Ish, I asked you to get Parliament Security to swap out this creepy guy who’d smirked at me yesterday. Can you do that ASAP, ’cos he’s still bloody here and I don’t want him on my property.’*

So sorry, Ishan texted back immediately, ***I did leave them a message; I’ll chase now.***

Normally he was so reliable, Savannah thought, chucking her phone down, but probably the Violet thing had thrown him off. They’d been close. And it reminded her that bloody Jackson still hadn’t responded either. Honestly, men. All men – except Dex.

‘So, Fleur.’ Savannah sat the girl down as the housekeeper brought tea. ‘What can you do for me? Or rather, what do you know that I don’t?’

‘Well—’ Fleur got out a little electronic notebook, ‘—we’re working on a hypothesis...’

Listening to the enthusiastic spiel, Savannah understood their main theory was a half-baked idea about jealous writers and superfans of Jackson Rayne. Angry he’d not won Best Crime Writer Award (which had gone to Elly Griffiths), these fans had apparently started the List to punish Langley & Co. ‘Because, look – everyone who’s on it works there.’

‘But how would these fans know Jackson wasn’t going to win? The List was published the same night.’ Savannah narrowed her eyes at Fleur. ‘And it wasn’t Langley’s fault, anyway. They don’t get to choose the award-winners.’

‘The whole list wasn’t published that night, from what we understand, though.’ The girl sat back. ‘Can I ask, what exactly do you know about Jackson Rayne’s fanbase?’

‘That they love good writing?’ Savannah pinched her fingers together hard. She felt a prickle of discomfort at being in a room with a stranger who must have seen the video of her and Rayne fucking. Good job she was due at the PRs by 2 p.m.

‘Nice theory, but there’s no evidence, is there?’ Savannah stood up. ‘I need to get ready.’

‘But what else do you know?’ the girl pressed. ‘About his fans?’

‘That they buy his books in droves? Look, leave your contact details, and if I think of anything...’ Savannah had zero intention of thinking. She was more interested in who’d written on her bathroom wall, and what she should wear to Freuds; something stark but demure, sexy but sensible.

‘Please, Ms Langley,’ the girl insisted, ‘I think it’s important. Have you heard of The Red Pillars? They’re an online group of incels.’

‘What are incels?’

‘Involuntary celibates. Men who can’t get women to like them, and think women are out to destroy them.’

‘Oh, them.’ Savannah’s mind whirled. ‘And what’s that got to do with the List?’

‘We think Rayne’s followers may be behind some of the Red Pillars stuff. Worse, in fact.’

‘Jackson?’ Savannah felt her heart speed up. ‘But he has zero problem getting women.’ And then she did flush. God, what was happening to her?

‘Well, sure, but...’ Fleur didn’t seem to notice, rummaging in her bag for something. ‘There is this.’ She produced a folder of internet printouts: message threads and other online content. ‘It’s very nasty. Total sexist

rubbish, the worst kind of misogyny. And I should give you a trigger warning...' Fleur flushed a bit herself, now. 'Your name is mentioned.'

Against her will, Savannah glanced at it, skimming some of the nastier comments until she was drawn in by the vitriol, and then by her own name.

Sexy Savanna? What a stacy I wouldn't would you? 0/10

Trust fund Princess thought she was untouchable - but 1 thing daddy's \$\$ can't buy back is a deleted video lol

LMAO 😂 the heiress sex tape. bet daddy's PR team is working overtime. some things £ can't scrub & dead simp boyfriend too

'Wow!' The young woman wasn't wrong: it was highly poisonous. Savannah read on a bit, absorbing the way she was insulted; the sexually vile language. 'Well, yes, I can see it's horrible,' Feeling a bit sick, Savannah looked back at Fleur. 'But what's it got to do with Jackson?'

'It appears to come from a proxy account.'

Savannah stared at her blankly. 'Right?'

'A proxy account masks a real IP address,' Fleur explained patiently, as if to a child. 'But there are ways to get through the layers of supposed privacy, and our top computer dude is near cracking this one. Once we can see who it belongs to, we'll know who originated most of this vile content.'

'So?'

'So!' Fleur beamed again, as if it was all super-exciting. 'It seems it's the same person who wrote the List.'

'What makes you say that?'

'Because they're sharing an IP address.' Fleur was still patient. 'And by the way, IP addresses are linked to real addresses.'

'Okay – so where is the list coming from?'

'Langley & Co.'

CHAPTER 50

WEDNESDAY MORNING

Outside the door to the next room, a thousand horror films flashed through Clara's head – but she wasn't going to get murdered here in broad daylight in a smart hotel, was she? It wasn't an actual slasher flick -

Clara! Don't be so dramatic! she chided herself – but it didn't help.

She paused for a second to listen, but things were hushed and silent. 'Hi?' She pushed the right-hand door gently. 'Anyone here?' She stepped inside cautiously, making sure she left the doors open behind her. She wasn't stupid, after all.

Inside, the thick curtains were drawn, no natural light filtering through at all, just a solitary candle lit on the mantelpiece.

'Hello?' Clara repeated, louder this time. Straining to see in the dark, it took a few seconds to compute that someone was on the enormous double bed. Filled with dread, taking another step, she saw a young woman, lying curled up on her side.

Violet!

'Are you okay?' Clara rushed to the bed, able to see now that the figure's wrists were tied. No, not even tied, but in handcuffs. 'Are you alone?'

But as she stood over her, realising this girl was taller and curvier than Violet, suddenly the bedroom door slammed shut behind them.

'Shit.' Clara could see now the girl was wearing a blindfold, her blouse unbuttoned. 'Who did this?' Clara bent to help her when a voice drawled,

'Hello, babes.'

Frozen on the spot, as Clara peered over her shoulder, she made out a figure standing in the doorway. He moved into the room, and she caught a whiff of aftershave she recognised.

'Hi, hot stuff,' Jackson Rayne growled in her ear. 'Ready to play?'

‘Play what?’ Clara stuttered and she looked down again at the woman on the bed, and thought, *do I recognise her?* ‘What have you done to her? Have you hurt her?’

‘God, no. And nothing she totally isn’t up for.’

The girl on the bed gave a slow smile.

‘It’s time for fun, little Clara.’ Jackson clasped her wrist in one strong hand, trying to force her to sit on the bed. On the other side stood an ice bucket full of Champagne, Clara realised, as she wriggled to get out of his grasp.

‘Please, don’t.’ But his grip was so strong. ‘Let me go.’

‘Bit of resistance, eh? Watch out, babes, or I’ll have to tie you up, too.’ Without warning, he’d produced a reel of thin rope from somewhere, spinning it in the air. ‘I bet you like it rough, hey?’

‘No, I don’t,’ Clara spluttered, banging her hand against him to get him to let go. ‘What the hell are you doing?’

For a second, the look on Jackson’s face was unreadable; his eyes hooded in the dark room. What was the expression?

‘But Clara, you said yesterday, you liked old Silva’s antics...’

‘What?’ she fumed. ‘I didn’t mean this kind of antics.’

‘This is just a recreation of the scene in *Dead Man Dead*.’ Jackson Rayne gazed at her, his teeth luminous in the gloom. ‘Don’t you remember? The girl on the bed, and the threesome with the ranger?’

‘I haven’t read it,’ Clara said shakily – thinking that was surely the most stupid title she’d ever heard.

‘Oh, dear!’ Rayne dropped her wrist. ‘I got this one all wrong, did I?’ He started laughing. ‘You little scaredy cat. Me and Tiffany was only messing.’ He sat on the bed and slipped the girl’s blindfold off. ‘We was only larking around, weren’t we, Tiff?’

'Yeah.' Tiffany sat up. "Course,' she purred, looking up at Jackson from under long lashes as he unlocked her handcuffs. 'Just a joke.'

'Right, well, if you don't mind...' Clara could feel actual sweat dripping down her back. 'I'd like to leave, now.' It was so hot in there, and she'd never felt so uncomfortable before in a supposed work scenario. 'If we're not doing any edits today, I'll go.' She inched towards the door. 'If that's okay.'

Why was she asking if it was okay, though? Inside, she was raging.

'Be my guest, babes.' He semi-smiled. 'Trot off.' Jackson had tired of the game, she could tell. As her eyes acclimatised to the gloom, Clara could see Tiffany walking pointy-nailed fingers up his muscled arm. The pair were obviously more than ready for her to leave.

'This isn't alright,' Clara sputtered, in outraged upset. 'It really isn't.'

'Clara, love.' Jackson looked worried now. 'I'm so sorry – I misread the situation.' He stood up and spread his hands in a plea. 'This very much isn't my normal MO. Let me make it up to you. Dinner?'

'S'fine.' Clara backed out of the room, desperate to leave. 'I'll – just let me know when you want to work on the book, okay? Thanks.'

Grabbing the bag she'd dropped, Clara fled, the girl's laughter ringing in her ears, Jackson's apologies falling into the void.

CHAPTER 51

WEDNESDAY LUNCHTIME

As Clara burst out onto the street, breathless and upset, it seemed very odd to be back in normality. Trying to contain her anger, the hubbub of London continued as ever all around her: the buzzing cafes, the buskers and the tourists alongside Londoners going about their everyday business. She dodged round a street cleaner and stood to take a breath.

But even as Clara collected herself, a figure hurrying away ahead of her caught her eye – a tall lanky form jogging round an elderly Japanese couple and their silly selfie-stick. Someone she was sure she recognised – the red jacket with a streak of black paint down the left arm, from when the main block's stairwell was still wet.

'Hey!' she called. 'Wait.'

But the figure didn't turn back, just kept speeding ahead of her.

'Adam?' she shouted, hurrying after him. She was sure it had been her brother, though. And if it was, why on earth was he here?

*

By the time Clara reached the tube station, having lost the person she'd been following, she was starting to wonder if she might be about to lose her job. Rejecting Rayne might turn out to be a really bad move -

Trying to catch her breath, her phone rang.

'Clara?' A worried male voice. 'That you? Are you okay?'

'Phil.' She flushed pinker, already hot-cheeked from the ebbing adrenaline.

'What was that weird text message about?' he demanded. 'You had me really stressed for a sec.'

'Sorry.' Embarrassed, worried about grassing Jackson up, Clara stalled. 'It was kind of something and nothing.' A woman barged into Clara at the tube entrance, making Clara almost drop her phone. 'Thanks, love,' she muttered, hauling it back to her ear.

'How about,' Phil was saying, 'I buy you a drink later, and cheer you up?'

'Oh,' she said stupidly. 'Yes, thanks, that sounds great.'

She needed to get back to the safety of the office, and she needed someone on side to help her understand what might be going on.

CHAPTER 52

WEDNESDAY AFTERNOON

The first brilliant flash shocked Savannah; the second blinded her as she stepped out of the PR firm's offices on High Holborn.

'Hey, sexy Sav,' a voice cried. 'Had any good table sex, recently?'

'Over here,' someone else shouted, the bulbs popping, one after the other. 'Show us your tits, love.'

'Fuck.' Savannah hadn't anticipated the paparazzi today, but here they were, out in full force. It had only been a matter of time, she supposed, as she put her head down and hurried towards the Mercedes.

'Savannah, hey, Savvi! When's the sex tape released officially?' The bulbs flashed on and on as Danvers leaped out to open the car door for her. Just in time, before she lost it and took a swing at a photographer.

'Are you hurt, Mrs Langley?' Danvers asked as Savannah tumbled inelegantly onto the backseat.

'I'm fine, thanks. Please, let's just get out of here.'

'Home, ma'am?'

'Sure.' In fact, the last place Savannah wanted to go was home, just to be alone yet again, but it looked like that was the only option, right now.

Tired but jittery now the paparazzi had appeared, Savannah rested her head on the back of the seat and watched central London become greener as the car cut through Hyde Park. She didn't know who'd alerted the papers to her whereabouts, but maybe it was the PRs themselves: stranger things had happened.

Savannah needed all this crap to come to an end, as she imagined the PR company would agree. The meeting just now had been deeply humiliating.

Their advice was the usual crisis management: keep quiet and do something for charity as soon as possible. They'd try to source the origin of the sex tape leak, but once footage was on the net, it was almost impossible to retrieve it.

'What we might be able to do, though,' the senior PR had suggested with a glint in his eye, 'is turn it to your advantage. You know, spin it.'

'How?' Savannah had sat up straighter.

'We've already had a proposal from Anne Summers for you to model their new range...'

'Tell me you're joking?' She wrinkled her nose. 'Really not my style – penis pasta and sweaty pink PVC.'

'Sure, but it got us thinking. If we use your sexuality as a kind of... *weapon of retaliation*, like, a mark of female pride, it might work.' He pushed his expensive frameless glasses up his nose. 'My best people are on it, don't worry. For now, just lay low.'

Savannah stood and put on her floor-length fake fur. 'Believe me, I'm trying.'

But laying low wasn't that easy in a family like the Langleys. Their disasters and downfalls were fodder for the gossip mags, Savannah was only too aware; newspaper editors had the whole family on speed-dial, so at least Savannah could block them when she wanted to. Except the paps had turned up in unison today, which meant she was a target.

As the car crawled towards Notting Hill, Savannah called her twin – but, as usual recently, it went straight to voicemail.

'When are you back in the UK, Bella?' she said, after the beep. 'Come and stay with me! It'll be like old times.'

Which would probably involve them having a huge row about something daft, of course – but if there was one person in the world

Savannah truly trusted, it was her twin sister. And she could really use the company.

In the end, full of too much nervous energy to sit still, despite her exhaustion, she tapped the glass divider between the front and back seats. 'Thank you, Danvers, I'll walk from here.'

As Savannah strode towards home, she kept to the busiest side of the street.

God only knew where the next threat was coming from.

*

At the house, Savannah waved at the guards, whom she now secretly hated, and locked the front door behind her. She fed the dog Kylie half a packet of smoked salmon, ate the other half herself, and ran upstairs.

Stripping off the stupid demure dress, she donned shorts and a vest top and, mounting her Peloton bike, rode it for miles like a demon was on her tail. Then, sweaty and panting, she dismounted, went downstairs and ate a whole tub of Cookie Dough Dynamo, then got back on the bike to burn it off.

But none of it helped. Not one bit.

She craved the deadening buzz of downing so much booze she couldn't think. She craved the strongest pills; she craved the oblivion she'd sought when her ex-husband Simon had hurt her so badly; had turned out to be a cheat and a liar. Thank God Ruth had made her sign that pre-nup.

At the front of Savannah's mind, however fast she pedalled, was Dex, and at the back, pounding after her like she was a deer in their sights, thoughts of those who wanted to hurt her.

If only she had some idea who they were. Her survival instinct was kicking in now, because she knew that if she didn't find out soon, she'd end

up like Dex and Violet. Stone dead. Her attempt with Clara to work out who might be doing this had led to nothing. She liked Clara, but she clearly knew no more than Savannah did – and the ticking clock was almost out of time on the latest version of the List.

Savannah got off the bike, poured a triple straight vodka and searched for her private doctor's number, to ask for a Xanax prescription. Being sensible be damned.

CHAPTER 53

WEDNESDAY AFTERNOON

‘Adam, why aren’t you answering?’ Clara stomped out of Bond Street Station on her phone, thoroughly discombobulated. ‘Was that you just now in Dean Street in Soho? Didn’t you hear me calling you?’

On the tube, she’d emailed Langley’s HR department, asking for a number for either Violet’s sister or her flatmate. Obviously, they’d have already known that poor Violet’s body had been found, but she wanted to say how sorry she was. And she wanted to know if they had any sort of clue whatsoever about what the hell was going on.

She checked the latest version of the List: the time clock was into minus hours.

*

Back in the office, Clara was terrified that Ruth would either arrive at her desk – unlikely to be honest, given how Ruth never mixed with the hoi polloi – or that her desk phone would ring, and Ruth would demand to know how the Jackson meeting had gone. Or worse, be calling to sack Clara after he’d probably complained about her.

Still too anxious to eat, around two, Clara grabbed a cup of tea from the nearest kitchen.

‘Ruth’s in New York, wining and dining Tom Cruise, lucky cow. After his memoir,’ she overheard someone say. ‘What a life he’s led.’

Honestly, Clara couldn’t have felt more relieved to know Ruth was out of the office, today.

But all afternoon, however hard she tried to concentrate on the edits for the psychological thriller *The Stalker*, she kept feeling Jackson Rayne’s steely grasp round her wrist.

Did Langley know that Jackson Rayne was potentially a predator? She kept thinking about Violet's text message on the night of the Book Awards – did it mean Violet had known? But - who else did?

'A delivery for you.' Maude walked up to her desk, her little patent shoes shining like mirrors. She passed Clara a bound document. 'Jackson's latest edits of *Leave Me Alone*.'

'*Leave me Alone*?' Clara repeated, staring at the words on the cover. 'Hang on, is that the name of the new book? No one told me—'

'Yes, and the title's on Miles Langley's instruction. I suggest you take it up with him, if you don't like it.' As demure and upright as ever, Maude walked away, leaving Clara feeling even more confused.

*

Around five, the computer nerd Phil arrived at her desk. 'Your carriage awaits,' he said, smiling at her.

'My carriage?' She suddenly felt like a bashful Cinderella.

'Yeah, Shanks' pony.' He pointed at his feet. 'C'mon, then. I'm parched.'

'Hey, you two.' Ishan was suddenly there, too. 'Going for a beverage?'

Clara looked at Phil. Maybe it wasn't a date, maybe it was just a sympathy drink. Sympathy for what, though? Being Violet's bereaved mate? Being on the bloody List?

'Let's all go.' Phil grinned at them both. 'Make a night of it.'

Clara got that sinking feeling you get when you've been looking forward to something, and then it turns out very different.

'Great. The Three Horsemen?' Ishan said. 'I just need to finish up – meet you there.'

*

The olde-worlde pub on the far corner of Portman Square was half empty and, typically, the other half was full of Langley staff. Clara waved at another editor she'd done her internship with, and found a cute little table away from the big TV. It had two little leather armchairs in front of the fake fire, flickering in the grate.

Phil fetched the drinks as Clara sat, sneaking a look at herself in the mirror. She resisted getting her lip gloss out, but tousled her hair a bit, interrupted by several loud sirens wailing past outside.

'Someone's in trouble.' Phil popped her drink down, and sank into the other armchair. 'It's very Harry Potter in here, isn't it? I've always loved it.' He cheersed her with his glass. 'A pint of butterbeer. C'mon then, Clara, what's this something and nothing? Sounds a bit scary to me.'

'Well.' Clara took a sip, unsure how much detail she dared go into. She barely knew Phil, but he had a nice, open face, and she felt strangely comfortable with him. Plus, with no Violet at Langley anymore, she needed someone to talk to. 'The thing is...'

'Hold that thought! I'll put some tunes on.' Maybe Phil sensed her unease and was giving her a minute as he headed to the old jukebox.

A minute later, the sexy song from the film *Love Actually* came on, 'Too Lost in You', and Clara felt a little flare of hope about Phil's motives.

'Why did you choose this tune?' she asked shyly as he sat again.

'My finger slipped on the button.' He pulled a face. 'I was trying for the Sugarcubes, not the bloody Sugababes. It's awful, isn't it?'

Clara tried not to feel daft. 'I quite like it, actually.'

'*Love* actually, don't you mean?' He winked. 'Go on then, tell me what happened earlier. Are you okay?'

'Yeah. Well, no...'

The door swung open, letting in a blast of freezing air, followed by two of the more poisonous Henriettas. Clara sighed and sat back, defeated. She valued her job more than the story was worth, even though she was dying to share it with someone. 'I mean, it was nothing, really.'

'Can't have been nothing though, you sounded so stressed.' His hazel eyes were encouraging. 'I won't tell anyone, if you're worried about that.'

'Well...' Clara took a deep breath. 'I just had a bit of an... odd meeting with Jackson Rayne. I went to do some edits with him at his flashy hotel in Soho, and I was just... a bit out of my depth. He got a bit... full on.'

'That dude.' Phil shook his head, sadly. 'His reputation precedes him.'

'Oh, really?' Clara was curious. 'What have you heard?'

'Few things, like, he's a bit of a player. More than a bit, in fact. Like, properly handsy, someone told me.'

'Really? Which someone?'

'Hmm.' He looked thoughtful. 'I think it might have been Violet.'

'That's weird, 'cos I saw an email from Violet to him saying *leave me alone*,' Clara mused. 'But then I clocked it was the working title of his new thriller, so I guess Violet might have just been referring to that.'

'What did Violet refer to?' Ishan appeared beside them, holding a glass of what looked like water.

'Nothing.' Clara stared at Phil, willing him not to say anything about Jackson and her meeting.

'We were just saying, poor Violet.' Phil read her mind, and Clara felt a little flush of excitement again that he had her back. 'So sad.'

'Oh God, I know!' Ishan pulled up a stool and sat, taking off his glasses to polish them. 'I can't believe she's really gone.'

'You know, I wanted to ask you something, Ish.' Phil's pleasant face turned solemn. 'That last night, at the Buzzy Bar...'

‘On Saturday, you mean?’ Ishan narrowed his eyes, as if thinking back.
‘What about it?’

‘Yeah, I just wondered, where did you and Violet go?’

‘What?’ Ishan shook his head, serious too now. ‘What do you mean?’

‘You went outside for a while, the pair of you, and then she was gone. I mean, she didn’t come back in.’ Phil took another sip of beer. ‘I just wondered – was she okay, then?’

‘You’ve got that wrong, mate. I didn’t go outside with her.’ Ishan shook his head again, and pushed his glasses up his nose. ‘I was inside all night.’

‘I don’t think so. I was standing with Maude’s gang at the bar, and Maude made some catty comment about you and Vi.’ Phil looked at the other guy curiously. ‘That’s why I remember.’

‘Well, Maude’s full of bullshit, we all know that. Wherever Violet went, I wasn’t with her. I was in the bar all night.’ Ishan stood up and stretched. ‘Anyone for a game of darts?’

But for all his nonchalance, Clara could sense the tension in Ishan. Which one of them was telling the truth, she wondered?

‘I’m no good at darts.’ Phil shrugged. ‘But I’ll give it a go.’

Halfway through the first round, Ishan’s phone beeped. ‘Oh, bollocks.’ He peered at it. ‘I forgot something at work. Be right back.’

*

It didn’t take long for Clara to realise how bad she was at the game. Her darts kept hitting the wall, and Phil was laughing when her phone rang.

Adam’s number flashed up. ‘Hello?’ But it was so loud in the pub, she couldn’t hear. Mouthing at Phil that she’d be a minute, she ran outside.

‘Hello?’ But standing on the pavement, she realised her brother wasn’t on the end of the line. In the dark, she was peering at the phone to ring him back when without warning, a figure hurled itself at her.

‘Oh my...’ Clara went flying forwards, grabbing onto the lamppost beside her before she fell flat on her face. From her awkward position, she could see a moped that had just mounted the pavement, missing her by centimetres, and was now roaring off.

‘God, are you okay?’ Ishan offered her his hand.

She was too stunned to move for a second.

On the far side of the square, people were shouting. ‘Ow.’ Her knee was sore and grazed as she took Ishan’s hand. ‘That hurts.’

‘Sorry but I had to act fast, Clara, that bike was about to hit you.’ He pulled her up and put an arm around her shoulders. ‘What a freak. Bloody delivery drivers.’

‘I’m okay.’ Shaken but not really hurt, the two of them went back inside, to find the whole pub quiet and staring at the big screen in the corner.

‘What’s going on?’ she asked Phil.

‘It’s Langley & Co.,’ he pointed helplessly at the screen. ‘Can’t believe it-’

‘According to eyewitnesses, three gunshots were heard about twenty minutes ago,’ a picture of the Langley HQ flashed up. *‘The reported target was the bestselling crime writer Jackson Rayne,’* a male presenter in a black anorak was saying, police cars parked behind him on the square. *‘Just here behind me, he was coming in for a meeting, apparently, when he was shot by a masked gunman, who then made off on a moped.’* Now, there was a montage of photos of Jackson Rayne. *‘Reports say the writer was immediately whisked to nearby Chelsea & Westminster Hospital, but it’s too early for an update on his condition.’* The reporter threw to the newsreader in the studio.

‘Thanks, John. Shocking indeed. Recent events suggest Mr Rayne is on some kind of anonymous hit list which, until yesterday, was believed to be a

hoax. However, what with Langley's top editor Dex Harris dying on Sunday morning, and the suicide of Dex Harris' assistant Violet Childs who was also on the hit list, it's starting to look like it's very bad luck for these Langley & Co. colleagues.'

A shiver went through the room and Ishan patted Clara's arm comfortingly.

Now a photo of Dex Harris was on screen, looking very suave, followed by more arial footage of the Langley & Co. building, and a montage of book covers by famous Langley authors. *'More news as we get it. Now, the weather for the UK is set to get a bit stormy, tonight...'*

They turned away from the TV in shock.

'Bloody hell,' Ishan said. 'This is all getting a bit *Bourne Identity*.'

'It really is,' Phil agreed, picking up his darts again.

'It's more like a horror film,' Clara muttered, her knee sore.

'Didn't you see something just now, Ishan?'

'No. I just went to get my Oyster card.' He flushed a bit. 'I mean, there might have been a police car, but I was on my phone so -'

Clara zoned out of their chat, overwhelmed by such a tumult of emotion, she wasn't quite sure what to do. That was three of them on the List gone, or catastrophically injured. Had that bike just nearly hit her on purpose?

Casting a nervous look around, Clara thought, she couldn't just stay there like easy prey – she should go home to safety. If home was safe...

Savannah was the only other person who might know what was going on – but they hadn't even swapped numbers.

'I don't suppose you know where Savannah lives, Ish?'

'I do, actually.' He looked surprised. 'Notting Hill, off Holland Park Road. Amazing house. Why?'

‘Can you show me?’

‘What, like, go there?’ Ish looked worried, now. ‘I mean, I’ve only been once, and I don’t know if we can just turn up...’

‘I can.’ Clara’s legs were shaky as she felt her phone vibrating in her jacket pocket. She answered so fast, she hadn’t seen who was calling.

‘Adam?’

‘Not last time I looked.’ A female voice – posh, kind of smooth and creamy. ‘It’s Savannah Langley. Have you seen the news?’

‘Hi. I saw about Jackson, if that’s what you meant? Is he okay?’

‘I don’t know. I hope so, obviously.’ Savannah didn’t wait for a reply. ‘Come over to my house in Notting Hill? Jump in a black cab, and I’ll pay.’

‘But why?’ Clara asked slowly.

‘Well, Clara,’ Savannah purred. ‘Maths was never my strong point, but even I know, there’s only two of us left on the List. So, let’s put our heads back together, shall we? Before it’s too late.’

CHAPTER 54

WEDNESDAY NIGHT

Savannah put the phone down and peered through her white linen blinds again.

For once, that bloody grey Audi wasn't lurking outside her front railings: along with the paparazzi and the security guards, all these people being constantly 'around' was getting on her nerves.

None of them were Dex, and he was the only person she wanted. And knowing that wasn't going to happen – she was a realist, after all – the next thing on Savannah's own list was the desire to survive, herself.

She was just praying Clara would have some more information that might help – before it was curtains for them both.

*

'Can I get you a drink?' Savannah let a nervous Clara in, half an hour later.

'Sure,' Clara said as Kylie the Chihuahua growled at her from the safety of the doorway. 'Maybe a cup of tea?'

'Sorry about her,' Savannah led the way into the enormous kitchen, the little dog skittering behind. 'Thinks she's a Rottweiler.'

'Bless her!' Clara peered down. 'She's not exactly scary, is she?'

A Rottweiler wasn't a bad idea, Savannah thought absently, putting on the kettle – one of the few items in the kitchen she actually knew how to use. 'Basket, Kylie.' The little dog pitter-pattered to a giant fluffy basket under the exotic hanging plants, tended to by the gardener.

'Please, pull up a really uncomfortable stool,' Savannah said wryly, and Clara grinned.

'Thanks.'

With steaming mugs of chamomile tea in front of them, the two women sat opposite one another among the kitchen's steel and shiny surfaces.

Again, Savannah thought how attractive Clara was – healthy and earthy. In fact, she kind of reminded Savannah of someone, though she couldn't think who, right now.

'It's so weird and scary and awful.' Clara looked pained. 'I feel a bit like I'm going mad.'

'Look, sod the tea. Shall we have something stronger?' Savannah pushed her mug away. 'Needs must, I think. Vodka? Rum? Tequila?'

'Vodka sounds good,' Clara agreed – to Savannah's relief. 'Thanks. I had a bit of a shock, just now.'

'Oh? What happened?'

'A bike nearly took me out. Accident, probably, but well, it's all a bit tense, isn't it?' Clara's smile was shaky. 'What do you know about Jackson?'

'He's survived, thank God.' Savannah opened a discreet but enormous wine fridge. 'One bullet went in his upper arm, missing anything vital. They're removing the bullet in surgery.'

'Well, that's a relief. Still terrifying though, isn't it?'

'You've obviously seen the sex tape.' Given recent events, Savannah decided it was time to stop beating round the bush, which is almost what Jackson had done that night -

'Not really...' Clara blushed.

'Don't be embarrassed, darling. I'd have watched it if I were you.'

'I haven't watched it,' Clara protested. 'I mean, I didn't like, *watch it*, watch it...'

'Whatever.' Fetching two diamond-cut shot glasses from a cupboard, Savannah broke the seal of the Grey Goose bottle. 'I was very drunk and Dex

was – let's just say, understanding. Or at least, I thought he was. But I couldn't ask him, because then he was dead. And that's the worst bit of it for me, right now.'

'I see.'

'But this List is really riling me now.' Savannah poured, drank and poured again. '*Santé*,' she toasted Clara. 'Here's to survival of the fittest.'

'Cheers.' Clara coughed on the fiery liquid. 'Wow, that's strong. And I agree, being the last two on the List is pretty shit.' She looked at Savannah nervously. 'Scuse my language.'

'Darling, I don't care what bloody language you use.' Savannah sat down with a sigh. 'All I want to do now is work out what to do, before we both meet our ends, too. The police are obviously next to useless, even though they've searched the house and taken my Ring doorbell.' She drained her shot glass. 'So, any new ideas?'

'Not really,' Clara was saying when Savannah's house phone rang. The only person who ever called her on it was Bella.

'Are you okay, darl?' Bella asked, a cacophony of birdsong behind her.

'Are you in an aviary?' Savannah stared out at the front garden as she listened to her twin's voice. 'And did you see about Jackson Rayne?'

'About you and him?'

'No, about him just getting shot.'

'Oh, shit!' Bella breathed. 'Is he dead too? I'm flying back tomorrow after we meet Seb in Nice, on his way to the Monaco Grand Prix. I'll come over then. Sorry I haven't been back for you sooner – we had to finish out here, first.'

'Oh, Dex was meant to go to the Grand Prix with Seb. I'd totally forgotten all about it.' Savannah gazed at Dex's little silver racing car; the

car he'd loved like a baby, that sometimes he'd just go and sit in, purely because he couldn't believe it was really his.

The car...

'Oh my God,' Savannah said slowly. 'Sorry, Bel, I need to go. Call me as soon as you land, yeah?' She hung up and rushed to the door. 'Dex's Aston Martin.'

'What?' Clara stood. 'What about it?'

'It's where he always went when he felt bad, or worried, or had to think. It was like his second home. I haven't looked in it since he died, but...' Savannah was halfway down the path already, car keys in hand.

She had a gut feeling she'd find something, now – something the police didn't know about. Some kind of answer.

Dex wouldn't let her down, surely – not this time.

*

The car smelled so strongly of Dex – of sandalwood aftershave and leather – that Savannah's memories rushed back, knocking all the air from her lungs.

Sitting in the driver's seat, after a few minutes, she composed herself enough to open the glovebox, though her hands trembled on the catch.

Nothing, except some Liquorice Allsorts and an old French map.

She checked the driver's door: just a pair of Ray-Bans. Then she slid a hand under the driver's seat, and her fingers closed round a metallic object: a phone, wrapped in a piece of paper.

Not a phone she immediately recognised, which made her heart lurch horribly. But she knew he'd used a work phone and a personal one, so it wasn't that odd. She tried to switch it on, but of course, it was dead.

Savannah got out of the car and walked slowly back to the house, feeling rather vacant. The meds on top of booze mightn't have been a great idea...

'Are you alright?' Clara asked, apparently worried.

'Me? Oh, yeah. We need a charger.' Savannah flung open the messiest kitchen drawer, full of random rubbish, and scrabbled through it. 'Here!' Triumphantly she plugged it in, and then spread the bit of paper the phone had been wrapped in on the counter.

Both women stared at the writing.

'What the hell does that mean?'

CHAPTER 55

WEDNESDAY NIGHT

'PeOPle are Going TO Suffer if U don't ACT,' said the badly scrawled writing. Half in capitals, and kind of familiar to Clara, but not familiar enough to identify; scribbled on a sheet of printer paper, by the looks of it, blank on the back.

'I think we need another one.' Savannah waved the bottle at Clara.

'I'm good, thanks.' Clara was remembering a vague rumour of Savannah being in rehab, around the time Clara started at Langley. It was none of her business what these rich folk did, though. She stared at the note. 'Who do you think wrote this? Not Dex, surely?'

'God no. He had lovely writing.' Savannah topped her own glass up. 'Those YouTuber Detectives mentioned Jackson Rayne's fans -'

'Yes, I saw their report outside Violet's flat - but I don't see why Rayne fans would be after Dex?'

'It doesn't make much sense, but the girl Fleur said there's a proxy account, in Jackson's name, masking whoever's behind all this. The IP address is at Langley,' Savannah's eyes were a bit unfocussed, Clara thought, gazing at her, 'but I still don't really know what it means.'

'Hang on,' Clara said eagerly, 'they said the account's coming from within Langley?' So, despite her brother Adam showing her that stuff online the other night: threads Jackson had liked, misogynistic Men's Rights waffle, the 'take women down' videos that he'd been watching, and Clara's panic about Adam lying about being in Soho earlier, along with Jackson's book being in his bag - he couldn't be behind anything coming directly from Langley...

‘So that means it has to be one of the staff?’ Savannah said, as Dex’s dead phone started to light up.

‘Look! Maybe some answer might be on this?’

‘The thing I don’t get is—’ Savannah ignored her, ‘—why Dex went back to Langley that night. It makes no sense.’

‘Have you checked he definitely came home, first? After the awards.’

‘No. I mean, I’m not sure how I could? The CCTV doesn’t work.’

‘You mentioned a Ring doorbell?’

‘Yeah, sure, but the police took it.’

‘Well, they must know. Have you asked them?’

‘Definitely not. They thought I killed him.’

‘But if you want to see, don’t you have the Ring app on your phone?’

‘The app? No. What does it do?’

‘It records the footage of who’s outside your door. A lot of us have them on my estate.’ Clara felt herself blush.

‘Estate?’ Savannah looked confused.

‘Council estate,’ Clara tried to look blasé. She couldn’t be intimidated by this woman’s inherited wealth. ‘Cos it’s... it can be a bit dodgy.’

‘Sounds like a good idea. I’m a bit clueless about tech stuff – Dex took care of that sort of thing.’ Savannah faltered.

‘Well, that’s okay, isn’t it?’ Clara sensed the older woman’s distress, her gorgeous face flushed with drink and emotion. ‘What about this phone?’ Clara pointed. ‘Maybe Dex had the app?’

‘Maybe,’ Savannah said slowly, pulling it towards her. ‘You - you have a look. You know what you’re looking for.’

‘But I don’t know the passcode.’

‘There’s a list on my computer.’ Savannah pushed her laptop to Clara. ‘Go for your life. I’ll just be a minute.’

*

Clara opened the phone, and located the Ring app, rewinding to Saturday night – the night of Dex’s death. It wasn’t long before she found him arriving in the black cab, around 11.28 p.m.

‘Savannah?’ she called. ‘I found something.’

Savannah returned from the bathroom, and Clara couldn’t help noticing she staggered a little as Clara held out the phone to show her.

‘Oh my God!’ Savannah gasped. ‘There he is, the darling man.’

How odd to see Dex alive and well, Clara thought, so suave in his tux, dark hair swept back. It was only a few days ago —

‘Dear God, I can’t believe I won’t see him again in this life,’ Savannah choked, and Clara put a tentative hand on her arm.

The two women watched as Dex paid the taxi driver, then the footage jumped to show him coming up the front steps, key in hand, then letting himself in, whereupon he disappeared from sight.

Clara waited, feeling a bit awkward to be witnessing the other woman’s raw emotion. When she sensed Savannah had collected herself a bit, she asked, quietly, ‘If I fast forward, we can see when he left the house again.’ Clara skipped ahead until a tall figure in a long mac stood at the gate.

‘Who’s that?’ Savannah frowned. ‘Oh, hang on – it’s Carl Carrington. The Langley lawyer. How odd.’

But Dex didn’t seem to have let Carl in. He might have spoken to him on the intercom – impossible to hear, though, as a heavy downpour had begun. Carl posted something into the front letterbox, and left.

‘Very odd,’ Savannah repeated. ‘Carl never mentioned he was here.’

Clara skipped forwards until someone else was caught on camera – a figure in black, hood up, dark beanie hat on and face carefully angled away from the lens as they buzzed the gate.

‘Who is that?’ They both craned to see until Savannah sat back. ‘I don’t know.’ She was visibly upset.

‘If there’s audio,’ Clara fiddled with the app, ‘it might help us.’

She rewound to where the figure entered and, lo and behold, they could make out a low voice, tinny and echoey. Most likely male, though not definitely. Maybe a bit like the call Clara had received, she thought, absently.

‘Dex, I really, really need your help at Langley ’cos...’ the voice said, as behind the figure, a Range Rover went past, swooshing on the wet road, drowning out part of the sentence, ‘...in real trouble!’

‘Oh God.’ The blood drained from Savannah’s lovely face. ‘We’re watching Dex being lured to his death.’

CHAPTER 56

WEDNESDAY NIGHT

‘We need to check the police have this footage,’ Clara said. Both she and Savannah were bleary-eyed and yawning, by now. ‘But I’m so tired – I really do need to go home and sleep. I’m already struggling at work.’ She clapped a hand over her mouth. ‘I mean, not really, I’m just—’

‘Distracted.’ Savannah reached out to pat the same hand. ‘It’s okay, I get it. Whereas I’m bored senseless and lonely, and Ruth’s instructed me to stay away from work altogether. I’m bringing nothing but shame on the family, apparently.’ She gave another wide yawn. ‘And it’s hard to trust the police these days, isn’t it? So many scandals of their own.’

‘But we still need to tell them, surely – about the proxy account?’

‘They must know that, already.’ Savannah sounded firm. ‘They must have some idea of what’s going on, without us spoon-feeding them.’

‘You’d hope so. I was wondering, though, Savannah. Can I ask...’ Feeling awkward, Clara pushed on. ‘About Jackson – you remember I mentioned his military career to you, did you find out anything else?’

‘Apart from the size of his dick?’ Savannah grimaced. ‘I know my siblings will do anything to keep him at Langley – he’s such a big seller.’

‘Nothing else?’ Did Clara dare tell Savannah about the weird incident earlier at the hotel? But then, maybe Savannah would think it was perfectly normal.

‘Well...’ Savannah paused for a second. ‘I know he was a killing machine for the British army, and I know he’s fit – if a bit rough, from my one experience. That’s it, really.’ Savannah rubbed her stiff neck. ‘Listen, why don’t you stay here tonight? I’ve got two empty ensuite guest rooms and, to be honest, since Dex’s death...’ It seemed like that word still stuck in her craw. ‘Well, I’d welcome the company.’

‘Thanks. I’ll take you up on it.’ Exhausted, Clara was happy to stay at Savannah’s house, what with security guards outside and a comfy bed inside. For once, she wouldn’t have to worry about who might be lurking, as she had every night since Dex died.

She wouldn’t have to worry about the door being kicked in.

CHAPTER 57

THURSDAY MORNING

By the time Clara had flopped onto the all-white four-poster, she was too tired to appreciate the luxury of Savannah's opulent guest bedroom – the thick carpet, the palm-tree wallpaper; so tired, she didn't even bother getting fully undressed, immediately drifting into a deep sleep.

But around 6 a.m., something woke Clara from a dream about Violet and a raging sea below her. It was the insistent ring of her phone, Clara realised groggily, fumbling the thick-pile carpet to find it. By the time she'd picked up, though, the caller had rung off.

Dragging herself off the bed, Clara listened to the message as she splashed her face in the ensuite basin.

'Clara.' Her mum, sounding tinny and faraway and, above all else, frightened. 'Please call me back. It's Adam, he's in real trouble...' The rest of the message was indistinct – like a dalek from *Dr Who* talking.

'Shit.' Clara's stomach dropped. Still befuddled, she tried to call both Adam – but his phone was off – then her mum. This time the line to Tenerife just sounded like a whirlwind howling.

Why hadn't she rung him back, last night?

*

'Couldn't you sleep either?' Savannah, dressed in an expensive-looking peasant outfit, greeted Clara as she stumbled down the stairs, into a hallway big enough almost for her whole flat. 'I've been reading Dex's phone most of the night.'

'And?'

'Oh, nothing much.' Savannah had a bright smile on her face, but her eyes looked like pinholes in the snow. 'Big news - we're going to visit

Jackson in hospital right now, so we can find out what actually happened. I've got questions for him, myself.'

'I can't, sorry.' Clara sat at the bottom of the sweeping staircase, and tried to put her boots on, but she was all thumbs. 'I need to go – my brother's in trouble.'

'What kind of trouble?'

'I'm not sure.' Clara looked up at Savannah, feeling suddenly like a small child. 'But I need to find him. And honestly, I'm worried that he might have been under some kind of Jackson Rayne spell.'

'Oh dear,' Savannah said, and there was something forced about her voice, like she was articulating very carefully. 'Pop in with me to the hospital, and you can ask Jackson yourself.'

*

As the Mercedes slipped through the quiet, early morning streets, Clara kept trying Adam's number, but it just rang out.

'Try not to worry, darling.' Savannah had been carefully applying first nude lipstick and then gloss, over and again. It was freaking Clara out, making her wonder what Savannah's true feelings were for the writer. 'I've pulled a little string, so we'll get to see Jackson straight away.'

'Great.' Frankly, though, right now, Clara just wanted to know if Adam was okay. She wasn't at all keen on seeing Jackson, given their last meeting – but maybe there'd be a few more answers, at least. And Savannah was still a Langley, and the Langleys paid Clara's wages, so she thought it wise to acquiesce.

In the hospital, they were directed to a family-and-friends waiting room upstairs, where a sleek-looking doctor appeared. Hurrying out to hug him, Savannah talked quietly with him at the door.

‘Friend of yours?’ Clara raised a brow when Savannah returned.

‘Old boyfriend. Perfect in every way – ‘til he decided he preferred men. He says Jackson’s fine, and awake.’ Savannah’s silk blouse had slipped off a shoulder, revealing a bra strap. ‘He’s in a private room, this way. I’ll pop in and warm him up -’

Clara watched through the glass window of Jackson’s room as Savannah fussed over the author. He was sitting up in bed with a black eye, his left arm in a sling.

Suddenly, Clara felt strange: as if she was being excluded from something; something both Jackson and Savannah were in on. *You’re just being paranoid, Voss*, she told herself firmly, but her dad strolled into her mind: the fact he’d always told her to ‘trust no one but yourself, sweetheart’.

But with that same odd smile, Savannah beckoned her in.

*

The second Clara walked into the small private room, stomach churning, Jackson’s handsome face darkened.

‘What the hell?’ He glowered at Savannah. ‘Get her out of here, now!’

‘Darling, don’t be so rude!’ Savannah frowned. ‘Clara’s a friend of mine. We’ve been working together to understand this infernal List—’

‘I don’t care what you’ve been doing. I let Ruth persuade me she could do my edits, but she’s trouble.’ Jackson scowled at Clara. ‘And so’s her brother.’

‘My brother?’ Clara stared at him. ‘What do you mean?’ *Oh, good God*, this was not what she’d expected. ‘How do you know my brother?’

‘Who the hell do you think did this?’ Jackson held his arm up, then groaned loudly in pain. ‘Oh my God! Jesus, it’s agony.’

Not such a brave soldier now, Clara thought bitterly, as a pretty nurse rushed in.

‘Please.’ the nurse shooed the two women out. ‘Mr Rayne needs calm and rest. You can come back later, if the doctor says so.’

*

‘I don’t know what he’s on about.’ Clara’s face was burning, as a shocked-looking Savannah stared at her in the corridor. ‘Adam doesn’t own a gun. He’d never shoot someone...’ Her phone rang again, interrupting her stream of consciousness; this time, it was a London number. Clara picked up, if only to turn away from Savannah’s accusing gaze.

‘Hello?’ a desperate voice said. ‘Clara?’

‘Adam! What have you done?’

‘I haven’t done anything, I swear.’ he sounded so young. ‘But I’ve been arrested, Clara, and...’ He let out a kind of sob. ‘I’ve been in a cell all night.’

‘Oh, God. Where are you, now?’

‘At Charing Cross Police Station. They’re saying they think I shot that writer dude, that one from your company, but I didn’t, I swear down.’ He sounded just like the little boy she’d picked up and carried everywhere when they were young kids. ‘Don’t leave me here, Clara. They found a gun, but I don’t know anything about it, or what’s going on. I think someone’s set me up—’

‘Hold on, Ad.’ Clara was already running towards the doors. ‘Keep calm, okay? I’m coming. Just hold on.’

CHAPTER 58

THURSDAY MORNING

Savannah insisted on driving Clara to Charing Cross Police Station. Or rather, Danvers drove them there, while Savannah tried to work out what the hell was going on. She was not feeling good at all, despite her act; she'd spent an hour at dawn going through weird messages on the phone between Violet and Dex. Messages that said things like *'We need to tell her'*, and *'I can't do this alone,'* and *'I didn't mean you to get hurt.'*

Her heart felt like it was actually breaking, and she'd slipped her first Xanax down with her coffee before she got dressed.

On top of that, now she could see that Clara was really struggling – the young woman trying and failing to stop herself bursting into frightened, angry tears. The tears just made Savannah feel awkward, and unsure how to react: none of the Langleys being believers in big displays of emotion.

'Come on, darling,' she patted Clara's knee, 'be brave.'

But the thought that pulsed through Savannah's foggy head as the car drove to the police station was: what if this girl's brother had killed Dex, too? It had been a young man they'd seen on the video doorbell when they'd watched it last night. Along with Carl Carrington, whom she intended to call as soon as she'd dropped Clara off. What the hell had he been delivering to Dex?

In the hospital before he'd spotted Clara, Savannah had finally got an answer from Jackson about how he got through the security gate: 'Dex gave me the code, a while back,' he said. 'It's your birthday, isn't it?'

'I'm just wondering,' Savannah said slowly. 'I really hate to say it, but do you think that might have been your brother outside?'

'Outside, where?' Clara sniffed.

'My house, on Saturday night.'

‘Oh.’ Clara searched her pocket for a tissue. ‘No, I don’t. I don’t think Adam’s got anything to do with this. He’s got no reason to be involved.’

‘Right.’ With a small sigh, Savannah passed Clara a tissue from the silver box between the seats. ‘I mean, I do hope for both your sakes he doesn’t.’

‘Adam would never shoot anyone. I don’t think he’s ever held a gun in his life.’

Savannah saw the girl’s tears - of rage and frustration.

‘I really hope you’re right.’ She shook her head sadly. But even though Savannah had warmed to Clara, there was a huge part of her that wanted it to be the poor girl’s brother. Because if it was, the whole awful affair would all be over, this ridiculous List would be wrapped up and then Savannah could go back to sleep for as long as it took to start to forget all her pain.

Crucially, she could mourn Dex properly.

CHAPTER 59

THURSDAY MORNING

So many questions were whizzing round Clara's head, it was hard to think straight, but the main one now was: *why* on earth would Adam shoot, if he *had* done it?

And if he had, where the hell had her brother got a gun?

Savannah was clearly embarrassed by the thought it could be Adam, as well as pretty out of it, all of which made Clara desperate to leave the car. Whatever poor Adam had or hadn't done, the Voss family clearly didn't belong in Savannah's world.

The two women travelled the last mile to the police station in total silence.

*

As the car stopped, Savannah opened her little Chanel bag – seriously mismatched with peasant chic, Clara thought – and gave Clara her card, her hand trembling.

'If you need a lawyer, call me. I mean it, Clara.'

'Okay.' Clara imagined Savannah thought she really did, and also that she was so out of it, she'd forgotten Clara already had her number. 'Thanks,' she pocketed the card.

'I do hope it's all alright.' Savannah patted her knee. 'Good luck.'

'Thanks,' Clara repeated, meeting Savannah's glazed-looking eyes briefly. 'And to you.'

The end of a beautiful new friendship, Clara thought, traipsing up the stairs into the police station. Of course it was the end; she didn't belong in Savannah's world or even begin to understand the strange moral code of the super-rich. What was far more worrying to Clara was the fact she'd probably be out of a job now.

Still, perhaps she'd be better off behind a bar or in a shop, or a care-home like her mum; publishing was just too poisonous, too full of snakes, however much Clara loved her job and her books.

*

Clara was escorted to an interview room off a noisy corridor when she enquired about Adam.

'Wait here please,' the officer said tersely.

Clara stared at the wall, trying to breathe calmly as she waited, until without warning, the door opened and Adam was ushered in, hair on end, wearing a grey tracksuit. But to Clara's huge relief, he wasn't handcuffed.

'He's free to go.' The booking officer, a stocky woman with braids, was pleasant. 'No charges.'

'No charges?' Clara repeated dumbly. 'Are you sure?' She stood up to hug a tearful Adam, who fell against her gratefully. As she put her arms around him, he smelt of sweat and fear.

'Your alibi turned out sound, eh, Adam?' The woman shrugged. 'He wasn't anywhere near Portman Square at the time of the shooting. Go on.' She opened the door for them. 'Get on with the rest of your life.'

'But...' Clara frowned, holding onto Adam's hand like he might be taken away again. 'Why did you think he was involved in the first place?'

'I believe it was a false allegation.' The woman's face grew serious. 'I can't share any more information, but I do suggest you, sir—' she nodded at Adam, '—avoid characters like those you've been mixing with, in future.'

'What characters?' Clara demanded.

'No one.' Adam stared at his trainers.

‘The Men’s Rights group? And those internet demons, the Red Pillars.’ The woman pulled a face. ‘Unsavoury little lot, if you ask me. Pedalling toxic filth. Do better, Adam.’

‘Thanks.’ Clara herded a sheepish-looking Adam to the door, and into the corridor. The woman was escorting them out when Clara had another thought. ‘Is DS Addo here, by any chance?’

‘DS Addo?’ The expression on the officer’s face was unreadable, now. ‘He’s not based here, no.’

‘But you know him?’

There was a pause as the woman swiped them through the first internal door. ‘I believe he had some interest in your brother’s arrest, yes.’

‘Do you have a number for him?’

‘Just call the main switchboard.’ The woman opened the second door and ushered them out. ‘They can help, I’m sure.’

*

Clara took Adam to the nearest café on The Strand, and bought him tea and a big plate of bacon and eggs. No protein shakes or smoothies, here.

Once a bit of colour had returned to his face, Clara looked her brother dead in the face and said, ‘Right. You’ve got some explaining to do.’

‘Why?’ He looked sulky as he burst an egg’s yolk.

‘Are you having a laugh?’ Frustrated, Clara jabbed his forearm with one finger. ‘You’ve just been arrested for shooting a world-famous writer, though now, thank God, it seems like you didn’t do it.’

‘I didn’t,’ he protested. ‘I was still on a coach back from Brighton, ’cos I’d missed my train.’

‘Why were you in Brighton in the first place? You’ve been acting so shady recently, and I want to know why.’ Clara felt nostalgic for the sweet

little boy he'd been before this recent transformation. 'I mean, do you even know Jackson Rayne?'

'No.' Adam looked flustered again, ladling too much sugar into his tea.

'Adam! Don't bloody lie.'

'Okay, yes – but also no.' He sighed. 'I mean, it's complicated.'

'I'm all ears.'

'I thought he was cool, I told you that. I was following him online.'

Adam picked up the brown sauce. 'He has a kind of underground group, linked to The Red Pillars.'

'What kind of group?'

'The Rain Effect. It's like, about how to pull, get bigger muscles, make money.' He flushed. 'I think you know the type of thing. Then he DMed me.'

'Who did? Jackson Rayne?'

'Yeah. He said he liked my reels in the gym. We kind of... just bantered for a while.'

'What kind of while?'

'Like, a few weeks?' Adam squeezed sauce all over his bacon. 'But he said not to tell anyone, 'cos of his high profile. He sent me some signed books. And then, on Tuesday, he asked me to collect a package from an InPost locker in the West End the next day, and deliver it to an address in Brighton. He said it was, like, a matter of life and death.'

'What kind of package?' Clara stared at her brother. 'Is that why you were in Soho yesterday?'

'Yeah. And I just picked it up, I didn't open it, and got the train down to Brighton like he said. But then it turned out—' Adam flushed beetroot-red, '—it turned out it was actually a pistol.'

CHAPTER 60

THURSDAY AFTERNOON

Savannah arrived home from the station feeling tired, sick and fed up, partly with herself, now. Clara Voss' company had provided the closest thing to stress relief she'd had this week. If Clara's brother hadn't turned out to be crazy, they might've even become friends.

And Savannah could really use some friends, right now.

The fact that her housekeeper was the only person she spoke to some days wasn't a good thing, she was aware – however fond she was of the woman. And, given Maria was now out food shopping, Savannah had to make her own espresso, using the extortionate coffee machine Dex had loved. But after achieving a drip of water and a face-full of steam, Savannah resorted to a cup of instant, and returned to the doorbell footage on Dex's old phone.

Over the next half hour, Savannah watched herself come and go from her own house, trying her hardest to concentrate on details other than her appearance.

She saw Jackson arrive on Monday night and leave again an hour or so later, strolling down the drive, not a care in the world. She watched Maria take Kylie out for the world's shortest walk – three and a half minutes – the next day. She watched the guards come and go – bantering, drinking Maria's tea, throwing a ball for the big Alsatian on the front lawn. Her gardener would disapprove.

And then Savannah stopped the video in surprise, and rewound back to Tuesday night, around 7 p.m.

There was Jackson Rayne, at the gate – but she hadn't seen him that night, had she? He'd only been here once, since Dex died. A black taxi was

ticking on the street behind him, she could just about see, as the security guard she'd taken such a dislike to walked down and let him in. The two men stood, chatting for a bit, just inside the gate.

The video stuttered forwards to the next recorded clip, and Savannah watched, her jaw dropping, as Jackson got something out of his pocket and gave it to the man.

Something that looked suspiciously like a wad of cash.

*

Hands shaking, Savannah rang Jackson's mobile, but it went straight to voicemail.

'Did you pay the guard at my place to do something?' She thought about the writing on the mirror: ***SOMEONE IS WATCHING YOU***. 'And did Dex actually tell you the gate code?' She was so angry, she could barely get the words out. 'Was it you in the mask at my window, scaring the fuck out of me? Call me back immediately, or I'm calling the police.'

And then Savannah picked up Dex's phone, and began to re-read the messages between him and his assistant. Had they been sleeping together? It certainly sounded that way.

But how the hell was she going to find out what they meant, given both Violet and Dex were dead?

CHAPTER 61

THURSDAY AFTERNOON

When she'd read everything again, slept for a while and calmed down, Savannah rang Ruth, who'd just landed at Heathrow from New York.

'Did you hear?' Ruth sounded jubilant. 'I've just signed Tom Cruise's memoir. And my God, I have to say, he's gorgeous in real life, short or not.'

'I don't give a holy crap about Tom Cruise.' Normally, Savannah would have been pleasantly surprised to hear her sister (almost) admitting to fancying someone – but she had far more important things on her mind. 'When Langley signed Jackson Rayne,' Savannah demanded, 'why did we? I thought Dex discovered him almost literally on the battlefield, ' God knew how that could have actually been possible, but it was part of the Rayne myth. 'But I'm realising that's not true. What exactly did you know about him?'

'Nice to hear from you, too,' Ruth drawled. 'I've no idea how Dex found him. Why?'

'Because I've got an inkling Jackson might not be the great guy he's cracked up to be.'

There was a pregnant pause.

'Ruth?' Savannah's antennae went up. 'You still there?'

'I'll see what I can find out. Sorry, I've got another call coming in.' The line went dead.

'Christ's sake.' Savannah was positive Ruth had more information on Rayne than she was letting on; she usually did. Which meant she was lying about something.

Savannah thought for a second and then ordered an Uber, as Danvers was obviously busy, driving Ruth into town from Heathrow.

Langley HQ, she typed.

If it was the last thing she did, Savannah would ensure Ruth told her everything she knew about Jackson, and she wouldn't leave until she did.

CHAPTER 62

THURSDAY AFTERNOON

Adam was expected at the gym for his shift, so Clara walked him to the nearest Lime Bike for hire, and then she got the bus to Langley & Co. She just hoped Adam's employers wouldn't get wind of his arrest.

All Clara really wanted to do now was go home, get into bed and put the covers over her head – but she'd been scared her job might be in jeopardy since the episode with Rayne, at the Soho Vibes Hotel. It was all a bit Harvey Weinstein, but look how long that had gone on for – and for all the public outrage, #MeToo seemed to have died a death. Clara knew it was usual for women to be disbelieved, or dismissed – and she didn't bring in any sort of money for Langley. The bottom line was Clara was expendable – and Jackson Rayne wasn't.

So, Clara knew she had to go into the office, if only to defend herself from the implications of her brother being accused of trying to knock off one of their top authors.

But maybe Langley & Co. wouldn't know about Adam – except, Clara remembered suddenly, of course Savannah knew - and it was clear where her allegiance would lie. Plus, she'd shagged Jackson, so...

Standing on the tube platform, Clara chewed her thumbnail – a nasty habit she'd given up years ago – and checked her emails on her phone. The HR assistant had sent her a number for Mumtaz, Violet's flatmate.

'She says she'd be happy to hear from you. She's very sad.'

Clara texted Mumtaz, saying how sorry she was about Violet, and asking if she could meet for a drink.

'Today, if possible?'

*

At her desk, Clara found a note from IT.

'Call us when you get in. We've had to wipe your passwords, soz.'

She called, half hoping to get Phil, but a woman answered.

'Clara Voss? There was some sort of corruption on your network, so we've set you up with a new username for now, and a generic password,' the woman explained. 'I can come round and show you, if you like.'

'No, it's fine, thanks.' Feeling fuzzy-headed and anxious, robotically, Clara turned on the new computer, and was typing in her new details when a buzz of excitement spread through the office.

'Oh my God!' someone said.

'It's Jackson Rayne!' her neighbour shrieked. 'You'll never guess what...' The girl paused for dramatic effect.

'He's dead?' someone else asked.

'No, it's even worse than that!'

CHAPTER 63

THURSDAY AFTERNOON

DS Addo was less than genial, the second time he met Jackson Rayne.

Any shine from his fame, any excitement, had worn off. Addo knew his wife would be sad, as she was a fan, but it wouldn't matter if he got his man.

'We've reason to believe you shot yourself, Mr Rayne,' Addo said, giving the author his special Look. 'Or should I call you Mr Payne.' It wasn't a question.

'Why would I shoot myself?' Jackson whined. 'That would be stupid.'

'I agree. But obviously, to get yourself off the hook for Dex Harris' murder.'

'Dex Harris?' Jackson Rayne paled. 'He was my editor, a top bloke. I didn't kill him, I swear.'

'What a shame I don't believe you,' Addo said. 'Cuff him.' He turned away as the uniformed officers stepped forwards.

'But my arm...' Jackson moaned.

'Your arm?' Addo looked at the PC who was holding the handcuffs. 'No problem. Just cuff Mr Rayne with his other arm across his body, on his right side.'

CHAPTER 64

THURSDAY AFTERNOON

Savannah walked into the Langley building just as the news about Jackson's arrest went viral.

Avoiding meeting anyone's eye, she took the private lift straight up to Ruth's office where, unfortunately, Miles was also in situ.

'What the hell's going on?' Savannah demanded of her older siblings. 'They're saying Jackson killed Dex.'

'Looks that way.' At the Art Deco drinks cabinet, Miles uncorked the whisky decanter and poured himself a glass without offering his sisters anything. Standard, thought Savannah. 'New CCTV just turned up.'

'Really? Are the police here?'

'No,' Miles downed his whisky. 'A missing clip was downloaded, and it seems Rayne never left the building after your little... *assignment*. Or rather, he didn't leave Langley's until *after* the footage shows Dex Harris arriving.'

'Why?' Savannah slumped on the leather sofa, trying to compute what she'd just been told. 'Give me a drink too, please.'

'We don't know why, but it looks like he was going through all Dex's notes on his computer, among other things.' Ruth looked even more serious than usual. 'He was up in this office, too.'

'The police are on their way.' Miles poured Savannah the smallest whisky, his face sour. 'This is not good.'

'We can make it good.' Ruth was calm. 'Or rather, we *need* to.'

'But how?' Miles ran his hands through his newly thickened hair. 'It's a fucking car crash, optically. Murders, sex in the building, dead assistants, our second bestselling author shot and then arrested. And after Ruth's mess, last year—'

‘Shush.’ Ruth steepled her hands on the desk. ‘I’m thinking.’

‘You should never have got those girls to sign the fucking NDAs,’ Miles’s hair was on end now. ‘If that comes out now, we’re truly screwed.’

‘I seem to remember the NDAs were your bloody idea, Miles,’ Ruth shot back. ‘But you’re right, we should have cut Rayne loose. These bastards we cover for always come back to bite us.’

‘What NDAs?’ Savannah frowned.

‘Maude.’ Ignoring her, Ruth buzzed her assistant. ‘Get me Carl Carrington on the phone, immediately.’

‘I want to talk to Carl too, please,’ Savannah said. She’d been feeling bleary all morning, but this news was like a jab in the arm. ‘He was sniffing round my house on Saturday night, when Dex was still alive—’

‘He what?’ Ruth stared at Savannah.

‘Carl was there, and he never mentioned it. I want to know why.’

‘I might know why.’ For once, Miles actually looked uncomfortable.

‘Go on.’ Ruth and Savannah spoke in unison.

‘Dex was being blackmailed.’

‘And you’re only just telling us this now?’ Ruth’s eyes nearly popped out of her head. ‘Do the police know?’

‘Hang on, please.’ Savannah stood up and sat down again, so furious she didn’t know what to do with herself. ‘Blackmailed? But... what are the NDAs for? You knew Jackson was up to no good, is that what you mean? Are we talking sexual harassment type stuff?’

‘Fraid so.’ Miles smirked. ‘You were just one of many, little sister.’

‘Do you enjoy being an absolute arsehole, Miles?’ she snarled. ‘Are you saying Dex was in on this? Or...’ She stared at her brother’s new hairline.

‘God, are you saying he was guilty of harassment, too?’

‘Anything’s possible,’ Miles sat down. ‘I’ve said it before, Harris’ morals were dubious – as you know all too well.’

‘Dear God, you’re a wanker.’

‘Oh, Savannah, honestly,’ Ruth sighed. ‘Don’t rise to his bait.’

But Savannah was apoplectic. ‘How dare you keep this from me? And you, Ruth, how could you? Do Bella and Seb know?’

‘Seb does, obviously. Bella, well, when’s she ever around?’

‘We didn’t know who was blackmailing Dex, that’s the problem.’ Miles sighed. ‘He rang me from LA, a few nights before he was killed.’

‘So the police knew, but not the whole board?’ Ruth was icy.

‘I only told the police after his death. I suspect that’s why Dex came back here, that night.’ To Savannah’s huge surprise, Miles looked upset. ‘I am sorry he’s dead. I liked Dex, for all his faults.’

‘We all have faults, Miles,’ Ruth shook her head in sorrow. ‘We’re human.’

‘I want all the details of the NDAs, today or I’ll – I’ll go to the press myself.’ Savannah stalked out, meeting the frankly delighted gaze of Ruth’s assistant, Maude, sitting at her desk outside.

‘Well done,’ Maude breathed. ‘You tell ’em. Jackson Rayne one hundred per cent had it coming to him.’

‘Thank you.’ And for once, hot with anger and shame, Savannah meant it. She might have the morals of an alleycat herself occasionally, but predatory sexual behaviour, and forcing innocent young female employees to keep their mouths shut? Well, that was a step too far, even for Langley & Co.

Savannah had been propositioned one too many times by hideous older guys in her time to let this one go.

CHAPTER 65

THURSDAY AFTERNOON

All around her, the office was in uproar as a shaky Clara leant back in her chair.

It slowly began to sink in that if Jackson Rayne was the culprit behind the List, and he'd been caught and arrested, well, it meant the reign of terror must be finished. It meant that, at last, the nightmare was over, and she could start to sleep properly at night again.

Honestly, Clara could have wept all over again – and even more so when she spotted Phil a little while later, on the other side of the office. She hoped he'd pop over for a chat, but he just waved at her cheerily as he walked on to a Henrietta's desk. Clara watched as he fitted some kind of computer cable for the other editor, chatting and smiling. Flirting, maybe?

Clara's head was suddenly full of her ex Sam and his last infidelity, but she reminded herself that Phil wasn't Sam – thank goodness.

Five minutes later, a text arrived on her phone:

'Fancy round 2 of drinks later, no drippy Ishan this time? ☺x'

Clara's heart soared.

*

Clara had just had her third cuppa, trying to keep awake at her desk on *The Stalker* edits, when Ishan turned up, holding a slab of what looked like carrot cake.

'Hi,' he said, shyly. 'I thought you might need cheering up after that hullabaloo. All a bit shocking, isn't it?'

'Yeah.' Of course, Clara hadn't been totally shocked, but she didn't have the energy to explain that now. 'Thanks.' Clara took the plate he passed her. 'What did I do to deserve this?'

‘I just thought you looked like you were having a bad day.’ Ishan ruffled his hair and straightened a cuff on his sweater. Was it Clara’s imagination, or did he seem more anxious than normal? ‘I mean, all this Jackson Rayne stuff.’

‘Yeah, it’s crazy.’ Then she stared hard at him. ‘Is that what you meant about a bad day?’

‘Well, I really meant, like, about your brother?’

‘How did you know about Adam?’ Clara put the cake down and licked icing off her fingers, trying to stay calm. ‘Is it common knowledge?’

‘I’m not sure. I think Savannah told me.’ Ishan looked uncomfortable. ‘Sorry if she shouldn’t have. I don’t judge, though.’

He sidled off before Clara could ask him anything else – leaving her bubble of relief somewhat deflated.

CHAPTER 66

THURSDAY AFTERNOON

Savannah sat in her own private office on the second floor, considering everything that had happened this past week.

What secrets had both men kept from her? Dex had never mentioned blackmail. And why the hell would Jackson Rayne have murdered Dex, when Dex had done so much for him – single-handedly creating his writing career? And why had he stayed in the office after she'd gone to the penthouse? From her recollection, Jackson had gone down to the atrium.

But she guessed Jackson had death in him: that innate drive to see blood, to end life. With a shudder, Savannah rang her assistant, who was sitting outside her office, no doubt working on a spreadsheet of her expenses.

'Ish.' She gave him a little wave through the glass when he picked up the phone. 'I'm just catching up with myself. Only calls from Ruth.'

'No problem. It's good to see you back,' Ishan said. There was a pause. 'Savannah...'

'Yes?' she prompted as he trailed off again. Looking out at him, she could see he was bent awkwardly over the phone. 'Ish? What is it?'

'Sorry.' He gave a nervous laugh. 'Doesn't matter.'

'Okay. Oh, and I'd love a strong cup of coffee – if you've got time,' she added generously. 'A big one, please. Bit sleep deprived.'

'Sure.'

And more than a bit hungover, if she was honest, and over-medicated. It was a slippery slope, and she'd lost her footing. Savannah stood and closed the internal blinds onto the big open-plan office. Then she took her shoes off, clipped her hair back and switched her computer on. It was time

she got back to business: sitting around at home, pining for Dex, was driving her mad.

Gradually working through five hundred or so emails, she kept an eye on the online news, but there was nothing about Jackson Rayne yet, other than the initial headlines:

Fact, not fiction: World-famous author murders own editor!

Savannah was still waiting for a response from Jackson to her earlier messages, but she guessed he was otherwise engaged right now; or that his phone had been removed. She could wait: that was fine by her. And it didn't matter anyway, now.

Good riddance to bad rubbish.

And poor Clara would be so relieved about her brother.

*

Around four, Savannah sent Ish out for sushi, lay back on her office sofa and turned the TV on. Her neck was stiff and her shoulders sore, her eyes gritty with tiredness, but she felt safer here than she had done for days.

Now Rayne had been arrested, she reminded herself sternly, she was safe in general. Home could be a haven again.

But it would still be one without Dex.

She flicked through the TV channels to take her mind off Dex, coming across Sky's leading arts show.

'It seems that Jackson Rayne, the author much loved for creating the maverick Alaskan cop, Smoke Silva, has a career history that's been embellished, to say the least,' the white-haired presenter was telling his guest – a leading literary critic Dex had despised. 'Apparently, he never even served as a marine.'

‘The Army Reserve isn’t anywhere near a combat Afghan tour!’ the critic scoffed. ‘A lesson on map reading’s not the same as disarming an IUD, is it, or saving a mate from death!’

‘Indeed not. Neighbours say the Payne family, from Norfolk, were very insular. Apparently the menfolk were regular hunters, who met to shoot small prey like squirrels with air rifles...’

‘Lovely.’ Savannah rolled her eyes and turned the television off.

Clara had been right about the fake identity. But how the hell had Dex not picked up on any of this? She closed her eyes and thought of her beloved fiancé. ‘Dex, darling. What did you do?’

Her tragedy was that she’d never be able to ask him, of course.

But Dex’s tragedy was far worse: the fact he’d found out way too late that Jackson Rayne – in fact born plain Jeffrey Payne – was a monster.

‘Sorry to disturb.’ Ishan knocked at the door with her sushi. ‘Maude just messaged, saying could you meet Ruth downstairs in the First Vault?’

‘Really?’ Savannah was surprised. ‘Why?’

‘Not sure.’ He smiled. ‘Just said she’s got something to show you.’

‘Okay.’ Savannah shrugged, putting the sushi down. ‘Thanks.’

Slipping her shoes back on, she thought, *maybe I was right all along. Maybe this all started down there, after all.*

Hurrying down the fire-escape stairs to the back entrance to the cellars, most of all, Savannah couldn’t wait to see the look on her sister’s face.

CHAPTER 67

THURSDAY AFTERNOON

At four, Clara had an editorial meeting with her whole team, in the small conference room. Given the news, Clara guessed her job was safe; she obviously hadn't been the first woman Rayne harassed.

When she returned to her desk at five, there was a Post-It note stuck to her computer screen.

'Please meet Savanna in the Secret Library 5.15, Ish x'

Clara was surprised – and also kind of excited. The Secret Library was one of the most exclusive Langley & Co. rooms. She'd only seen it once before, on her induction tour last year. So perhaps this was it – her turn to properly join the great and the good of publishing.

She'd see Savannah, then hopefully meet up with Phil for that drink. Adam had texted to say things were okay at work – nothing had been mentioned about his arrest. Life was looking up.

*

As most of her colleagues were packing up to leave, Clara straightened her dress, checked her eyes for panda makeup, and took the stairs to the next floor. Hurrying along the long corridor to the Secret Library at the end, she knocked nervously – but the small room was empty when she entered.

That was cool with her, though; it gave her the chance to look around alone.

The room smelled delicious: of old leather books, like the public library Clara had spent half her childhood in, and the smell of it brought back strong memories. She saw the old oak desk designed to look like

Charles Dickens' workstation, and the beautiful Tiffany lamp on it. Staring up at the bookshelves that ran the length of the back wall, Clara brushed her hands over the books, and stopped at a beautiful edition of *Frankenstein*; the first classic she'd read last year, when she started educating herself better. Pulling it down, she flipped through its pages with reverence; if only she could edit something as brilliant, by an eighteen-year-old girl genius, she was thinking, when a scuffling came from somewhere nearby.

Clara almost dropped the book in fright. 'Hello?'

Probably just mice, she told herself. Or, knowing London, maybe a big rat – a sight Clara was well used to seeing between the bins on her council estate, or on the canal paths she sometimes cycled down. But the scuffling stopped as Clara put the book back. Still, her nerves ramped up; hopefully, Savannah would be there any second...

A weird knocking noise started – but Clara couldn't work out where it was coming from. Maybe it was the old building's pipes? Or... well, she didn't know what it was, but it was getting nearer. Clara's heart rate sped up as she hurried to the door, to check the corridor – empty.

Behind her, though, the knocking increased until Clara froze on the spot. Had someone just cried out, nearby?

'God's sake.' Unnerved, Clara felt like running back to the main office – but then the cry came again.

'Help!' she thought she heard the voice gasp, from very far away.

Be brave, Clara, she told herself. 'Hello?' She edged towards the old wooden door in the far corner; a cupboard, she presumed. 'Is someone there?' Bracing herself, with one hand on the doorknob, she wrenched it open.

CHAPTER 68

THURSDAY AFTERNOON

When Savannah arrived at the locked metal and glass doors to the old vaults, Ruth wasn't there.

But all the Langleys had access codes to each part of the building. Savannah could never remember them, of course, but there was a list on her phone, which Ish had installed for her, along with her own home codes, and Dex's passwords. Dex must have trusted her implicitly – he can't have been such a bad guy, then, surely?

She tapped in the vault number, and the electronic door slid open.

'Hello?' she called, walking in. She didn't mind this part of the cellars – the First Vault, as it was now called, because as well as glass doors, it had a proper lighting system. The entire subterranean level had been refurbished a few years ago – at huge expense, since the building was listed; moving the bones in the old graveyard turned out to be illegal. Now the company used the First Vault for events, like the recent launch of a historical horror about Anne Boleyn's headless ghost.

But Savannah wasn't sure she wanted to think about ghosts now, or what lay beyond the First Vault; a network of passageways and deeper cellars that led God knew where-

Without warning, a clanking noise began. Spinning round, the main door was sliding shut automatically behind her.

Before Savannah could slip through it, another noise filtered through, like a laugh – or a cry.

'Ruth?' Savannah edged towards the far passage. 'Is that you?'

'Help!' a faint cry came from somewhere.

'Hello?' Savannah thought it was ahead of her, or maybe above her?

But it was so echoey down here, it was hard to tell, the exposed brickwork

making every noise bounce. ‘Is someone there?’ She peered down the passageway on the far side of the First Vault, remembering getting locked in the Secret Library the other day. These passages must all link up – that’s why she’d asked Ruth to get Security to check them.

Now Savannah heard footsteps, and then, right at the end of the dim passageway, something moved.

Savannah screamed. Honestly, she was getting worse than her sister Bella – the type to believe in ‘spirits’, and pay for Tarot readings and that sort of rubbish. But right now Savannah, who prided herself in being tough, didn’t feel tough at all.

She clutched the wall for support, sure she’d just seen a figure moving away in the distant shadows – and from its size, it was most likely male.

CHAPTER 69

THURSDAY AFTERNOON

As Clara tore back the door, a bedraggled-looking woman in filthy clothes stood swaying, just visible in the dark passageway.

‘Oh my God.’ Clara’s mouth fell open in shock.

‘Clara,’ croaked the voice, and, for a second, Clara thought she was looking at a ghost.

‘Help me, please,’ Violet whispered, half-stepping, half-falling into the room, and Clara lunged to catch her as she toppled forwards.

‘Oh my days, Violet.’ Clara felt the slight weight of her good friend against her, the smell of mildew and old sweat; her bones protruding, her body shaking with cold. ‘You’re meant to be dead.’

CHAPTER 70

THURSDAY AFTERNOON

Savannah had two choices.

She could run back and open the electronic door, or go on.

She wasn't stupid, and she was phobic about the dark. She went backwards, back to the First Vault, and tapped in the number at the door.

Nothing happened. The keypad wasn't working – in fact, it looked like it had been disabled. She tried a few more times, more and more frustrated, but she couldn't get back out, and her phone had no signal, down here.

As terrified as she now felt, she was left with no other option: she had to try to find her way through the cellars. She was sure they'd connect somewhere to the entrance of the passageway that led to the Secret Library, where she'd been stuck briefly the other day. If she could find her way through the old tunnels to that passageway, she'd be able to get back upstairs via the library.

Something fluttered near her ear, and she muffled a shriek, burying her face in her hands. Why the hell had she thought it was a good idea to come down here alone? But Ishan had said Ruth was here...

Was Ruth here?

If it was Ish having a joke, and if it was him in the passageway, she'd be alright, though. He was hardly frightening, not really – he was just a scrawny little so-and-so.

Heart racing, Savannah swallowed hard. She wasn't going to be defeated again. Taking a massive breath to steady herself, she turned around and hurried back into the cellar.

CHAPTER 71

THURSDAY AFTERNOON

‘What the hell, Violet?’ Clara sat her trembling friend down in one of the armchairs of the Secret Library. ‘Are you okay? You scared me half to death.’

But Violet was mute, breathing heavily, her hands grimy, her nails ragged, clutching the chair arms to keep herself upright.

Trying to calm her own thoughts, Clara fetched her friend a shot of brandy from the drinks cabinet. ‘I thought you were dead – we all did. It’s been in the papers and everything.’

‘I thought I would be dead. I’ve *been* scared to death.’ Violet’s eyes were dark and huge, her greasy hair hanging limply round her pale face. ‘I’ve been hiding since Monday. I was terrified he was going to find me.’

‘But... they found your body?’

‘Where?’

‘Here, drink this.’ Clara passed Violet the glass. ‘At Beachy Head?’

‘Oh,’ Violet said absently. ‘Well, it wasn’t me.’ She put her glass down and rubbed her arms. ‘I mean, I was there, in Sussex, but I got away – and then I had to hide.’

‘Someone sent me a video, and it was awful.’ Clara sat down herself. ‘I thought someone had pushed you off the clifftop.’

‘Jackson Rayne lured me there.’ Violet’s eyes filled with tears. ‘He sent me weird messages, and then he filmed me on the clifftop, and it was only because someone came that I got away. I’m so cold and tired, Clara. I don’t think I’ll ever be warm again.’

‘So is that who were you hiding from?’ Clara peeled off her cardigan and gave it to her friend. ‘Jackson Rayne? But it’s okay, Violet, you’re safe now. He’s been arrested, today, for killing Dex.’

‘Dex? Jackson Rayne killed him?’ But Violet looked strangely absent, and Clara felt fear pierce her belly. ‘That man’s a monster, you know. I thought he was coming for me again. I thought my life was over.’ Violet let out a sob. ‘It’s been hell.’

‘Oh my God, Violet, I’m so sorry.’ Clara took her friend’s hand. ‘But I don’t understand any of it. Why did he kill Dex?’

‘I don’t know. I think it’s a long story, like, about the real Jackson, and who he really is. I think his history is all made up.’ Violet shut her eyes and breathed deeply.

‘Yeah, that’s starting to come out, now. His name’s not even Jackson; he wasn’t in the Marines. I guessed that, a few days ago.’

‘No surprise. I’ve been hiding down there for days and, honestly, I thought I’d never dare come out.’

‘Thank God I had a meeting here.’ Clara had forgotten all about Savannah; presumably, she’d be along in a minute. ‘Let’s get you somewhere warmer and safer. Do you think you need A & E?’

‘I don’t know. Clara?’ Violet put a cold little hand on Clara’s arm. ‘I’m so hungry, I feel really faint.’

‘Oh, of course.’ Clara felt foolish. ‘Sorry. There’s nothing to eat here, but... I can run up to the upstairs café, if it’s still open. Get you a sandwich or something?’

‘Anything at all.’ Violet’s little heart-shaped face was pathetically grateful. ‘You’re such a good friend, Clara. I can’t tell you how relieved I am to see you.’

‘Me too, mate, me too,’ Clara said with feeling, leaning in to hug Violet again, despite the musty smell. ‘I’m just so glad you’re okay. I can’t believe it, really. Everything’s going to be alright.’

CHAPTER 72

THURSDAY AFTERNOON

Savannah had almost lost her mind, along with a shoe and a diamond earring, by the time she found the entrance to the passageway that led to the Secret Library.

Using her iPhone torch – the only thing the device was good for, down here, given the lack of reception – she'd also come across some crisp and recent sandwich wrappers, a couple of empty bottles of water, a half-burnt candle and two blankets squirrelled in the corner of one of the passages that had been blocked off.

Someone had definitely been sleeping here – for at least a day or two, she imagined.

Edging up the last passageway, swallowing the panic that kept surging through her, Savannah could hear her own breaths echoing in her ears until, suddenly, she thought she saw a chink of light – the door at the end – *thank God*.

But then, the world went dark.

'Hey,' she shouted in absolute terror, fighting the thing that had been thrown over her head. 'Get off me!' The next thing she knew, a crack of pain resounded through her skull, and she was falling, and then—

CHAPTER 73

THURSDAY AFTERNOON

Hurrying out to the lifts, Clara had got as far as the third floor when she realised she'd left her purse in her bag.

Rushing back downstairs and along the corridor, as she neared the Secret Library, she thought she heard voices. Savannah must have turned up.

'What the hell have you just done?' someone was hissing loudly. 'You're just making it worse. Is she alive?'

'She's breathing. I just panicked. This isn't what I signed up for,' an angry male voice replied, almost shouting. 'This is all mental – you're mental. Right from the stupid bloody dummy. And I never agreed to kill anyone—'

'You didn't kill anyone,' the female voice replied calmly. 'And it was his just deserts.'

'No, it wasn't. It was properly fucked up. You never said anything about murder when you asked me to help you.'

'You didn't, though, did you? I did it.'

'But you never said—'

'Violet?' Clara opened the door in shock. 'What's going on?'

'Oh, this is just fucking great.' The man in the corner of the room threw his hands up in fury. 'And now what, Violet, eh? Soon, the whole world will know—'

'Phil?' Clara couldn't take it all in. 'What are you doing here?'

'Oh Phil, you've really blown it, now.' Violet sighed.

'Blown what?' Clara stammered.

'You know Phil, don't you, and I think you quite like him? Well, dear Phil's my friend and accomplice.' Violet gave a strange laugh, and Clara

looked at her and thought, *she looks deranged!* 'He's helped me, the past few months. His tech know-how has been invaluable.'

'Helped you *what*, though?' Clara stared at her best friend at Langley & Co. 'What did you do?'

'Helped me work out my revenge.'

'Violet, you're an absolute wack-job.' Phil stormed past Clara, his cute face furious. Then he turned back to Clara. 'This was fuck all to do with me, okay? She said she needed some IT help, with the CCTV and all that, and that was all I did, because she told me why, and it was awful. I thought she was just going to read Dex the riot act. And sorry about that video – it was pretty sick. And sorry I corrupted the link. You didn't deserve it.' His eyes were almost black with fear. 'You seem alright, despite what Violet said.'

'A ringing endorsement,' Violet murmured. 'Put it on a front cover.'

'What did she say?' Clara could barely get her words out.

'That you're a traitor.'

As Phil left, banging the door behind him, Clara and Violet faced each other in the small room. The colour was starting to return to Violet's pale face again as she stood up, clearly much stronger than Clara had thought, and for all her dishevelled appearance, she'd started to look more normal, for a moment. Or she would, if she didn't also look crazed.

'A traitor? Please, tell me what's going on?' Clara whispered. 'What did he mean about killing people?'

'I did it. I killed Dex.' Violet leaned against the nearest chair. 'I didn't mean to, but I did. I didn't really mean any of it to happen, but it just kept on going.'

CHAPTER 74

THURSDAY AFTERNOON

Savannah had disappeared down to meet Ruth, and Ishan was at his desk, working on his own sci-fi novel, about the cousins of the Klingons, which he often did when most of his Langley colleagues had gone home. No one seemed to care, or notice him much, which was okay with him. It was so much warmer here than in his damp, freezing house-share, out in the sticks.

From the corner of his eye, Ishan spotted a figure hurrying, almost running, through the almost empty office.

‘Hey.’ Ish waved from the other side of the huge space. ‘Alright, mate? You look like you’re in a rush.’

The figure was heading towards Clara’s empty desk.

‘Yes, buddy.’ He raised a hand back. ‘Just left my phone, I think, when I was fixing Clara’s computer earlier.’

‘I’ll help you look.’ Ishan strolled over. ‘Need a break, anyway.’

‘No, don’t bother.’ Phil seemed on edge. ‘I’m sure it’s around here...’

A phone pinged.

‘Mate, it’s right there.’ Ishan pointed at Phil’s back pocket.

‘God, I’m losing it.’ Phil pulled the phone out and turned it off, but not before Ishan glimpsed the screen: eight missed calls from... *Violet*? ‘Thanks. Gotta go, or I’ll miss my gym session.’

‘No worries,’ Ishan said slowly. ‘See you.’

He watched Phil hurry away and, pushing his thick hair off his forehead, Ishan knew in his gut something was wrong. His eyes swept Clara’s desk, and settled on a Post-It note.

With a horrible realisation, he saw that he’d supposedly written it, telling Clara to meet ‘Savanna’ in the Secret Library. But he hadn’t – so why would anyone pretend to be him?

CHAPTER 75

THURSDAY AFTERNOON

‘Why?’ Clara croaked. ‘Why did you kill Dex? I thought you loved him?’

‘I did kind of love him, and I trusted him, which is why it hurt so bloody much when he let me down so badly.’ Violet’s eyes were dark with pain. ‘When I told him about Jackson, and he ignored me.’

‘About what? What did Jackson do?’

‘He assaulted me,’ Violet said flatly.

‘Oh my God, Vi, that’s terrible.’ Clara was horrified. But she was also unsurprised, given her recent encounter with the man. ‘When?’

‘At the Brighton Book Festival in the summer. We all went back to the Grand Hotel afterwards, and he kept buying Champagne, and I got stupidly drunk. And then he invited some of us up to his suite for another drink, and – oh, I don’t know. I was stupid, and naïve.’ But the way Violet spoke scared Clara even more – like she was reciting a shopping list.

‘No,’ said Clara sharply. ‘It’s not stupid or naïve to say yes to a drink with a colleague.’ She thought about Jackson’s attempt to entice her into a threesome yesterday, and about her brother Adam, and the disgusting online content she’d seen. ‘Rayne’s a sex pest – and a complete wanker.’

‘But I didn’t realise ’til I was in the room that it was just me and him.’ Violet’s eyes were kind of spaced-out and starey. She started to pace as she spoke. ‘And then he took advantage of how drunk I was, and he... tried to undress me, pull my skirt up, my tights down. He had me literally cornered in his room and... and when I refused, he tried to rape me. He said that’s what women like.’

‘Oh God, Violet,’ Clara exhaled. ‘I’m so sorry.’

‘So am I,’ said Violet dully. ‘He ripped my skirt and my tights, and I only got away because he was even drunker than me. But he ruined everything.’

‘But...’ Clara was trying to put the pieces together. ‘What happened with Dex, then?’

‘I told him.’ Violet paced back to the chair and sat. ‘I told him the week after about Jackson, and he didn’t do anything. I mean, Dex did say he was very sorry, and all that. Started to buy me stuff, took me for a few dinners to “explain” his position but, ultimately, he said to keep my mouth shut.’

‘But, why? I thought Dex was a good guy.’

‘Don’t defend him, Clara. Why d’you think? Jackson makes Langley & Co. literally millions with his shit books. Books he doesn’t even write.’ Violet’s face had gone very white again, a brilliant spot of colour on each cheekbone. ‘Who cares about some stupid little assistant—’ she spat, ‘—who can be replaced any time?’

‘But...’ Clara squirmed. ‘If it was you who wrote the List, well, why did you put me on it? I mean,’ she took a deep breath, ‘I didn’t let you down, did I?’

‘Yeah, you did.’ Violet was breathing very heavily now. Perhaps she was having a panic attack, Clara thought, her own stomach churning. ‘I tried to tell you that night in the club, but you didn’t even listen. You and your promotion after all that business with Ruth, and... you were leaving me behind.’

‘I don’t think I understood. I was very drunk that night.’ Clara winced at the memory. ‘I’m sorry, that’s a shit excuse. It was just after Sam, and everything – but I really didn’t mean to let you down.’ However sorry she was, it didn’t take away the fact that Violet had just literally admitted to

Dex's murder. Though how the hell she'd managed that alone, God only knew. Violet was tiny, and Dex was a tall, strong man.

'Did Phil help you kill Dex?'

'No.' Violet shrugged. 'It was all me. Phil just sorted the CCTV, switched it on and off, so I could get in and out of the building. Helped make it look like Jackson was still in the building, after he'd actually left. And he helped me get Dex back here, under false pretences.'

'Oh, God.' So, the young man in the hoodie who showed up on the Ring footage at Savannah's house – that must have been Phil. Not Adam – and even though Clara had known that deep down, it was still a relief to hear. But none of the rest of it was a relief. It was all just terrible.

'So, what did you do?' Clara stared at her friend. 'How the hell did you manage to kill Dex?'

'I wasn't even planning to kill him, not really. I just wanted to make him understand my pain. I set up the awards thing, and Phil helped, so that everyone would know Dex was almost as bad as Rayne. But then the organisers shut it all down, so it didn't work out like I wanted it to.'

'You set that dummy thing up?' Clara's brain wouldn't work fast enough to take this all in. 'Why?'

'I wanted everyone in publishing to know the truth. It was meant to be like a big reveal – but it backfired.' Violet's voice dropped, like she was a kind of robot. 'Then after, Phil went to Dex's house and told Dex I was desperate, and that I'd said I was going to hurt myself. That got Dex to the office. And believe me, I've wanted to end it all, since that bastard Rayne.'

'But Dex was twice your size?' Clara said. 'You're not big enough to have strung him up.'

‘I didn’t string him up.’ Violet looked exhausted now, her breathing still raspy as she stared around the room as if she was looking for something. ‘It was easier than I thought it would be.’

‘But, Violet—’ Clara began when, with one swift move, Violet swiped an object from the desk. Before Clara could react, she realised Violet was holding it against her own throat.

‘I did a terrible thing, and that’s that. I didn’t want to hurt anyone else. I even went to try and talk to Savannah, the next day. I felt so bad, I was going to confess, but she didn’t let me in, so—’

‘Violet.’ It was an ornate old paper cutter, Clara realised – part of the Dickens memorabilia. ‘Put that down, now, and don’t be stupid.’

‘But I *have* been stupid, and I’m not going to get away with this.’ Violet pushed the blade into her own neck, so the blood stopped around it; her flesh turned translucent where she pushed harder. ‘You know that, Clara.’

‘Please.’ Clara inched towards her friend. ‘Don’t be silly. We can work it out.’

‘We can’t.’ A bead of blood dripped down Violet’s neck. ‘Jackson will be freed, and Langley will keep publishing him, and I’ll go to jail for life. Look at this crappy world we live in. As long as they’re making money, they couldn’t care less that he’s a sexual predator.’

CHAPTER 76

THURSDAY AFTERNOON

The main door to the Secret Library burst open.

‘Ishan,’ Clara almost shouted. *Dear God*, was he another of Violet’s accomplices? Who round here could she actually trust?

‘Vi, you goose.’ Ishan held his arms out to Violet. ‘Don’t be daft – put that down.’

‘Oh, Ish, you are sweet.’ As Violet turned to look at Ishan, Clara rushed forwards and tried to knock the hand holding the paperknife down.

But Violet’s balance was off, so the two young women staggered against each other until they fell, tumbling to the floor – and the blade that Violet had held to her own neck found purchase as they both went down.

Slicing through the thin material of her dress, it slid into the flesh of Clara’s shoulder.

There was a flash of white-hot pain – and then Clara felt nothing.

CHAPTER 76

LAST SUNDAY, 2.35 A.M.

Dex got out of the black cab outside the Langley building. He swiped himself up to the first floor and hurried into his private office, to find his assistant Violet sitting at his desk, crying.

‘Violet.’ He rushed forwards. ‘What’s wrong?’

‘You know what’s wrong.’ She looked up at him and, for a second, he thought he saw hatred in her eyes. But it was so dark in here, he was probably mistaken. He’d taken a lot of migraine medication earlier, on top of jet lag, and then there was the whole blackmail thing and Carl’s visit. He was done in.

Violet stood up. ‘I’m so sad, Dex.’ There was a bottle of Jack Daniels on the desk, he realised absently, and two glasses, and she poured them both a drink. ‘I can’t get that awful night with Jackson out of my mind.’

‘I’m sorry.’ Dex took the glass she offered, and in the pit of his stomach, he felt real fear. ‘It’s been a balls-up, I know.’

The whole Jackson Rayne situation had been a nightmare since it started. When Violet told him about the hotel assault in the early summer, Dex had gone straight to Ruth and Miles Langley, and reported what she’d said.

What shocked him was that the Langleys both knew it wasn’t the first time Jackson Rayne had done it. It seemed that Ruth’s own assistant Maude had also accused Rayne of inappropriate texting; one of the HR staff had told Miles that Rayne had touched her up at the Christmas party; a young editor said he’d suggested an orgy, pressuring her to comply.

All these women had been paid off after signing non-disclosure agreements drafted by the Langley legal team. The young editor had gone

to Harper Collins soon after, but the HR girl was promoted, while Ruth had kept Maude carefully where she could hear her not breathing a word.

‘We’re not getting rid of Rayne,’ Miles had told Dex. ‘Not ’til he really oversteps.’

‘What’s “really” overstepping?’ Dex was angry. ‘He’s a predator.’

But Ruth had been away from work herself for a good while, and when she came back, she seemed non-committal. ‘Miles is dealing with this one.’ It was like she couldn’t bear to admit that Jackson Rayne was a monster.

And now, here was Violet in the middle of the night, obviously distraught. Her colleague Phil had come to the house just now, telling Dex she was suicidal, which had brought Dex rushing here.

Desperately uncomfortable, unsure how to approach this, he downed the Bourbon without thinking. ‘What can I do?’ He put the glass on the desk. ‘How can I make it better?’

‘It’s too late.’ Violet was cold. ‘I asked you before and you didn’t help.’

‘Too late?’ Dex was starting to feel very strange, like he couldn’t focus. ‘For what? Let me help you.’ He stumbled a bit, leaning on his desk for support. ‘God, sorry. I think I took too many pain pills.’ His tongue had gone numb.

‘Sit down, here.’ Violet got up and helped him to the chair she’d been sitting in, by the door.

Dex started to feel very spacey, like he wasn’t really here; like he was seeing everything through thick, dark glass. He sat in the chair and leaned his head back, and he felt Violet slip something round his neck – something floaty that became tighter.

Glancing down, Dex thought perhaps it was one of those scarves he’d bought everyone last Christmas. Maybe it was – but he was fast losing

control of his body and mind, and Violet was murmuring something and he couldn't really understand it.

'I'm sorry,' she said, softly, 'but someone has to pay.'

And there was a weird pressure on his throat, and some kind of pain, maybe, and he thought about Savannah and her beautiful green eyes, and how he'd finally found real love at his age, and how he'd actually felt a bit jealous, leaving her with Rayne tonight – so jealous, he might ask if she wanted to close the relationship, and just be together.

And then all was fading, and Dex's breath was hard to come by, and his neck was in a sort of agony, so painful, but he was there and not there; he couldn't really breathe, and everything was going into black...

CHAPTER 77

THURSDAY NIGHT

Clara lapsed in and out of consciousness on the floor of the Secret Library as everything began to blur together.

The paramedics arrived at the same time as the police, called by Ishan, and Violet made no attempt to get away, but sat in the armchair, sobbing.

The last thing Clara remembered hearing before she was taken out of the room was a female uniformed officer, radio on her shoulder, who began to read Violet her rights.

*

When Clara was carried out on an actual stretcher, Ishan had accompanied her in the ambulance.

‘You’re lucky the knife missed the main artery, or your friend would have been facing a murder charge,’ the first paramedic told Clara as he applied pressure to the bleed.

‘She’s facing one, anyway,’ Ishan piped up.

‘It was an accident,’ Clara kept croaking, but when the other paramedic slipped a syringe of morphine into her arm, she gave up resisting.

And, accident or not, Ish told her later that Violet also hadn’t resisted at all as she was handcuffed and taken into custody.

‘Best place for her,’ he said sagely, and Clara supposed she agreed.

*

Later, Clara was glad to hear that Jackson Rayne had been removed from the Chelsea and Westminster Hospital before she was rushed in by ambulance,

although she didn't know that until she'd been treated, and made comfortable. She had a private room that Langley & Co. would pay for – and Clara wasn't arguing with that.

About ten o'clock at night, DS Addo had arrived to see Clara.

'I'm very sorry this happened to you.' The policeman looked like his remorse was genuine. 'This whole case has been a complete misdirected mess.'

'I can't get my head round it all.' Clara was still woozy from the pain medication. 'How she managed to murder Dex?'

'By her account, she drugged Dex in his office, god knows with what. We're still waiting for the tox reports. He sat in a chair near his office door, and that allowed her to strangle him from behind, probably using garden wire and then that scarf.'

'And his suicide note?'

'Taken from his own notebooks, she says. She used the scarf to attach him to the back of his own door, and then she must have kicked the chair out somehow, making it look like suicide.'

'God. That's horribly clever.'

'Well, she is. And she's not shy of explaining herself, which is a good thing for us.' Addo sighed. 'Which reminds me, she's admitted she set your brother up.'

'Why, though?' Clara stared at him. 'What did Adam do to her?'

'I imagine it was to hurt you. She was very set on what she calls revenge.'

'And the terrible video of Violet on the cliffs that I got sent? And the body that they said was hers?' Clara thought about her frantic journey to Eastbourne, and how the police wouldn't let her see Violet. If they had, maybe this would have been clearer, sooner.

‘Her mate, the IT guy Phil Kirk, filmed the video with her, and sent it. I imagine the body is a Jane Doe. Happens all the time on Beachy Head, unfortunately. And we haven’t brought Kirk in yet,’ Addo ran a hand over tired eyes, ‘but it won’t be long.’

‘Was it Phil who hacked my phone and email? So I looked like I was making it up.’ Clara rested her head back against the pillow and closed her eyes. ‘Was it him making the weird calls too?’ She heard her own sigh. ‘It’s so awfully sad about Violet.’

‘She’s one very sick young lady,’ Addo said. ‘Something has gone horribly wrong for her, that’s clear.’

‘Well, yes.’ Something else was bothering Clara. ‘But... Jackson Rayne? Did Violet shoot him, too?’

‘Work in progress, but it seems like Rayne paid a manosphere acolyte to fake a shooting, as a sort of alibi.’ Addo wiped his face with a big hanky. ‘Very cunning. I suppose he is a crime writer.’

‘Is he, though?’ Clara thought about the reckless moped outside the pub, last night. None of it was sophisticated.

Addo didn’t catch her barbed reference. ‘We’ve seen the messages between Rayne and Violet. We know she was threatening to go to the press. Either that, or blackmail him. She was already blackmailing Dex Harris.’

‘That would have been preferable, wouldn’t it?’ Clara said sadly. ‘A bit of bad press coverage. Better than all this madness.’

‘I guess so. But Rayne was relying on the NDA he thought she’d signed – except I understand Violet had always refused. Anyway, an NDA isn’t really worth the paper it’s printed on.’ The policeman put his hanky away. ‘If only the poor innocents in the world who sign them all knew that.’

*

After DS Addo left, Ishan appeared at Clara's door. 'Okay to come in?'

'Course.' She might be drained by the drama of the last few days, but she was with-it enough to acknowledge her embarrassment.

'I brought you a hot chocolate,' he said.

'I don't deserve it.' She'd had a brief moment of doubting Ish, but all the time, it had been the cute IT guy, Phil. That'd teach her to have a crush.

'Maude just told me that Phil's flatmate works at Madame Tussauds,' Ish pushed his specs up his nose.

'So?' Clara was lost.

'So, that's how they got the dummy. Violet commissioned the flatmate to make a special model of Dex, as a supposed "present for her boss"'

'Oh, God.' Clara lay back for a second, considering all of this. 'You know, Ish, it all just makes me really sad. Violet so desperately wanted publishing to see Jackson's depravity, and Dex's complicity – she went to all those crazy lengths, the body at the awards, all of that - and no one really cared. Everyone just thought it was a kind of fun scandal.'

'That's corporate publishing for you,' Ish grimaced. 'It is sad.'

As Clara took a pensive sip of hot chocolate, her phone rang. "Lo?"

'Is that Clara? This is Mumtaz, Violet's flatmate. Sorry it's so late.'

'Thanks so much for calling back,' Clara said. 'Have you heard about Violet? She's alive.'

'Oh, my goodness.' The girl gasped. 'Her poor parents will be so relieved to hear that.'

'Her parents?' Clara nearly spilled her drink all over the bed. 'I thought they were both dead?'

'Oh no,' Mumtaz said. 'They live up near Harrogate, and they've been devastated. They'll be so glad to know she's okay.'

‘Great.’ Clara thought sadly that their happiness might not last all that long.

But as she hung up, she looked up and saw her own mum and brother arriving at her door, and she thanked God for her own life and luck.

Plus – Langley & Co. really owed her, now – and it was high time she used more things to her advantage.

Clara planned to take a leaf out of Savannah’s book from now on. Even if they couldn’t be friends.

CHAPTER 79

THURSDAY EVENING

In the Langley car, on the way home after being checked for concussion in hospital, Savannah laid her head back and closed her eyes, trying not to sink into despair.

She had a massive egg on her head, courtesy of some silly IT boy who'd been helping mad Violet, but she'd survived. And she was glad to hear the young editor Clara had been okay, despite getting herself stabbed.

But the relief Savannah briefly experienced, knowing she hadn't caused Dex's death, was meaningless; she'd still lost the love of her life.

And she was beyond furious her siblings had covered for Jackson Rayne – allowing him to create such a false identity, covered in glory.

Famous authors so often weren't what they pretended to be – an illusion often supported by a horribly flawed system that chose to propel a lucky few to the top, deserving or not. The most brilliant writers were also often the shy, diffident ones – the type not to make any fuss or hoopla about their talent – virtues that usually got them nowhere.

And, in Rayne's case, it transpired that Violet had rewritten a lot of his work – for which she'd have seen precisely no recompense, apart from a bit of gratitude and a few bottles of wine from Dex. No wonder she was angry – though it was still no reason to kill her boss.

As Danvers stopped the car outside her gates, Savannah leaned forwards.

'Danvers, may I ask you something?'

'Course, ma'am.'

'Please, just Savannah. But I wanted to know, what should I call you?'

The tips of the driver's ears went red. 'Danvers will do, ma'am – Savannah.'

‘But what’s your actual name?’

‘Derek,’ he confessed, almost childlike with pleasure.

‘Oh, I am sorry.’ Savannah opened her door. ‘Probably better to stick with Danvers, don’t you think?’

Despite her heavy heart, she sashayed back up the garden path to her beautiful house, passing the security patrol who were still there. It was the handsome American on duty tonight and, though she knew she could let him go safely, now, it was too tempting to keep him around.

Langley & Co. were picking up the bill anyway, so who cared?

*

When Savannah walked in, her housekeeper took her coat.

‘You have visitors, Mrs Savannah. I make them tea.’ Maria looked tired; she’d done a lot of over-time recently. ‘Can I get you a drink?’

‘Yes please, a huge glass of red.’ Even though she’d been warned not to drink by the doctor after her bump on the head, she needed to relax. ‘And one for you, too,’ Savannah was feeling super-generous for the second time today.

To her great surprise, both her sisters were in front of the sitting-room fire – her twin Bella rolling a joint, Ruth gazing at her phone in front of the gorgeous fake flames.

‘Savannah.’ Ruth stood. ‘I heard you were hurt?’

‘Savvi!’ Bella threw her arms around her sister, her mass of auburn curls and plaits tickling Savannah’s nose. She smelled of patchouli oil and old leather – from the terrible jerkin she wore. It really was such an abomination, Savannah had to avert her eyes. ‘You’re alive, praise be.’

‘God, what *do* you smell of, you hippy?’ Savannah wrinkled her nose. ‘It was just a small bang. Right up my street.’

'I'm not stopping.' Bella released her to light the joint. 'I've got a Greenpeace do in Oxford tomorrow, and then a silent Zen Souls weekend.'

Savannah could literally hear Ruth's eye-roll.

'But I just wanted to make sure you were alive.' Bella hugged her tight again, which was just weird. 'I was so worried.'

'As you can see,' Savannah said drily, 'I am.' And in her twin's embrace, Savannah thought with horror she might start crying, until a honking horn from outside broke the spell.

'Aha,' Bella stepped back. 'My kindred spirit's here.'

'So we can hear.' A monster truck had mounted the pavement outside the house, dub reggae throbbing into the night. 'Not very green, darling.' Savannah slumped on the sofa. 'Four tonnes of diesel.'

'Needs must, lovely. Omari's got so many vital tools for the oil protests. Don't get up.' Bella blew them both kisses from the door. 'Back next week, I promise. Namaste.'

'You need to make the next board meeting, dear.' Ruth stared Bella down. 'You've missed the last two.'

'No problem.' Bella floated past Maria, who was bringing the wine in.

'So this is a surprise, Ruth.' Savannah raised a brow as the front door banged. 'I'm not sure I've ever seen you here, have I?' Ruth didn't mix business with pleasure – and family was strictly the former. 'Thanks, Maria.'

'Lovely place you've got. And so the List is finished with?' Ruth said, clutching her mug of tea. 'And that lunatic little Violet's been arrested.'

'Apparently so.'

'What a relief.' Ruth's face was even more solemn than usual. 'They've still got to track her friend Phil down, I'm told. We must vet staff better.'

'But you've not come to chat about them, have you?'

'No.' Ruth looked at her feet. 'I've come to say I'm sorry.'

‘Good God.’ Savannah was amazed. ‘That’s another first. For what?’

‘For Dex.’ Ruth looked pained. ‘I should have listened to him. But Miles and Sebastian were so insistent that we just go the normal NDA route again. That poor little girl.’

‘Not such a poor little girl.’ Savannah clutched her wine. She’d definitely get back on the wagon tomorrow. ‘She orchestrated Dex’s death very cleverly.’ It made her feel sick to even say it.

‘It’s hideous – poor Dex. But her life is ruined now, too.’ Ruth stood up before Savannah could respond. ‘Why were you on her List, do you know?’

‘Not really. I think she just wanted a Langley to pay, and it could have been any of us. But...’ Savannah grimaced. ‘Maybe because she came here, and I wouldn’t see her? Which I hugely regretted, but... who knows. She’s obviously crazy.’

‘Well, I’m glad you survived.’ Ruth gave her a wintry smile. ‘By the way, while I’m here, I had a little thought about repackaging the Smoke Silva books. Not sure how yet – do you agree? I mean, obviously, we’re not publishing the memoir, given it’s all made up...’

‘Ruth.’ Savannah matched the coolness in her sister’s smile. ‘Bring it to the board meeting next month. I’m exhausted.’

‘Sure. But please, keep a lid on the Violet and Dex thing, okay? Until we’ve worked out our spin.’

‘Ah I *see*.’ Savannah eased her high heels off, one of which a Langley minion had retrieved from the secret tunnels for Savannah. ‘So you’re not sorry at all, Ruth. You’re just worried about the bloody brand.’

‘I *am* sorry.’ Ruth put her mug down. ‘Truly. Dex was a great editor and a good man. But family comes first, yes?’ She headed to the door.

‘Does it really?’ Savannah leaned back and then laughed as her big sister tripped over the little dog, trailed by the housekeeper and some carpet spray. ‘Mind where you step, darling. Kylie’s about as well-trained as Miles.’

‘Nasty little thing,’ Ruth could be heard muttering as she walked to the front door. She’d never liked animals.

Savannah watched her older sister walk down the path, her elegant back as rigid as ever, and get into the Langley car on the other side of the gate. Danvers must have waited for her when he dropped Savannah off.

With a gusty sigh, Savannah looked at the photo of Dex on the mantelpiece, and blew him a kiss. At least now, she could bury him, and she planned to arrange a funeral to end all funerals. Something a bit like Princess Diana’s; perhaps dear Elton would write a little tune. She could just see herself in a nice little black veil, like a stylish mafia widow.

Pleased with that thought, Savannah took a big swig of her red wine and sprayed herself liberally with Chanel no. 5; reapplied her red lipstick and tousled her hair artfully around her bruised head.

Then she leaned over and knocked on the window, giving the cute American guard a wave. He was leaning on the van, checking his phone.

‘Fancy a drink?’ Savannah mouthed when he looked up at her.

He raised his own eyebrow with a grin. ‘Sure thing.’

CHAPTER 80

AFTERWARDS

Both Savannah and Clara were informed the next day that Phil had been picked up at his mum's.

He'd sung like the proverbial canary when he was offered a deal, blaming Violet for tricking him, enticing him to help her create various fake online identities. One of which had been the fake Dex Harris address; the other was added to Jackson Rayne's own disgusting toxic manosphere world, the Rain Effect.

From these fake identities, the two had sent out the List.

*

DS Addo called Savannah to explain and apologise.

Almost the biggest relief for her was that the suicide note Dex had supposedly written had been doctored from his own edit notes for a new fantasy writer. Violet had pulled out a line or two from Dex's notebook, and photocopied it into a convincing note.

'We found the scream mask in Jackson's Audi,' DS Addo also informed Savannah; the same car she'd kept seeing on her street. Rayne had enjoyed 'pranking' the women he slept with, it seemed: 'keeping them in their place', all part of the ethos he promoted on his toxic digital profile, which was being splashed internet-wide.

It was clear now that the supposed author, a man who'd cleverly constructed his false identity, and who had in fact been born Jeffrey Payne, was not only a liar, but a sexual predator.

He was facing charges for his online library of sexual content of women he'd 'overpowered', and it seemed he'd shared his own footage of him and Savannah that she didn't even know he'd filmed.

But Savannah had started to forget about Jackson. Now, she was happily sleeping with Brad, the American security guard. He really did have the most enormous muscles and excellent bum and, one day at a time, he was helping her gradually come to terms with the terrible loss of Dex.

And this she could do without guilt, because one thing Savannah knew for sure about her beloved fiancé was that he wouldn't want her to be lonely without him.

EPILOGUE

Back at Langley & Co., after Dex's funeral, Ruth was sanguine about the whole affair.

'It's all very sad, but at least it shows Clara Voss was worth that pay-rise you were so against,' she told Miles. 'She's been superb in all this.'

'Really?' Her chinless brother was surprised. 'I thought we might fire her.'

'Absolutely not. And we need to keep her close, as our days of NDAs are over – they're so terribly noughties. Also, if Violet Childs goes to Broadmoor after the trial, where she belongs, just think about the memoir she could write.' Ruth buzzed her assistant Maude to bring them coffee. 'Clara could edit it – or ghost it, even. They were great mates, after all, even if Violet did stab her. Which makes it an even better story.'

'Hmm.' Miles was less confident. 'But we need to be seen to make amends. Do something publicly, showing we regret the whole Rayne affair.'

'Yes,' said Ruth, thoughtfully. 'How about free therapy for all affected? Big piece in the Sunday papers. Staff well-being is all the rage; shows we're bang on trend. We can discuss it at the next board meeting. Don't you agree, Maude, therapy for all our staff?'

Ruth's prim little assistant stood quietly, holding a tray with a cafetière and a silver jug of cream.

'Oh yes, Ruth,' Maude said, and only the most eagle-eyed of people would have noticed the murderous look in the assistant's eyes. 'Therapy for all could be just the ticket. Who knows what it might reveal?'

THE END ...

until THE THERAPIST...